LESSON 1

# 1. What Academic Writing Is

## Lesson overview

This lesson introduces academic writing, explaining its purpose, intended audience, and how it differs from everyday writing. Students will learn why these differences matter and how to adapt their writing style for academic contexts.

## Learning outcomes

- Identify the main purpose of academic writing
- Describe the typical audience for academic texts
- Compare academic writing with everyday writing
- Explain why tone and structure are important in academic work

## 1.1 What Is Academic Writing?

Academic writing is a special way of putting thoughts on paper that is used in schools, colleges, and research settings.

It is **not** the same as a text message to a friend or a casual blog post.

Instead, it follows rules that help the writer share ideas clearly, logically, and formally.

First, think of academic writing as a bridge. The bridge's job is to let a reader travel from one side (the writer's knowledge) to the other side (the reader's understanding). To make the crossing safe, the bridge must be strong, well■designed, and free of gaps. In writing, those "gaps" are vague words, unclear arguments, or informal slang. By removing them, the writer ensures that anyone who follows the bridge can reach the same conclusion without getting lost.

Why does this matter? In school and university, we are often asked to discuss research findings, explain a theory, or argue a point. If the writing is messy, the reader may misinterpret the idea, or the writer may lose credibility. Clear, formal writing shows that the author respects the reader and the subject, and it makes the information easier to evaluate and build upon.

> **Definition:** Academic writing is a formal style of communication that presents ideas, arguments, or research findings in a clear, logical, and evidence■based manner.

### *The Goal: Communicating Ideas Clearly and Formally*

- **Clarity** means the reader can understand exactly what the writer intends.
- Use precise words. Instead of saying "a lot of people," say "approximately 70 % of participants."
- Organize thoughts in a logical order: introduction -> method -> results -> discussion (the typical structure of a research paper).
- **Formality** means avoiding casual language, contractions, and personal anecdotes unless they are explicitly required.
- Replace "can't" with "cannot."
- Replace "I think" with "The evidence suggests."

Formality does not mean the writing has to be stiff or boring; it simply follows conventions that signal professionalism.

> **Note:** Formal language is not the same as complicated language. Use simple, exact words rather than overly fancy ones that might confuse the reader.

### *Everyday Comparison*

Imagine you are giving directions to a friend who has never been to your city. If you say, "Just go down the road, turn left at the big tree, then you'll see the place," your friend might get lost because "the big tree" could be ambiguous. In academic writing, you would give exact street names, distances, and landmarks: "Proceed south on Main Street for 1.2 km, turn left onto Oak Avenue, and continue for 300 m; the building is located at 45 Oak Avenue, on the right." The second set of directions is clearer and more reliable - just like academic writing aims to be.

### *Building the Concept Step by Step*

- **Step 1: Identify the main idea.** What is the central claim or finding you want to share? Write it in one sentence.
- **Step 2: Gather evidence.** This can be data, quotations from sources, or logical reasoning that supports the main idea.
- **Step 3: Organize the evidence.** Place the strongest evidence first, then follow with supporting details.
- **Step 4: Explain the connection.** Show how each piece of evidence backs up the main idea. Use linking words such as "therefore," "because," and "as a result."
- **Step 5: Conclude.** Summarize the main point and its significance, without introducing new information.

By following these steps, the writer creates a clear path for the reader, just like a well■marked trail in a forest.

> **In daily life:** Think of academic writing like a recipe. A recipe lists ingredients (evidence), steps (logic), and the final dish (conclusion). If the recipe is vague, the dish may turn out wrong. A precise recipe leads to a predictable, tasty result - just as precise academic writing leads to a clear, understandable argument.

### *Avoiding Common Pitfalls*

A frequent mistake is mixing informal speech with formal analysis. For example, writing "I'm pretty sure this works because it looks cool" is both informal ("I'm pretty sure," "looks cool") and unsupported. Academic writing requires evidence and a neutral tone.

> **Common mistake:** Using first■person pronouns ("I," "we") in disciplines that expect an objective voice, unless the assignment specifically allows them.

### *Summing Up*

Academic writing is a disciplined way of sharing knowledge. Its purpose is to make ideas easy to follow and to show respect for the reader and the scholarly community. By being clear, organized, and formal, writers help others understand, evaluate, and build upon their work. Remember to keep the bridge sturdy: choose precise words, follow a logical structure, and support every claim with evidence.

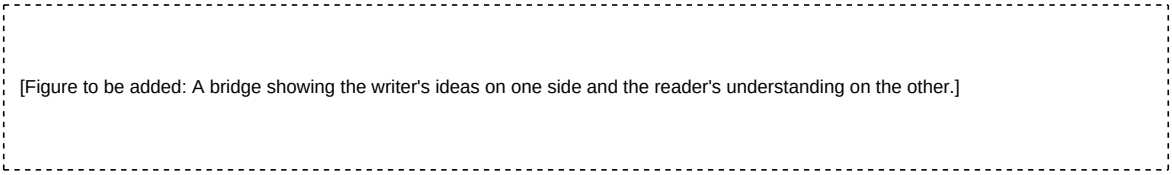



Figure 1.1. A bridge showing the writer's ideas on one side and the reader's understanding on the other.




Figure 1.2. Three typical audiences for school and early■university writing.

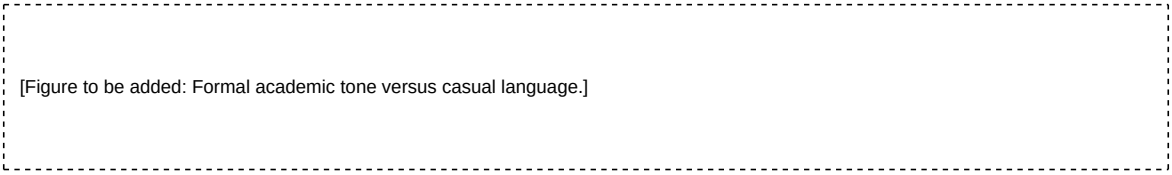



Figure 1.3. Formal academic tone versus casual language.




Figure 1.4. Academic Writing vs Everyday Writing




Figure 1.5. Key Parts of an Academic Piece




Figure 1.6. Simple Academic Writing Process

[Figure to be added: Main Purposes of Academic Writing]

Figure 1.7. Main Purposes of Academic Writing

## 1.2 Purpose of Academic Writing

Academic writing is a special kind of writing that you will see in school essays, research reports, and university papers. Its main job is not just to tell a story or share an opinion, but to **inform**, **argue**, or **analyze** something in a clear, logical way. Let's break down what each of those three purposes means and why they matter.

First, **inform** means giving the reader reliable facts or explanations about a topic. Imagine you are writing a report about how photosynthesis works. Your goal is to present the correct steps, the chemicals involved, and the importance of the process for plants and the whole planet. You are not trying to persuade anyone to think a certain way; you are simply delivering accurate information so the reader learns something new.

Second, **argue** means taking a position on a question and supporting it with evidence. Suppose you write an essay about whether school uniforms improve learning. You would state a clear claim - *"School uniforms do improve learning outcomes"* - and then provide data, studies, or expert opinions that back up that claim. The argument is built on logical reasoning: each piece of evidence should connect to the claim and help convince the reader that your view is reasonable.

Third, **analyze** means breaking a complex idea into smaller parts and examining how those parts work together. For example, when you write a literary analysis of Shakespeare's *Macbeth*, you look at characters, themes, and language, and you explain how each element contributes to the play's overall meaning. Analysis is like taking apart a machine to see how each gear moves the whole system.

> **Definition:** *Purpose* in academic writing refers to the specific goal - inform, argue, or analyze - that guides the whole piece. Knowing the purpose tells you what kind of evidence you need and how you should organize your ideas.

Why is it useful to keep these purposes separate? Because each purpose demands a different approach to evidence and reasoning. When you **inform**, you focus on presenting facts that are widely accepted and clearly cited. When you **argue**, you must choose evidence that supports one side of a debate and explain why that evidence is stronger than opposing evidence. When you **analyze**, you look for patterns, relationships, or underlying principles that explain a phenomenon.

Think of it like cooking. If you want to **inform**, you are simply showing the recipe step■by■step so anyone can follow it. If you want to **argue**, you might claim that a particular ingredient (say, olive oil) makes the dish healthier, and you would cite nutrition studies to prove it. If you want to **analyze**, you would examine how the flavors interact, why the texture changes at certain temperatures, and what that tells you about the cooking process. Each cooking goal changes how you write about the dish.

In academic writing, the evidence you use must be **relevant** (directly related to your point), **reliable** (coming from trustworthy sources), and **sufficient** (enough to support your claim). Logical reasoning connects the evidence to your main idea. A simple logical chain can be shown with a tiny formula:

\text{Claim} \;\rightarrow\; \text{Evidence} \;\rightarrow\; \text{Conclusion}

If any link is missing or weak, the whole argument can fall apart.

> **Note:** Always link each piece of evidence to the purpose of your writing. A fact that merely describes a topic is good for informing, but it does not automatically support an argument unless you explain its relevance.

Another important point is that academic writing avoids personal opinions that are not backed up. Saying "I think this is the best solution" is not enough. You must replace "I think" with a statement that can be checked, such as "According to the 2023 World Health Organization report, this solution reduces infection rates by 15 %." This shift from personal belief to documented evidence is what makes academic writing trustworthy.

> **In daily life:** When you explain a game's rules to a friend, you are **informing**. When you try to convince your friend to pick one team over another, you are **arguing**. When you break down why a particular strategy works, you are **analyzing**. Academic writing does the same things, just with more formal language and stricter evidence.

A common mistake is to mix these purposes without clear signals. For example, you might start a paragraph by stating a fact (inform) and then jump to a personal opinion (argue) without showing how the fact supports the opinion. Readers can become confused and may doubt the credibility of your work.

> **Common mistake:** Blending information and opinion without explicit connections. Always make the link between evidence and claim explicit.

Finally, remember that the purpose you choose shapes the entire structure of your paper. An informative piece often follows a logical order of topics (e.g., introduction -> background -> details -> summary). An argumentative essay usually follows a claim■evidence■counter■argument pattern. An analytical work often uses sections that each examine a different component of the whole.

> **Remember:** Identify the purpose early, gather appropriate evidence, and keep the logical chain clear. This will make your academic writing purposeful, convincing, and easy for the reader to follow.

## 1.3 Who Is the Audience?

Academic writing is never created in a vacuum; it is always written for someone else to read.

The "someone else" is called the **audience**. In most school and early■university work the audience falls into three broad groups: teachers, peers, and experts. Understanding who they are helps you decide what to explain, what language to use, and how much detail to give.

First, think of a teacher as a **coach** who knows the rules of the game but does not know the exact moves you will make in this assignment. The teacher expects you to show that you understand the topic, that you can follow the required format, and that you can argue your point clearly. Because the teacher already knows the basics of the subject, you do not need to define every single term, but you must still explain any *specialised* concept that is new to the class.

Second, your **peers** are the classmates who are learning the same material at roughly the same level as you. They may have missed a lecture or read a different textbook chapter, so they need a little more background than the teacher. When you write for peers, you should include brief reminders of key ideas, use examples that relate to everyday experiences, and avoid jargon that only a specialist would understand.

Third, **experts** are scholars, researchers, or professionals who have spent years studying the field. In most secondary■school essays you will not be writing directly to an expert, but you may be asked to cite expert opinions or research findings. If you do address an expert audience - perhaps in a short research report - you must be precise, use the correct terminology, and provide evidence for every claim. Experts will quickly notice any vague statements or unsupported assertions.

> **Definition:** *Audience* - the group of readers for whom a piece of writing is intended. Knowing the audience tells you what they already know and what they need to learn from your text.

Why does this matter? Imagine you are explaining how a bicycle works. If you assume the audience already knows what a *chain* is, you might skip that part and focus on the gear ratios. A beginner who has never seen a bicycle would be lost. Likewise, in academic writing, if you skip explanations that your audience does not yet know, they will not understand your argument and may mark your work down.

> **In daily life:** Think of a movie trailer. The trailer shows highlights that will interest the *target audience* - people who like action movies, for example. It does not explain every plot detail because the viewers already know the genre's conventions. Academic writing works the same way: you give just enough information to keep the reader engaged and informed.

When you write, ask yourself three simple questions:

- **What does the audience already know?**

List the concepts that are likely familiar (e.g., basic algebra for a math essay) and those that are not (e.g., a new theorem).

- **What does the audience need to learn?**

Identify the gaps in their knowledge that your paper must fill. This determines where you add definitions, examples, or data.

- **What tone is appropriate?**

Teachers expect a formal tone, peers accept a slightly conversational style, and experts require a highly technical tone.

> **Note:** *Tone* is the writer's attitude toward the subject and the audience, shown through word choice and sentence structure. A formal tone uses precise language and avoids slang; a conversational tone may include personal pronouns and simpler sentences.

A common mistake is to write as if everyone knows the same things. This leads to two problems:

- **Over■explaining** for an expert audience, which can make the text feel redundant and boring.
- **Under■explaining** for a peer or teacher audience, which leaves readers confused and unable to follow the argument.

> **Common mistake:** Assuming the audience has the same background knowledge as you. Always check the assignment brief for clues about the expected readership.

Finally, remember that academic writing is a dialogue. Even though you cannot hear the reader's questions directly, you can anticipate them by considering the audience's perspective. If you imagine a teacher asking, "Why is this source reliable?" or a peer wondering, "How does this example relate to the main idea?" you can answer those questions within your paper, making your writing clearer and more persuasive.

> **Remember:** Tailoring your writing to the audience is not an extra step; it is the core of effective academic communication. By matching the depth of explanation, the choice of vocabulary, and the overall tone to teachers, peers, or experts, you ensure that your ideas are understood and valued.

## 1.4 Differences from Everyday Writing

Academic writing sounds more formal than the messages you send to friends, but the differences are easy to see once you break them down. Let's look at three main areas: tone, structure, and use of evidence.

First, the **tone** of academic writing is polite, objective, and precise. "Objective" means the writer tries to stay neutral and does not let personal feelings dominate the text. For example, instead of writing *"I think this movie is the best ever!"* you would write *"The film demonstrates a high level of narrative cohesion, as evidenced by its consistent thematic development."* The word *evidence* here signals that the claim is backed up, not just a personal opinion.

> **Note:** Academic tone avoids slang, emojis, and contractions such as *can't* or *won't*. Write *cannot* and *will not* instead.

Why is this useful? A neutral tone lets readers focus on the ideas, not on how the writer feels. In a research paper, the goal is to convince other scholars that the argument is reliable, not to persuade them with charisma.

Second, the **structure** of academic writing follows a clear, logical order. Most essays start with an introduction that states the main question or thesis, followed by body paragraphs that each cover one sub■point, and end with a conclusion that summarises the findings. Each paragraph usually follows a pattern: topic sentence -> evidence -> explanation -> link to the next point.

Contrast this with a casual text message: you might jump straight to the point, add a joke, and end with a smiley face, all in one short line. There is no need for a formal opening or closing, and the order of ideas can be flexible.

> **In daily life:** A social■media post often begins with a hook ("Guess what happened today!"), then shares a story, and finishes with a call to action ("Like if you agree!"). Academic writing would replace the hook with a clear research question and the call to action with a statement of implications.

Third, **use of evidence** is the biggest divider. In everyday writing you might say *"Everyone knows that pizza is the best food."* No proof is required because the statement is meant to be light■hearted. In academic writing, every claim must be supported by data, citations, or logical reasoning. For instance:

\text{Claim} = \text{Observation} + \text{Citation}

If you argue that "students who study in groups perform better," you need to cite a study, give the statistical result (e.g., $p < 0.05$), and explain how the data support the claim. The citation itself follows a specific format (APA, MLA, Chicago, etc.) so that readers can locate the original source.

> **Common mistake:** Forgetting to add a citation after a factual statement. In academic work this is called *plagiarism* - using someone else's ideas without giving credit.

Why does evidence matter? It shows that the writer has done research and respects the reader's need to verify information. It also builds trust: if a reader can check the source, they are more likely to accept the argument.

Putting these ideas together, you can see how academic writing differs from everyday writing:

- **Tone** - neutral and formal vs. personal and informal.
- **Structure** - organized with introduction, body, conclusion vs. free■form.
- **Evidence** - always cited and explained vs. optional or omitted.

When you start writing an essay, ask yourself: *Am I using a neutral voice? Does each paragraph follow a clear pattern? Have I backed every claim with a source?* Answering "yes" to all three means you are on the right track toward academic writing.

## 1.5 Adapting Your Voice

When you write for a class, a journal, or any academic setting, the way you sound - your *voice* - needs to change. In everyday conversation you might say, "I think this movie was awesome because the story was super cool." In an academic paper the same idea becomes, "The film is noteworthy due to its compelling narrative structure." The shift is not about hiding your opinion; it is about presenting it in a way that other scholars can trust and evaluate.

**Why the shift matters**

Academic readers expect arguments that are based on evidence, not on personal feelings alone. A formal voice shows that you have considered the topic carefully, used reliable sources, and are ready to join a larger conversation. If you keep a casual tone, readers may think you are not serious or that your claims are just personal preferences.

**Step 1: Replace first■person pronouns**

In daily life we often say "I feel," "I think," or "I believe." In academic writing these are usually replaced by more neutral constructions.

- *Informal*: "I think the results are important."
- *Formal*: "The results are important because ..."

If you must keep a first■person reference (for example, in a reflective essay), limit it to a brief statement of your role: "In this study, the researcher examined ..."

**Step 2: Choose precise nouns and verbs**

Everyday speech loves vague words like "stuff," "things," or "really." Academic writing prefers specific terms.

- *Informal*: "The experiment showed a lot of interesting stuff."
- *Formal*: "The experiment revealed several significant patterns."

Notice the verb change from "showed" (a general verb) to "revealed" (more precise) and the noun change from "stuff" to "patterns."

**Step 3: Use "objective" adjectives and adverbs**

Words that express personal judgment (e.g., "awesome," "terrible," "cool") are replaced by adjectives that describe measurable qualities.

- *Informal*: "The policy is terrible because it hurts people."
- *Formal*: "The policy is problematic because it adversely affects vulnerable populations."

Here "problematic" and "adversely" are neutral terms that can be supported with data.

**Step 4: Cite evidence**

A casual claim can stand on its own, but an academic claim must be backed up.

- *Informal*: "Everyone knows that exercise is good for health."
- *Formal*: "Regular physical activity is associated with reduced risk of cardiovascular disease (Smith & Lee, 2020)."

The citation tells the reader where the information comes from, allowing verification.

> **Definition:** *Objective voice* - a writing style that presents information without personal bias, using evidence and neutral language.

**Step 5: Balance active and passive voice**

Both voices are useful, but academic writing often uses the passive form to keep the focus on the action or result rather than the actor.

- *Active*: "We measured the temperature every hour."
- *Passive*: "The temperature was measured every hour."

The passive sentence emphasizes the measurement itself, which is usually what matters in research.

**Step 6: Check sentence length and structure**

Everyday sentences can be short and fragmented. Academic sentences may be longer, linking ideas with conjunctions (and, however, therefore) and using commas to separate clauses.

- *Informal*: "The data is weird. It doesn't match the model."
- *Formal*: "The data are inconsistent with the model, suggesting that additional variables may be influencing the outcome."

**Step 7: Review for colloquialisms**

Colloquial expressions (e.g., "a lot of," "kind of," "stuff") should be replaced.

- *Informal*: "There's a lot of evidence that supports this."
- *Formal*: "Substantial evidence supports this conclusion."

> **Note:** Avoid *over■formalizing* - using overly complex words when a simpler term conveys the same meaning. Clarity is more important than sounding "fancy."

**Putting it all together**

Take a paragraph you wrote for a blog and rewrite it using the steps above. You will see the same ideas, but now they appear in a tone that academic readers expect.

> **In daily life:** When you explain a game rule to a friend, you might say, "You just have to try not to get caught." In a research paper about game theory, you would write, "Players aim to minimize the probability of detection while maximizing payoff."

> **Common mistake:** Adding too many citations in a row, like "(Smith, 2020; Jones, 2019; Lee, 2018)." Instead, combine sources when they support the same point: "Several studies (Smith, 2020; Jones, 2019; Lee, 2018) have demonstrated ..."

> **Remember:** The goal of adapting your voice is not to erase your personality, but to present your ideas in a way that other scholars can evaluate objectively. By following these small, concrete steps, you can move smoothly from a chatty, personal style to a clear, formal academic voice.

## 1.6 Key Take■aways

Academic writing is a special style that helps readers understand ideas that are based on research, evidence, or careful reasoning.

When you start any academic piece, keep these core ideas in mind. They will guide you from the first sentence to the final reference list.

> **Definition:** *Academic writing* is a formal way of communicating ideas that relies on evidence, clear structure, and an objective tone.

It is different from a text message or a personal blog because it aims to inform or persuade other scholars, not just to share feelings.

> **Note:** The main **purpose** of academic writing is to contribute to a conversation that already exists in a field of study.

You are not just stating an opinion; you are adding a piece of knowledge that others can check, test, or build upon. This purpose shapes every choice you make - what you include, how you organise it, and how you cite sources.

> **In daily life:** Think of academic writing like a recipe in a cookbook.

A recipe tells you exactly what ingredients (evidence) you need, the steps (structure) to follow, and the measurements (citations) so that anyone can recreate the dish (the argument). If you skip an ingredient or change the steps without explanation, the result may be confusing or even unsafe. The same is true for an essay: missing evidence or unclear logic makes the reader doubt your conclusions.

> **Common mistake:** Using a *personal* voice (e.g., "I think", "I feel") instead of an *objective* voice.

Academic writing expects you to let the evidence speak for itself. Replace "I think the results are important" with "The results suggest importance because ...". This shift shows that you are not relying on personal belief but on data that can be examined by anyone.

> **Remember:** Before you write, ask yourself three quick questions and turn the answers into a checklist:

- **Who is my audience?**
- Are they experts who know the jargon, or a broader group that needs more background?
- Adjust the level of detail and the amount of explanation accordingly.
- **What is my purpose?**
- Am I explaining a concept, arguing a position, or reporting research findings?
- Choose the appropriate structure: introduction -> literature review -> method -> results -> discussion for a research report; or problem -> analysis -> solution for an argumentative essay.
- **What evidence do I need?**
- List the main sources, data, or examples that will support each claim.
- Make sure every claim is backed by at least one piece of evidence; otherwise, mark it for revision.
- **How will I organise the piece?**
- Draft a simple outline with headings that reflect the logical flow.
- Typical headings: Introduction, Main Body (with sub■sections), Conclusion, References.
- **Is my tone objective and formal?**
- Replace casual words ("big", "cool") with precise terms ("significant", "noteworthy").
- Avoid contractions ("don't", "can't") and slang.
- **Have I cited everything correctly?**
- Every quotation, paraphrase, or data point must have a citation.
- Follow the required style guide (APA, MLA, Chicago, etc.) consistently.

When you finish a draft, run through this checklist once more. If any item is missing or unclear, revise that part before moving on. By treating the checklist like a safety net, you reduce the chance of common errors and produce work that meets the standards of academic writing.

In summary, academic writing is a disciplined, evidence■based way of communicating with a scholarly audience. Its purpose is to add reliable knowledge, its voice is objective, and its structure is clear. Use the checklist above each time you begin a new assignment, and you will build a strong foundation for every piece you write.

### Terminology at a glance

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Academic writing | A formal style of writing that relies on evidence, clear structure, and an objective tone to inform, argue, or analyse. |
| Audience | The readers of a text; in academic writing they are usually teachers, peers, or experts. |
| Tone | The attitude of the writer, which should be polite, objective, and precise in academic work. |
| Evidence | Facts, data, or citations that support a claim or argument. |
| Purpose | The main goal of the writing: to inform, argue, or analyse. |
| Voice | The way the writer sounds; in academic writing it is formal and avoids slang or personal bias. |
| Structure | The organized layout of a piece, typically including introduction, body, and conclusion with logical flow. |
| Citation | A reference to the source of information, allowing readers to verify and follow up on the evidence. |

### Practical application

Exercise 1.1:

Exercise 1.2:

Exercise 1.3:

Exercise 1.4:

Exercise 1.5:

Exercise 1.6:

### Checklist

- [ ] Identify the main purpose of academic writing
- [ ] Describe the typical audience for academic texts
- [ ] Compare academic writing with everyday writing
- [ ] Explain why tone and structure are important in academic work

LESSON 2

# 2. Planning an Essay

### Lesson overview

Students learn how to pick a suitable essay question, generate ideas through brainstorming, and turn those ideas into a clear outline. This step■by■step process prepares them to write focused, well■structured essays.

### Learning outcomes

- Select an appropriate essay question from a given prompt
- Generate a list of relevant ideas using brainstorming techniques
- Organise those ideas into a logical outline with introduction, body, and conclusion
- Explain how the outline guides the writing process

### 2.1 Understanding the Prompt

When you first see an essay prompt, treat it like a short set of instructions you would follow to bake a cake. You must read every word, notice the special "key words," and then decide exactly what the prompt is asking you to do before you start gathering ingredients (ideas).

> **Definition:** *Prompt* - the sentence or short paragraph given by the teacher that tells you the topic, the task, and any limits (such as word count or perspective).

The first step is **reading carefully**. Do not skim. Read the prompt at least twice. On the first read, just get the overall idea: what subject is being mentioned? On the second read, start underlining or highlighting the words that tell you *how* to respond. These are the key words.

> **Note:** Key words are usually verbs like *analyse*, *compare*, *argue*, *discuss*, *evaluate*, or *describe*. They tell you the *type* of essay you must write.

Why does this matter? Imagine you are given a recipe that says "mix the batter, then bake for 20 minutes." If you ignore the word "bake" and only stir, you will not end up with a cake. In the same way, if you miss the verb "evaluate," you might simply describe the topic instead of judging its strengths and weaknesses, and you will lose marks.

### *Spotting the verb*

- **Identify the action word.** Look for a verb that is not part of a noun phrase.

Example prompt: *"Discuss the impact of social media on teenage self■esteem."*

The verb is **discuss**.

- **Ask yourself what "discuss" means.** In academic writing, *discuss* usually means you should present different viewpoints, explain each, and then give your own balanced conclusion.

If the prompt uses *compare*, you must put two (or more) items side by side and point out similarities **and** differences. If it uses *analyse*, you break the topic into parts and examine each part in detail.

> **In daily life:** Think of "compare" like looking at two smartphones side by side: you note the camera quality, battery life, and price, then say which is better for a student.

### *Finding limits and scope*

Prompts often contain limits that tell you how far to go.

- **Time frame:** "in the 20th century" limits your discussion to that period.
- **Geographic area:** "in Europe" tells you to focus on European examples.
- **Number of items:** "two major causes" means you should not list three or more.

If you ignore these limits, you might write a long essay that wanders off topic, and the teacher will mark many sentences as irrelevant.

### *Turning the prompt into a question*

After you have highlighted the verb and any limits, rewrite the prompt as a clear question you can answer. This helps you see the exact task.

Prompt: *"Evaluate the effectiveness of renewable energy policies in Germany since 2000."*

Rewritten question: *"How effective have Germany's renewable energy policies been since the year 2000?"*

Now you have a single, answerable question. Every paragraph you write should help you answer this question.

> **Common mistake:** Turning a prompt into a statement instead of a question. For example, writing "Renewable energy policies in Germany are effective" is a claim, not a question, and it can lead you to jump straight to a conclusion without examining evidence.

### *Quick checklist for "Understanding the Prompt"*

- Read the prompt twice.
- Highlight the **verb** (action word).
- Highlight any **limits** (time, place, number).
- Rewrite the prompt as a question.
- Keep this question in front of you while you brainstorm.

When you follow these steps, you turn a vague instruction into a clear roadmap. The rest of the essay■planning process - brainstorming, grouping ideas, outlining - will be much smoother because you already know exactly what you need to answer.

Remember, the prompt is the compass; if you follow it correctly, you will never get lost in the writing process.

[Figure to be added: Shows an essay prompt written like a cake recipe with highlighted key words.]

Figure 2.1. Shows an essay prompt written like a cake recipe with highlighted key words.

[Figure to be added: A bucket being filled with ideas like water droplets.]

Figure 2.2. A bucket being filled with ideas like water droplets.

[Figure to be added: Outline shown as the skeleton of a building before walls are added.]

Figure 2.3. Outline shown as the skeleton of a building before walls are added.

[Figure to be added: Broad Topic vs. Specific Question]

Figure 2.4. Broad Topic vs. Specific Question

[Figure to be added: Steps to Create an Outline]

Figure 2.5. Steps to Create an Outline

[Figure to be added: Parts of an Essay Outline]

Figure 2.6. Parts of an Essay Outline

[Figure to be added: Using the Outline to Start Writing]

Figure 2.7. Using the Outline to Start Writing

## 2.2 Choosing a Question

When you first look at a prompt, it often gives you a *broad* topic - something like **"climate change"** or **"the impact of social media."**

A broad topic is like a huge garden: there are many different plants, paths, and corners. If you try to describe the whole garden in a short essay, you will run out of space and your writing will feel scattered.

The first step is to **narrow the garden down to one clear path** that you can walk from start to finish within the word limit. In essay terms, that means turning the broad topic into a **specific, manageable question** that you can answer completely in the time you have.

### *1. Look for the key words in the prompt*

Identify the words that tell you what the teacher wants you to do.

- **"Discuss," "evaluate," "compare,"** or **"explain"** are action words that indicate the type of answer expected.
- The **subject** (e.g., "climate change") tells you what you are writing about.

> **Definition:** *Action word* - a verb in the prompt that tells you the kind of response required (e.g., discuss, argue, analyse).

### *2. Ask yourself: "What part of this big topic am I most interested in, and what can I actually cover?"*

Write down a few possible angles. For the prompt *"Discuss the impact of social media on teenagers,"* you might note:

- Positive effects on communication
- Influence on mental health

- Role in education
- Effects on privacy

Each of these is a **sub■topic** - a smaller piece of the whole garden.

### *3. Turn a sub■topic into a question*

A good essay question is **specific** (it points to one clear focus) and **answerable** (you can provide evidence and a conclusion within the essay length).

Take the sub■topic *"influence on mental health."* A possible question could be:

> "How does daily use of Instagram affect the self■esteem of teenagers aged 13■16?"

Notice the question now includes:

- **What** - the effect (self■esteem)
- **How** - the mechanism (daily use)
- **Who** - the group (teenagers 13■16)

This level of detail tells you exactly what to research and write about.

> **In daily life:** Think of planning a road trip. Instead of saying "I'll drive across the whole country," you pick a specific route, like "I'll travel from Paris to Lyon in three days." The route is your focused question; the whole country is the broad topic.

### *4. Check that the question fits the essay length*

A quick way to test this is the **"three■sentence test."** Try to answer the question in three sentences:

- State the main point (your thesis).
- Give one piece of evidence or example.
- Explain why it matters.

If you can do this without running out of ideas, the question is likely **manageable**. If you need a fourth or fifth sentence just to explain the basics, the question may still be too wide.

> **Note:** A manageable question lets you give a clear answer, not a vague overview.

### *5. Refine the wording*

Make sure the question uses the same terminology as the prompt. If the prompt says "evaluate," your question should include a word like "effect" or "impact" that invites evaluation. Also, avoid vague words such as "some," "many," or "important" unless you define them later.

### *6. Write the final question on a separate line*

Having the question written clearly at the top of your notes helps you stay focused while you brainstorm and outline.

How does daily use of Instagram affect the self■esteem of teenagers aged 13■16?

### *7. Quick checklist before you move on*

- Does the question **focus on one main idea**?
- Is it **answerable** with the evidence you can find?
- Does it **match the action word** in the prompt?
- Can you **state a thesis** in one sentence that directly answers the question?

> **Common mistake:** Choosing a question that is still too broad, like "What are the effects of social media?" This forces you to cover too many points and you will run out of space.

### *8. Practice example*

Prompt: *"Analyse the reasons why renewable energy is important for the future."*

- Action word: **analyse** (break down into parts).
- Sub■topics: cost, environmental benefits, job creation, technology limits.
- Choose one: environmental benefits.
- Form question: *"What are the three main environmental benefits of solar power compared to coal in the United Kingdom?"*

Now you have a clear, focused question that you can answer with three main points, each supported by data.

By following these steps, you turn a wide■ranging prompt into a sharp, answerable question - just the right size for a well■structured essay.

## 2.3 Brainstorming Ideas

When you start to **brainstorm**, you are simply trying to get as many ideas as possible onto paper before you decide which ones are the best.

Think of it like filling a bucket with water: you keep pouring in until the bucket is full, then later you can pour out the water you don't need.

> **Definition:** *Brainstorming* - a quick, free■flowing way of generating many ideas, facts, or arguments without judging them at first.

### *1. Choose a simple tool*

You do not need fancy software; a plain sheet of paper, a notebook, or a blank document works fine. The three most common tools are:

- **Mind■map** - a diagram that starts with the main topic in the centre and branches out with related ideas.
- **List** - a straight■forward vertical or horizontal series of points.
- **Free writing** - writing continuously for a set time (e.g., five minutes) without stopping to edit.

### *2. Start with a mind■map*

- Write the essay prompt or the question you have chosen in the middle of the page.
- Draw a line outward and write the first word that comes to mind. This could be a **concept**, a **example**, or a **personal experience**.
- From each new word, draw another line and add another related idea. Keep going until you feel you have covered most angles.

Why this works: the visual layout shows connections you might not notice when you write a plain list. It also helps you see clusters of ideas that belong together.

> **In daily life:** A mind■map is like a subway map. The central station is the essay topic, and each line is a different train line leading to a destination (your supporting points).

### *3. Make a quick list*

If you prefer words over pictures, write a list:

- Write the prompt at the top.
- Under it, bullet■point every thought that pops up: facts you know, opinions, anecdotes, statistics, quotations, etc.
- Do not worry about order or relevance yet; just capture everything.

A list is especially useful when you have many short ideas that do not easily fit into a branching diagram.

### *4. Try free writing*

Set a timer for 5-7 minutes. Begin with a sentence that restates the prompt in your own words, then keep typing or writing until the timer stops. Do not edit, delete, or worry about spelling. The goal is to let your mind move freely.

Free writing often uncovers hidden arguments or personal connections you might miss when you force yourself to think in a structured way.

> **Note:** The purpose of free writing is *generation*, not *polishing*. Editing comes later.

### *5. Capture evidence and arguments*

While you are brainstorming, mark each idea with a simple code:

- **E** for evidence (statistics, research findings, quotations).
- **A** for argument (your own claim or interpretation).
- **P** for personal example (a story from your life).

Example entry in a list:

- E: 78 % of teenagers use social media for more than 3 hours daily (survey 2023).
- A: Heavy social■media use can reduce face■to■face communication skills.
- P: I noticed I stopped calling my friends after joining a new online game.

These codes help you later when you need to balance facts with your own voice.

### *6. Group similar ideas*

After you have a generous pool of ideas, look for patterns:

- Put all **evidence** together.

- Cluster **arguments** that support the same main point.
- Gather **personal examples** that illustrate each argument.

You can do this by drawing circles around related items in your mind■map, or by re■ordering your list into sections.

> **Common mistake:** Trying to pick the "best" idea while you are still brainstorming. This stops the flow of thoughts and may cause you to miss valuable material.

#### *7. Prioritise what matters most*

Not every idea will make it into the final essay. Ask yourself:

- Does this idea answer the prompt?
- Is there reliable evidence to back it up?
- Will it interest the reader?

Mark the strongest ideas with a star (*) or a number (1, 2, 3) to show priority. The lower■priority items can be saved for later essays or discarded.

#### *8. Keep the brainstorming record*

When you finish, keep the whole sheet. Even the ideas you discard may inspire a future paragraph or a different essay topic. Having a record also shows you the effort you put into planning, which can be useful for self■assessment.

> **Remember:** Brainstorming is a *quantity* exercise first, *quality* later. Fill the bucket, then sort the water.

### 2.4 Grouping and Prioritising Ideas

When you finish a quick brainstorm you will have a long list of words, phrases, and tiny sentences.

The next step is to **group** those items into sensible categories and then **prioritise** them - decide which groups and which ideas inside each group are the most useful for answering the essay prompt.

> **Definition:** *Grouping* means putting similar ideas together, like sorting a pile of mixed socks into pairs of the same colour.

> **Note:** *Prioritising* means ranking those groups (and the ideas inside them) from most important to least important for your argument.

#### *1. Look for natural themes*

Read each brainstormed item and ask yourself, "What does this point have in common with other points?"

Typical themes for an essay might be:

- **Causes** - reasons why something happened.
- **Effects** - results or consequences.
- **Examples** - specific cases that illustrate a point.
- **Counter■arguments** - ideas that oppose your main claim.

Write the name of each theme on a separate line and place the relevant ideas underneath it. If an idea could belong to two themes, put it under the one that fits best for the purpose of your essay.

> **In daily life:** Think of organising a music playlist. You might create sections for "rock", "pop", and "classical". Songs that sound like both rock and pop can go in the "rock" section if that's the mood you want to set for the playlist.

#### *2. Check each group for relevance*

Now ask: "Will this group help me answer the prompt directly?"

If the prompt asks you to *explain* the benefits of renewable energy, a group called **Historical background of coal mining** is probably not needed. Keep it only if it directly supports a point about why we need to change.

*Discard* any group that:

- Does not relate to the question.
- Repeats the same idea already covered elsewhere.
- Is too detailed for the length of the essay (you can save it for a longer paper).

#### *3. Rank the groups*

Write the groups in order of importance. The most crucial group should appear **first** in your essay because readers notice the opening paragraphs most strongly.

A simple way to rank is to ask:

- Does this group provide the main answer to the prompt?
- Does it contain evidence that is strong, recent, or especially convincing?
- Will it help me convince the reader of my thesis?

Place the strongest group at the top, the next strongest second, and so on.

#### *4. Prioritise ideas inside each group*

Within a group you may still have many points. Choose the **key ideas** that will form the body paragraphs.

Use the following checklist for each idea:

- **Relevance** - directly supports the paragraph's main claim.
- **Evidence** - you have a fact, statistic, or quotation to back it up.
- **Clarity** - it can be explained in one or two sentences without confusing the reader.

If an idea fails two of the three checks, consider dropping it or saving it for a later draft.

> **Common mistake:** Keeping every brainstormed point because "it might be useful later." This makes the outline crowded and the essay unfocused.

#### *5. Create a short "priority list"*

For each group write a bullet list of the **top three** ideas you will actually use. Anything beyond those three can be set aside. This list becomes a quick reference when you start writing, ensuring you never wander off■topic.

Example for a group called **Benefits of Solar Power**:

- Reduces greenhouse■gas emissions (supported by 2023 IPCC data).
- Lowers electricity bills for households (average 15 % saving).
- Creates jobs in installation and maintenance (U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2022).

#### *6. Review the whole picture*

Finally, step back and look at the ordered groups and their priority lists together. Ask yourself:

- Does the sequence flow logically from one idea to the next?
- Have I covered the prompt from all required angles?
- Is there a balance between **facts** (evidence) and **explanations** (analysis)?

If something feels out of place, move the whole group up or down, or replace an idea with a stronger one from the discarded list.

> **Remember:** Grouping and prioritising is not a one■time action. It is a short, iterative process that sharpens your focus before you even write a single sentence.

By sorting your brainstormed thoughts into clear categories, discarding the irrelevant, and highlighting the most powerful points, you build a solid foundation for a well■structured essay. The outline you create from this work will guide you smoothly from introduction to conclusion, keeping your writing on track and your argument persuasive.

## 2.5 Creating an Outline

When you have a list of ideas that you think belong in your essay, the next step is to **arrange them into a clear, logical shape**.

Think of the outline as the skeleton of a building: the skeleton tells you where the walls, doors and windows will go before you start putting bricks on top. In an essay the "walls" are the paragraphs, the "door" is the introduction that lets the reader in, and the "window" is the conclusion that lets the reader leave with a clear view of what you have proved.

#### *1. Start with the introduction and the thesis*

The introduction is the first paragraph of your essay. Its main job is to tell the reader three things:

- **What the topic is** - the subject you are writing about.
- **Why it matters** - a brief reason that shows the topic is worth reading.
- **Your thesis statement** - a single sentence that states the answer to the question you chose.

> **Definition:** *Thesis statement* - a concise claim that tells the reader exactly what you will argue or explain in the essay.

Write the thesis as a **complete sentence** that can stand on its own. For example, if the prompt asks you to discuss the benefits of recycling, a good thesis could be:

*"Recycling reduces waste, saves energy, and creates jobs, making it essential for a sustainable future."*

Notice how the thesis already hints at the three main points you will develop later.

### *2. Decide how many body paragraphs you need*

A typical short essay (about 500■800 words) works well with **three body paragraphs**, each covering one main point from the thesis. If your thesis lists four ideas, you can use four paragraphs, or you can combine two smaller ideas into one paragraph if they fit together naturally.

> **In daily life:** Think of a sandwich. The bread slices are the introduction and conclusion, and each filling layer is a body paragraph. Too many layers make the sandwich messy; just enough layers keep it tasty and easy to eat.

### *3. Fill each paragraph with a main point and supporting evidence*

For every body paragraph, follow this mini■structure:

- **Topic sentence** - a sentence that states the paragraph's main point (the first part of your thesis).
- **Explanation** - a few sentences that expand on the point, showing why it matters.
- **Evidence** - facts, statistics, quotations, or examples that prove the point.
- **Link** - a sentence that connects this paragraph to the next one, keeping the essay flowing.

You can write this as a simple formula:

\text{Paragraph} = \text{Topic sentence} + \text{Explanation} + \text{Evidence} + \text{Link}

### *4. Draft the conclusion*

The conclusion is the final paragraph. Its purpose is to **wrap up** the essay, not to introduce new ideas. A good conclusion repeats the thesis (in slightly different words) and briefly reminds the reader of the three main points. It may also end with a **call to action** or a thought■provoking question that shows why the discussion matters beyond the essay.

> **Note:** Do not add fresh evidence in the conclusion. The conclusion is a summary, not a new argument.

### *5. Put everything together in a visual outline*

Now write the outline in a list form. Use numbers or letters to show the hierarchy:

- **Introduction**

a. Hook (a surprising fact or question)

b. Brief background

c. **Thesis statement**

- **Body Paragraph 1** - First main point

a. Topic sentence

b. Explanation

c. Evidence (e.g., statistic, example)

d. Link to paragraph 2

- **Body Paragraph 2** - Second main point

a. Topic sentence

b. Explanation

c. Evidence

d. Link to paragraph 3

- **Body Paragraph 3** - Third main point

a. Topic sentence

b. Explanation

c. Evidence

d. Link to conclusion

- **Conclusion**

a. Restate thesis in new words

b. Summarise three main points

c. Closing thought or call to action

Seeing the essay laid out like this lets you check two things quickly:

- **Logical order** - Does each paragraph naturally lead to the next?
- **Balance** - Does each paragraph have roughly the same amount of space and evidence?

> **Common mistake:** Writing an outline that is just a random list of facts. An outline must show *how* the facts connect to the thesis, not merely that they exist.

#### *6. Test the outline before you start writing*

Read the outline aloud. If you can hear a smooth story from the first sentence to the last, you are ready. If any part feels abrupt or missing, add a link sentence or move a point to a different paragraph. This quick check saves time later, because you will not have to rearrange whole sections while you are already writing.

By turning your brainstormed ideas into this structured outline, you give yourself a clear roadmap. When you sit down to write, you will simply follow the map, filling in the sentences instead of figuring out where each idea belongs. This makes the writing process faster, clearer, and less stressful.

## 2.6 Checking the Outline

When you have finished a first draft of your outline, treat it like a map before you start a road■trip. A map shows you where you are going, the main stops, and the best order to visit them. If the map is wrong, you might drive around in circles or miss an important place. The same is true for an essay outline: it must clearly point to your thesis, and every point on the map should help you reach that destination.

**First step - make sure every point backs up the thesis**

The thesis is the single sentence that tells the reader what you are arguing. Look at each heading or bullet in your outline and ask, "Does this idea give evidence, explanation, or an example that supports the thesis?" If the answer is "no," the point does not belong here. You can either delete it or move it to a different essay where it fits better.

> **Note:** A strong outline contains only ideas that are directly linked to the thesis. Extra material weakens the argument and wastes space.

**Second step - check the logical flow**

Ideas should follow a natural order, just like steps in a recipe. Start with the simplest or most general point, then move to more detailed or specific evidence, and finish with a conclusion that ties everything together. Ask yourself:

- Does each paragraph lead smoothly to the next?
- Are there any abrupt jumps that might confuse the reader?

If you spot a jump, consider adding a transition sentence or re■ordering the points. For example, if you discuss "the impact of social media on friendships" before defining what "social media" means, the reader may be lost. Swap the order so the definition comes first.

> **In daily life:** Think of arranging books on a shelf. You would put the larger, heavier books at the bottom and the lighter ones on top so the stack stays stable. An essay works the same way: start with the "heavier" (broad) ideas and place the "lighter" (specific) ideas on top.

**Third step - verify length requirements**

Most assignments state a word count or a page limit. Your outline should give you a rough idea of whether you will meet that requirement. Estimate the length of each paragraph by multiplying the number of main points by an average word count (about 120■150 words per paragraph for a typical secondary■school essay). Add these estimates together:

Total words approx (Number of paragraphs) times 135

If the total is far below the minimum, you need more supporting points or deeper analysis. If it is far above the maximum, you must cut less essential ideas. Remember, quality beats quantity: a concise, well■supported essay is better than a long, rambling one.

> **Common mistake:** Adding many unrelated facts just to reach the word count. This makes the essay unfocused and can lower your grade.

**Fourth step - look for balance**

An essay should not have one huge paragraph and several tiny ones. Check that each main point has roughly the same amount of supporting detail. If one section is much longer, ask whether it is truly more important, or whether you have given too much space to a side issue. Adjust by either expanding shorter sections or trimming the long one.

**Fifth step - run a quick "self■question" test**

Read each heading aloud and answer these questions:

- Does this heading tell me exactly what the paragraph will discuss?
- Is the order of headings logical from the reader's perspective?
- Will the paragraph, as outlined, give enough evidence for the thesis?

If any answer is "no," rewrite that part of the outline until the answer is "yes." This short mental checklist catches hidden problems before you start writing.

> **Remember:** Checking the outline is not a one■time chore; it is a brief, systematic review that saves you time later. A clean, logical outline makes the actual writing stage flow smoothly, just like a well■planned route makes a road■trip enjoyable.

## 2.7 Using the Outline to Start Writing

When you have finished your outline, think of it as a **road map** for your essay.

A road map tells a driver where to turn, when to keep going straight, and where the journey ends.

Your outline does the same for your writing: it shows you the order of your ideas, the points you must cover in each paragraph, and the connections between them. Because the route is already drawn, you can start the first draft much more quickly and with less hesitation.

> **Definition:** *Outline* - a short, organized list of the main points and sub■points you plan to include in your essay, usually arranged in the same order as the final paragraphs.

### *1. Follow the outline step by step*

Begin with the first item on your outline, which is usually the **introduction**. Write a single sentence that restates the essay prompt in your own words, then add a **thesis statement** - a clear sentence that tells the reader what you will argue or explain. Because the outline already tells you that the introduction must contain these two parts, you can write them without stopping to think about structure.

> **In daily life:** Imagine you are assembling a piece of furniture with a picture of the finished product on the box. The picture (your outline) shows you exactly where each screw and board belongs, so you don't waste time guessing.

### *2. Turn each main point into a paragraph*

Your outline lists the main ideas as separate bullet points, for example:

- Reason 1: ...
- Reason 2: ...
- Reason 3: ...

Take the first bullet and turn it into a **topic sentence** - the first sentence of the paragraph that states the main idea. Then add a few **supporting sentences** that explain, give evidence, or provide examples. Because the outline already grouped the supporting ideas under each main point, you simply expand them one by one.

> **Note:** Keep each paragraph focused on a single main idea. If you find yourself adding a sentence that belongs to another bullet, move it to the appropriate paragraph later.

### *3. Use the sub■points as a checklist while you write*

Each sub■point in the outline is a piece of information you need to include. As you write, glance at the sub■points and ask yourself, "Did I mention this?" Tick it off mentally or with a pen. This checklist prevents you from forgetting important details and reduces the need to back■track later.

### *4. Connect paragraphs with transition words*

Your outline may already indicate the logical flow (e.g., "First," "Next," "Finally"). When you move from one paragraph to the next, insert a **transition word** or phrase that signals the shift. Examples are *however*, *therefore*, *in addition*, and *on the other hand*. These words act like signposts on a road, guiding the reader smoothly from one turn to the next.

### *5. Write the conclusion last, but follow the outline's guide*

The outline usually ends with a bullet that says "Conclusion: restate thesis, summarize main points, final thought." Follow this order exactly. Restating the thesis reminds the reader of your main argument, summarizing the points shows you have covered the road map, and a final thought (a recommendation, a question, or a broader implication) leaves a lasting impression.

> **Common mistake:** Trying to write the whole essay without looking back at the outline. This often leads to missing points or adding irrelevant material, which makes later revisions harder.

### *6. Keep the draft fluid; edit later*

Remember that the first draft does not have to be perfect. The purpose of using the outline is to get words on the page quickly, following a clear structure. You can always return later to improve wording, fix grammar, or tighten arguments. By the time you finish the draft, the outline will have served its purpose as a **road map**, and you will have a complete, organized essay ready for polishing.

> **Remember:** An outline is not a rigid script; it is a flexible guide. Follow its order, fill in the details, and you will find that the first draft becomes faster, smoother, and far less stressful.

## Terminology at a glance

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Prompt | The sentence or short paragraph given by the teacher that tells you the topic, task, and any limits. |
| Key words | Verbs like analyse, compare, argue, discuss, evaluate, or describe that indicate the type of essay required. |
| Brainstorming | A quick, free■flowing way of generating many ideas, facts, or arguments without judging them at first. |
| Grouping | Putting similar ideas together, like sorting mixed socks into pairs of the same colour. |
| Prioritising | Ranking groups and ideas from most to least important for answering the prompt. |
| Thesis statement | A single sentence that states the answer to the chosen question and guides the whole essay. |
| Outline | A short, organized list of main points and sub■points arranged in the order they will appear in the essay. |
| Introduction | The first paragraph that states the topic, why it matters, and presents the thesis. |

## Practical application

Exercise 2.1:

Exercise 2.2:

Exercise 2.3:

Exercise 2.4:

Exercise 2.5:

Exercise 2.6:

## Checklist

- [ ] Select an appropriate essay question from a given prompt
- [ ] Generate a list of relevant ideas using brainstorming techniques
- [ ] Organise those ideas into a logical outline with introduction, body, and conclusion
- [ ] Explain how the outline guides the writing process

LESSON 3

# 3. Writing a Strong Thesis

## Lesson overview

In this lesson students learn what a thesis statement is, how to test its strength, and where to place it in an essay introduction. They will practice crafting clear, focused theses for different essay topics.

## Learning outcomes

- Define a thesis statement and its purpose
- Evaluate a thesis for clarity and arguability
- Write a strong thesis for a given prompt
- Position the thesis correctly within an introduction

## 3.1 What Is a Thesis Statement?

A thesis statement is the single sentence that tells the reader **exactly** what your essay will argue or explain.

Think of it as the "road sign" for your whole piece of writing.

> **Definition:** *A thesis statement is one sentence that states the main argument or claim of the essay.*

Why does this matter? When a reader sees your essay, they need a quick clue about where the writing is headed. Without a clear thesis, the reader may wander through paragraphs that feel unrelated, and the writer may lose focus. The thesis gives both the writer and the reader a target to aim for.

### *Breaking the idea down*

- **Single sentence** - Not a paragraph, not a list. One complete sentence that can stand on its own.
- **Main argument or claim** - It is not a summary of facts; it is the point you are trying to convince the reader of.
- **Of the essay** - The thesis must cover the whole essay, not just one paragraph or one example.

> **Note:** *Argument* means a statement you can support with evidence. *Claim* is another word for the same idea.

### *Everyday comparison*

Imagine you are giving directions to a friend who wants to visit a new coffee shop.

- If you say, "The coffee shop is on Main Street, near the library, and it has good pastries," you have given several pieces of information, but no clear purpose.
- If you say, "Take Main Street east for two blocks, turn left at the library, and you'll find the coffee shop that serves the best croissants in town," you have given a single, focused instruction that tells your friend exactly what to do and why it matters.

The second sentence works like a thesis: it tells the listener the *main point* (the coffee shop has the best croissants) and points the way to get there (the directions). In an essay, the thesis does the same job - telling the reader the main point and guiding them through the supporting evidence.

### *How a thesis looks in a sentence*

Consider a short essay about school uniforms.

- **Weak version:** "School uniforms are a topic that many people discuss."
- **Strong version:** "School uniforms improve student focus and reduce bullying, so schools should adopt them universally."

The strong version is a single sentence that *states a claim* (uniforms improve focus and reduce bullying) and *indicates the writer's stance* (schools should adopt them).

> **Common mistake:** *Writing a thesis that is too broad or vague, such as "There are many reasons why X is important."* This does not give the reader a clear direction.

### *What the thesis does not include*

- **Facts alone:** "Students in the United States spend an average of 6.5 hours on homework each week." This is a fact, not a claim you are arguing for.
- **Questions:** "Should schools require uniforms?" A question invites discussion but does not state the writer's position.
- **Multiple sentences:** "Uniforms are popular. They are also controversial." Two sentences split the focus; combine them into one clear claim.

> **Remember:** *A thesis must be debatable.* If everyone already agrees with it, there is nothing to argue, and the essay loses purpose.

### *Putting it together*

When you start drafting an essay, ask yourself:

- **What am I trying to convince my reader of?**
- **Can I express that in one clear sentence?**
- **Does the sentence tell the reader the main point and hint at the supporting ideas?**

If the answer is "yes," you have a working thesis. You can later refine the wording, but the core idea should stay the same throughout the essay.

By treating the thesis as the essay's single■sentence "road sign," you give yourself a compass for planning paragraphs, selecting evidence, and staying on track from the first introduction to the final conclusion.

[Figure to be added: A road sign pointing to the main argument, showing how a thesis guides the essay.]

Figure 3.1. A road sign pointing to the main argument, showing how a thesis guides the essay.

[Figure to be added: A shaky bridge representing a weak thesis that cannot support the essay.]

Figure 3.2. A shaky bridge representing a weak thesis that cannot support the essay.

[Figure to be added: A checklist used to test a thesis for clarity, specificity, and debatable claim.]

Figure 3.3. A checklist used to test a thesis for clarity, specificity, and debatable claim.

[Figure to be added: Key Features of a Strong Thesis]

Figure 3.4. Key Features of a Strong Thesis

[Figure to be added: Strong vs. Weak Thesis]

Figure 3.5. Strong vs. Weak Thesis

[Figure to be added: Components of an Introduction]

Figure 3.6. Components of an Introduction

[Figure to be added: Testing Your Thesis Checklist]

Figure 3.7. Testing Your Thesis Checklist

[Figure to be added: Write■Test■Revise Thesis Activity]

Figure 3.8. Write■Test■Revise Thesis Activity

## 3.2 Characteristics of a Strong Thesis

A strong thesis is the backbone of any academic essay. Think of it as the **main claim** you are asking your reader to accept. If the thesis is weak, the whole paper can feel shaky, just like a house built on a wobbly foundation.

**Specificity** means the thesis tells exactly *what* you will discuss, not just a vague idea.

> **Definition:** *Specific* = clear, detailed, and limited to a manageable scope.

Instead of writing, "*Technology changes society*," a specific thesis would say, "*The rise of smartphones since 2007 has increased teenagers' average daily screen time by 30 % and reduced face■to■face conversation, which harms their social skills*." The latter tells the reader the exact topic (smartphones), the time frame (since 2007), the measurable effect (30 % increase), and the consequence (harmed social skills). Because it is specific, you can find evidence that directly supports each part.

**Arguability** means the thesis is a claim that someone could reasonably disagree with. If everyone already agrees with your statement, there is nothing to argue, and the essay becomes a summary rather than an argument.

> **Note:** A *claim* that invites debate is called *arguable*.

For example, "*Reading books is good*" is not arguable; most people accept it. Change it to, "*Reading fiction improves empathy more than reading non■fiction, because it forces readers to adopt perspectives different from their own*." Now a reader could say, "No, non■fiction can also build empathy," and you have a clear point to defend with evidence.

**Relevance to the prompt** means the thesis must answer the question that the assignment asks. If the prompt asks you to "*evaluate the impact of renewable energy on the economy*," a thesis that talks about "*the history of wind turbines*" would be off■topic.

> **In daily life:** Imagine a teacher asks you to write a report on *how to bake a cake*. If you start writing about *the history of ovens*, your work is interesting but does not answer the teacher's request. The same idea applies to academic prompts.

Putting these three qualities together, a strong thesis looks like a compact sentence that tells the reader:

- **What** you are discussing (the subject).
- **Why** it matters (the claim).
- **How** you will support it (the scope or angle).

You can test whether your thesis meets these criteria by asking yourself three simple questions:

- **Specific?** Can I point to at least two pieces of evidence that directly support this statement?
- **Arguable?** Could a classmate write a paragraph disagreeing with me?
- **Relevant?** Does this sentence answer every part of the assignment prompt?

If the answer to any question is "no," revise the thesis until the answer is "yes."

> **Common mistake:** *Making the thesis too broad.* A statement like "*Climate change is a problem*" is true but so general that you cannot cover it in a short essay. Narrow it down: "*Rising sea levels caused by climate change will displace 10 million coastal residents by 2050, requiring urgent investment in flood■resilient infrastructure*."

> **Remember:** A strong thesis is *specific, arguable, and on■topic*. Treat it like a compass: it points the direction of your entire essay and keeps you from wandering off course. When you write each paragraph, ask yourself, "Does this paragraph help prove my thesis?" If the answer is no, it probably belongs elsewhere or needs to be rewritten. This habit ensures that every part of your paper works together toward the same clear, defensible claim.

## 3.3 Testing Your Thesis

When you first write a thesis statement, it can feel like you have captured the whole idea of your essay in one sentence.

Before you move on, you need to **test** that sentence to make sure it really works. Think of testing like a quick "quality check" you do on a piece of fruit before you eat it. You look, you feel, you maybe even smell it, and then you decide if it's ready. The same idea applies to a

thesis: you examine it from a few angles and decide if it is ready to carry your whole paper.

> **Note:** *Testing* a thesis means asking yourself a short list of questions and answering them honestly. If any answer is "no," you revise the thesis until the answer becomes "yes."

Below is a simple checklist you can keep on a sticky note or in your notebook. Go through each item one by one.

- ■ Test - What to ask yourself
- 1■■ - **Does it answer the assignment question?**<br>Read the prompt again. Does your thesis give a direct answer, or is it just a topic?
- 2■■ - **Is it debatable?**<br>Can someone reasonably disagree with your claim? If everyone would agree, the statement is a fact, not a thesis.
- 3■■ - **Is it clear?**<br>Will a reader who knows nothing about your topic understand what you are saying?
- 4■■ - **Is it concise?**<br>Can you say the same thing in fewer words without losing meaning? Aim for one sentence, usually 20■30 words.
- 5■■ - **Does it preview the main points?**<br>Does it hint at the major arguments you will use, without listing them all?

### *Why each question matters*

- **Answering the question** is the foundation. Imagine a math problem that asks you to find the area of a circle. If you write "Circles are round," you have not answered the problem. Similarly, a thesis must directly respond to the writing prompt.
- **Debatability** turns a statement into an argument. A fact like "Water freezes at 0 degreesC" cannot be argued, so it does not give you a reason to write a paper. A debatable claim such as "Schools should start later in the morning" invites evidence and reasoning.
- **Clarity** prevents confusion. If you use a word like "cultural hegemony," first define it: *the dominance of one culture over others*. Without a brief definition, readers may get lost.
- **Conciseness** keeps the reader's attention. Long, winding theses act like a tangled rope; they are hard to follow. Cutting unnecessary words makes the thesis stronger, just like trimming excess branches makes a tree healthier.
- **Previewing main points** gives the reader a roadmap. You don't need to list every sub■argument, but a hint such as "because it improves health, boosts productivity, and reduces traffic accidents" tells the reader what to expect.

### *Quick self■test example*

Suppose your essay prompt is: *"Explain why renewable energy is essential for the future."*

A first draft thesis might be:

> "Renewable energy is good for the environment and the economy."

Run the checklist:

- **Answer?** - It says *why* renewable energy is good, but the prompt asks *why it is essential*. **No.**
- **Debatable?** - Someone could argue that renewable energy is not essential. **Yes.**
- **Clear?** - The terms "good for the environment" are clear, but "good for the economy" is vague. **Partial.**
- **Concise?** - It is short, but could be tighter. **Yes.**
- **Preview?** - It hints at two reasons but not enough detail. **Partial.**

After revising, you might write:

> "Renewable energy is essential for the future because it reduces greenhouse■gas emissions, creates sustainable jobs, and lowers long■term energy costs."

Now the checklist gives **yes** for all items.

> **In daily life:** Think of testing a thesis like checking a recipe before you start cooking. You make sure you have all the ingredients (answer the question), that the flavors will contrast (debate), that the steps are clear (clarity), that the list isn't too long (concise), and that the method hints at the final dish (preview).

### *How to use the checklist in practice*

- **Write your first draft** of the thesis. Don't worry about perfection.
- **Print or write the checklist** beside it.
- **Answer each question** with a simple "yes" or "no." If "no," underline the part of the thesis that needs work.
- **Revise** that part, then run the checklist again.

- **Repeat** until every answer is "yes."

> **Remember:** The goal isn't to make the checklist a chore; it's a safety net that catches weak statements before they become the backbone of a whole essay. When the checklist is all "yes," you have a strong, test■proved thesis ready to guide your writing.

## 3.4 Common Weak Thesis Mistakes

A weak thesis is like a shaky bridge - it may look solid at first, but it cannot hold the weight of your argument.

When a thesis is unclear, too general, or simply states a fact, readers will not know what you are trying to prove, and the whole essay can fall apart.

> **Common mistake:** *A statement of fact* - "The Earth orbits the Sun."

> **Why it is a mistake:** This sentence tells the reader something that is already known and cannot be argued for or against. A thesis must present a claim that you will support with evidence, not a simple truth.

Think of a courtroom. The prosecutor does not open with "The defendant was at the scene." That is already proven by the police report. Instead, the prosecutor says, "The defendant deliberately broke the law because..." The latter is a claim that needs proof. In academic writing, your thesis works the same way: it must be a claim, not a fact.

> **Note:** *Overly broad claims* - "Technology is changing the world."

> **Why it is a mistake:** This statement is so wide that it could apply to almost any essay about computers, phones, or the internet. It gives the reader no clear direction about what specific aspect you will discuss, nor does it set limits on the evidence you will use.

Imagine you are asked to describe a single tree in a forest. If you say, "Trees are important," you have said something true but too vague to be useful. A better description would focus on one tree's height, age, and role in the ecosystem. In a thesis, you need that same focus: pick a specific angle and stick to it.

> **In daily life:** *Vague language* - "Many people think that school is hard."

> **Why it is a mistake:** Words like "many," "some," or "important" are vague because they do not tell the reader exactly how many or how important. Without precise language, the reader cannot see the scope of your argument.

When you write "many people," the reader wonders: How many is many? Fifty percent? Ten percent? Precise language would replace "many" with a specific figure or a clear qualifier, such as "a majority of high■school students" or "approximately 70 % of surveyed students." This gives your thesis measurable weight.

Another frequent error is using **question form** as a thesis. For example: "Should schools ban smartphones?" A thesis should not be a question; it should be an answer to a question. Turning the question into a statement shows the position you will defend: "Schools should ban smartphones because they distract students and reduce academic performance." This converts the inquiry into a claim that can be supported with data.

> **Remember:** *A thesis must be debatable.*

> **Why it is useful:** If someone could easily agree with your statement without needing evidence, the thesis is not strong enough. A good thesis invites discussion: "Social media harms teenage mental health" can be argued with studies, surveys, and expert opinions, whereas "Social media exists" cannot.

### *Step■by■step checklist for spotting weak theses*

- **Is the sentence a fact?** If it can be verified with a dictionary or a textbook, rewrite it as a claim.
- **Is it too broad?** Look for words that cover an entire field (e.g., "culture," "technology," "education"). Narrow it to a specific aspect.
- **Does it use vague terms?** Replace "many," "some," "important," etc., with precise adjectives or numbers.
- **Is it a question?** Change the question into a clear statement of your position.
- **Can someone disagree?** If the answer is "yes," you have a debatable claim; if not, rework it.

### *Example transformation*

- **Weak:** "Reading books is good for students."
- **Strong:** "Reading literary fiction improves high■school students' empathy because it exposes them to diverse perspectives, as shown by a 2022 study where participants scored 15 % higher on empathy tests after a six■week reading program."

Notice how the strong version replaces the vague "good" with a specific benefit ("improves empathy"), adds a reason ("exposes them to diverse perspectives"), and points to evidence (the study). This is the kind of thesis that can guide an entire essay.

By avoiding statements of fact, overly broad claims, vague language, and question forms, you build a thesis that acts like a sturdy bridge, ready to carry the weight of your arguments safely to the conclusion.

## 3.5 Placing the Thesis in the Introduction

When you begin an essay, the first paragraph does three jobs: it **hooks** the reader, it gives just enough background, and it tells the reader exactly what you will argue.

The hook is a short, interesting fact, a question, or a vivid picture that makes the reader want to keep reading.

The background (sometimes called "context") explains any terms or ideas the reader needs to understand before they can follow your argument.

The thesis statement is the final piece of the puzzle - it tells the reader, in one clear sentence, the main point you will defend throughout the paper.

> **Definition:** *Thesis statement* - a single sentence that states the central claim or argument of your essay and previews the main points you will use to support it.

**Why the thesis belongs at the end of the introduction**

Think of the introductory paragraph as a short story. First you grab attention (the hook), then you set the scene (background), and finally you announce the purpose of the story (the thesis). Placing the thesis at the end lets the reader see the logical flow: *Because of this background, I am now ready to make this claim.* If the thesis appears too early, the reader may feel lost because they have not yet been given the information needed to understand why the claim matters.

**Everyday comparison**

Imagine you are giving directions to a friend who wants to meet you at a coffee shop. You might start with a friendly greeting (hook), then tell them which street the shop is on and how busy it usually is (background). Only after that do you say, "**Meet me at the corner table at 3 p.m.**" - that precise instruction is like the thesis. It comes last because the earlier details help your friend understand why that exact time and place are the best choice.

**How the three parts connect**

- **Hook** - grabs interest.
- **Background** - supplies needed facts or definitions.
- **Thesis** - states the argument and hints at the structure.

When you write, make sure each sentence leads naturally to the next. A smooth transition might look like this:

> "Every year, more than 8 million tons of plastic waste end up in the oceans (hook). This waste harms marine life, disrupts ecosystems, and eventually enters the human food chain (background). **Therefore, governments must adopt comprehensive plastic■reduction policies, including bans on single■use items, incentives for reusable packaging, and public education campaigns** (thesis)."

Notice how the thesis begins with a linking word ("Therefore") that ties it back to the problem described in the background.

> **Note:** The thesis should be specific, not vague. Instead of saying "*Plastic is bad*," say what should be done about it and how you will argue that point.

**Common mistake**

A frequent error is to place the thesis in the middle of the paragraph or to make it a question. Questions belong in the hook, not in the thesis. A thesis must be a statement, not a question, because it declares what you will prove.

> **Remember:** After you write the thesis, read the whole introductory paragraph aloud. Does the thesis feel like the natural conclusion of the ideas you just presented? If not, add a transition word or adjust the background information.

**Testing the placement**

- Remove the thesis sentence. Does the paragraph still make sense? It should feel incomplete, as if something important is missing.
- Move the thesis to the first sentence. Does the paragraph lose its logical build■up? It will likely feel abrupt.

When the thesis sits at the end, the paragraph flows from curiosity to understanding to a clear direction for the essay. This structure guides the reader smoothly into the body of your work, where you will develop each part of the thesis in detail.

## 3.6 Practice Activity: Write and Test Your Thesis

Imagine you have a **prompt** - a short question or statement that tells you what to write about.

For this activity you will:

- **Pick a prompt** from the list below.
- **Write a first■draft thesis** - one sentence that tells the reader exactly what you will argue.
- **Use the checklist** (the "Testing Your Thesis" list from the previous lesson) to see if your sentence is clear, specific, and debatable.
- **Revise** the thesis until it passes every item on the checklist.
- **Place the finished thesis** into a short introductory paragraph (about 4■5 sentences) that leads the reader into your essay.

> **Definition:** *Prompt* - a brief instruction or question that gives you a topic to write about.

> **In daily life:** Think of a prompt like a recipe card. The card tells you the main dish you need to make; your thesis is the exact list of ingredients and steps you will use to create that dish.

### *Step 1 - Choose a Prompt*

Select one of the following prompts. Write the number you choose at the top of your worksheet.

- **Technology** - "How does social media affect teenagers' sense of self■worth?"
- **Environment** - "Why should cities invest more in public bike lanes?"
- **Education** - "What are the benefits of project■based learning in high schools?"
- **Health** - "Should schools require daily physical■education classes for all students?"

### *Step 2 - Draft Your First Thesis*

Write **one sentence** that answers the prompt. It should tell the reader:

- **What** you are arguing (the main claim).
- **Why** it matters (the significance).

Example (for Prompt 2):

*"Public bike lanes improve city health, reduce traffic congestion, and encourage sustainable travel, so municipalities should allocate more funding to build them."*

Don't worry about perfection yet; just get your ideas on paper.

### *Step 3 - Test Your Thesis with the Checklist*

Look at each item and mark **Yes** or **No**. If you answer **No**, rewrite the thesis until the answer becomes **Yes**.

- Checklist item - Yes / No - How to fix it
- **Clear claim** - does the sentence state a specific position?
- **Debatable** - could someone reasonably disagree?
- **Specific** - are the main points (e.g., health, traffic, sustainability) named?
- **Focused** - does it cover only one main idea, not several unrelated topics?
- **Relevant to prompt** - does it answer the question asked?

> **Note:** A strong thesis never says "This essay will discuss...". Instead, it *states* the argument directly.

### *Step 4 - Revise Until It Passes*

Use the notes from the checklist to edit your sentence. Common ways to improve:

- Replace vague words like "good" or "important" with concrete nouns (e.g., "improved public health").
- Add a **why** clause that explains the significance ("because it lowers healthcare costs").
- Remove extra ideas that belong in later paragraphs.

Write the final version of your thesis below the checklist.

### *Step 5 - Write a Short Introductory Paragraph*

Now you will embed the thesis in a mini■introduction. Follow this simple structure:

- **Hook** - a surprising fact, question, or brief anecdote that grabs attention.
- **Context** - one or two sentences that give background information about the topic.
- **Thesis** - place your revised thesis sentence at the end of the paragraph.

Example (continuing Prompt 2):

*Hook:* "In Copenhagen, more than 40 % of commuters travel by bike, and traffic accidents have dropped by 30 % in the last decade."

*Context:* "Cities worldwide are looking for ways to make streets safer and reduce carbon emissions. One proven strategy is the creation of dedicated bike lanes."

*Thesis:* "Public bike lanes improve city health, reduce traffic congestion, and encourage sustainable travel, so municipalities should allocate more funding to build them."

Write your own paragraph below, using the same three■part pattern. Make sure the thesis is the **last sentence**; this tells the reader exactly what the essay will prove.

#### *Quick Self■Check*

After you finish, read your paragraph aloud. Ask yourself:

- Does the hook make me want to keep reading?
- Does the context explain why the topic matters?
- Is the thesis clear, specific, and debatable?

If any answer is "no," tweak the sentence until it feels right.

When you are satisfied, you have completed the practice activity: a solid thesis and a well■structured introductory paragraph ready for a full essay. Good work!

## 3.7 Reflection and Self■Check

When you finish writing your thesis statement, take a moment to look at it the way a teacher would. This "reflection" step is like checking a map before you start a road trip - it helps you see if you are headed in the right direction and spot any potholes that might slow you down later.

First, read your thesis out loud. Hearing the words can reveal awkward phrasing that your eyes missed. Ask yourself:

- Does the sentence tell the reader **exactly** what you will argue?
- Is it **specific** enough that someone could not guess the details of your paper from it?
- Does it use **active** language (the writer does something) rather than passive language (something is done to the writer)?

If you answer "yes" to all three, you are on the right track. If not, note the problem and think of a quick fix.

> **Note:** *Specific* means giving enough detail to narrow the focus. Instead of "Technology changes education," a specific thesis would say, "Online video tutorials improve high■school students' performance in algebra by 15 %." The extra numbers and clear subject make the claim testable.

Next, compare your thesis to the **checklist** you used earlier in the lesson:

- Checklist item - Does your thesis meet it? (✓ / ✗) - Quick comment
- One clear claim
- Answers the "so what?" question
- Uses concrete terms, not vague words
- Can be supported with evidence
- Fits the length of one sentence

Write a short note in the "Quick comment" column for each item you marked ✗. This forces you to think about *why* the statement falls short, not just that it does.

> **In daily life:** Think of this table like a grocery list. Before you leave the store, you check each item off to make sure you didn't forget anything. The checklist does the same for your thesis.

Now, look for **common weak spots** that many students overlook:

- **Broad language** - words like "many," "important," or "significant" are vague unless you attach a measurable detail.
- **Question format** - a thesis should be a statement, not a question. Change "Does social media affect teen confidence?" to "Social media reduces teen confidence by lowering self■esteem scores."
- **Multiple ideas** - trying to argue two unrelated points in one sentence confuses the reader. Split them into separate sentences or choose the stronger one.

> **Common mistake:** Writing a thesis that *states* a fact instead of *arguing* a point. Example of a fact: "The Earth orbits the Sun." Example of an argument: "The heliocentric model, first proposed by Copernicus, better explains planetary motion because it accounts for retrograde motion without epicycles."

If you spot any of these issues, rewrite the sentence in a separate notebook or on a sticky note. Keep the original version nearby so you can compare the two versions later.

Finally, make a **self■check plan** for future revisions:

- **One■sentence test** - Can you say your thesis in exactly one sentence without losing meaning?
- **Evidence test** - List three pieces of evidence you could use to support the claim. If you can't think of three, the thesis may be too broad or too narrow.
- **Reader test** - Imagine a classmate who knows nothing about your topic. After reading your thesis, would they understand what you will argue and why it matters? If the answer is "no," add a brief phrase that explains the significance.

Write these three answers below your thesis. They become a quick reference you can return to while drafting the body paragraphs.

> **Remember:** Reflection is not a one■time activity. Each time you revise a paragraph, return to this self■check. Over time, the habit will make your thesis statements stronger and your whole essay clearer.

## Terminology at a glance

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Thesis statement | One sentence that states the main argument or claim of an essay. |
| Specificity | Providing clear, detailed, and limited information so the thesis is focused. |
| Debatable claim | A statement that can be argued for or against, not a simple fact. |
| Introduction hook | An opening sentence that grabs the reader's attention. |
| Background (context) | Brief information that helps the reader understand the topic before the thesis. |
| Checklist testing | A set of questions used to evaluate whether a thesis is clear, specific, and debatable. |
| Weak thesis | A thesis that is vague, factual, or too broad, offering no clear argument. |
| Placement | The thesis should appear at the end of the introductory paragraph. |

## Practical application

Exercise 3.1:

Exercise 3.2:

Exercise 3.3:

Exercise 3.4:

Exercise 3.5:

Exercise 3.6:

## Checklist

[ ] Define a thesis statement and its purpose

[ ] Evaluate a thesis for clarity and arguability

[ ] Write a strong thesis for a given prompt

[ ] Position the thesis correctly within an introduction

LESSON 4

# 4. Structuring Paragraphs

## Lesson overview

In this lesson students learn how to build a strong paragraph by using a clear topic sentence, supporting evidence, analysis, and linking ideas. They will see how each part works together to make their writing coherent and persuasive.

## Learning outcomes

- Identify the function of a topic sentence in a paragraph
- Select appropriate evidence to support a claim
- Explain how analysis connects evidence to the main idea
- Use linking words to create smooth transitions between sentences

## 4.1 1. The Role of a Topic Sentence

A **topic sentence** is the first sentence that tells the reader what the whole paragraph will be about.

Think of it as a signpost on a road: it points the way so the reader knows which direction the paragraph will take.

> **Definition:** A topic sentence states the main idea of the paragraph and guides the reader.

Why do we need this signpost?

When someone reads a piece of writing, they move from one idea to the next. If each paragraph has a clear topic sentence, the reader can quickly decide whether the paragraph is relevant to their interests and can follow the writer's line of reasoning without getting lost. Without a topic sentence, the paragraph can feel like a collection of unrelated facts, and the reader may have to guess the purpose of each sentence.

**Every paragraph needs a main idea.**

The main idea is the single most important point you want to communicate in that paragraph. All the other sentences - examples, data, explanations - should support this point. The topic sentence makes the main idea explicit.

> **In daily life:** Imagine you are giving a friend directions to a coffee shop. You start by saying, "First, turn left at the library." That first instruction is like a topic sentence: it tells your friend what the next steps will be about.

### *How a topic sentence works*

- **Introduce the main idea** - It tells the reader what you will discuss.
- **Set the scope** - It hints at how much detail you will go into. A broad topic sentence leads to a longer paragraph; a narrow one leads to a short, focused paragraph.
- **Create expectation** - The reader now expects the rest of the paragraph to explain, prove, or illustrate the idea you just stated.

Because the topic sentence is usually placed at the beginning, it also helps the writer organize thoughts before writing. When you know the main idea first, you can select evidence and analysis that fit, rather than writing random sentences and trying to force them together later.

> **Note:** A good topic sentence is specific enough to give direction, but not so detailed that it repeats the whole paragraph.

### *Example*

Suppose you are writing about the benefits of reading fiction.

- **Weak topic sentence:** "Reading is good." (Too vague; the paragraph could go anywhere.)
- **Strong topic sentence:** "Reading fiction improves empathy by letting readers experience lives different from their own." (Clearly states the main idea and hints at the kind of evidence you will use.)

The strong version tells the reader that the paragraph will explain *how* fiction builds empathy, perhaps with research studies or personal anecdotes.

### *Building a topic sentence step by step*

- **Identify the main point** you want the paragraph to make.
- **Ask yourself:** *What is the simplest way to say this?*
- **Write a concise sentence** that includes the key terms.
- **Check:** Does it tell the reader what the rest of the paragraph will do? If the answer is "yes," you have a good topic sentence.

### *Why it matters in academic writing*

Academic essays are judged on how clearly ideas are presented. Professors look for paragraphs that each have a clear purpose. A well■crafted topic sentence shows that you have thought about the structure of your argument and helps the reader follow your logic. This, in turn, makes your writing more persuasive and easier to grade.

> **Remember:** Every paragraph should start with a topic sentence that states the main idea and guides the reader.

[Figure to be added: A road sign pointing the way, representing a topic sentence guiding the paragraph.]

Figure 4.1. A road sign pointing the way, representing a topic sentence guiding the paragraph.

[Figure to be added: Puzzle pieces fitting together to illustrate relevant evidence matching the topic sentence.]

Figure 4.2. Puzzle pieces fitting together to illustrate relevant evidence matching the topic sentence.

[Figure to be added: A sandwich diagram showing the parts of a paragraph.]

Figure 4.3. A sandwich diagram showing the parts of a paragraph.

[Figure to be added: Parts of a Paragraph]

Figure 4.4. Parts of a Paragraph

[Figure to be added: How to Build a Paragraph]

Figure 4.5. How to Build a Paragraph

[Figure to be added: Topic Sentence vs. Linking Sentence]

Figure 4.6. Topic Sentence vs. Linking Sentence

[Figure to be added: Common Mistakes to Avoid]

Figure 4.7. Common Mistakes to Avoid

[Figure to be added: Practice Activity Steps]

Figure 4.8. Practice Activity Steps

## 4.2 2. Choosing Relevant Evidence

When you write a paragraph, the **topic sentence** tells the reader what the paragraph is about. The evidence you choose must line up with that claim, just like a puzzle piece that fits perfectly into the picture shown by the topic sentence.

**Why relevance matters**

If the evidence does not match the topic sentence, the reader will feel confused and may think the paragraph is off■track. Relevant evidence makes your argument clear, convincing, and easy to follow.

> **Definition:** *Relevant evidence* - facts, quotations, statistics, or examples that directly support the idea stated in the topic sentence.

### *Step 1: Identify the key idea in the topic sentence*

Read the topic sentence and ask yourself: *What exactly am I trying to prove?*

- Look for the main **claim** (the statement you are supporting).
- Note any **keywords** that signal the type of support needed (e.g., "increase," "cause," "example").

### *Step 2: Brainstorm possible sources of evidence*

Make a quick list of everything you know about the claim:

- **Facts** - objective pieces of information that can be verified.
- **Quotes** - exact words spoken or written by an expert or a primary source.
- **Data** - numbers, percentages, or results of experiments.

### *Step 3: Check each item against the claim*

For each item on your list, ask: *Does this piece directly illustrate or prove the claim?* If the answer is "yes," keep it; if "no," set it aside.

> **In daily life:** Choosing relevant evidence is like picking the right tool from a toolbox. If you need to hang a picture, you reach for a hammer, not a screwdriver. The hammer (relevant evidence) fits the job (the claim) perfectly.

### *Step 4: Prioritise the strongest evidence*

Not all evidence is equal. Rank them by:

- **Authority** - is the source trustworthy? (e.g., a peer■reviewed journal vs. a personal blog)
- **Specificity** - does it address the exact point, or is it vague?
- **Recency** - is the information up■to■date?

Select the top two or three items; a paragraph rarely needs more than that.

### *Step 5: Introduce the evidence clearly*

When you bring the evidence into the paragraph, use a **signal phrase** (e.g., "According to...," "Research shows...") so the reader knows where the information comes from. This also avoids plagiarism by giving credit.

### *Step 6: Connect the evidence back to the claim*

After presenting the evidence, explain *how* it supports the topic sentence. This is the **analysis** step, but even at the evidence stage you can add a brief link:

- "This 15 % rise in enrollment demonstrates..."
- "Smith's observation that 'students learn better when...' confirms..."

> **Remember:** Always tie the evidence back to the claim; never let it stand alone.

### *Step 7: Watch out for irrelevant or weak evidence*

Sometimes a fact looks impressive but does not actually address the claim. For example, quoting a famous author about "beauty" would not support a claim about "the economic impact of tourism."

> **Common mistake:** Using a statistic that is related to the general topic but not to the specific point of the paragraph. This dilutes the argument and confuses the reader.

### *Quick checklist for choosing relevant evidence*

- Does the evidence directly support the claim?
- Is the source credible?

- Is the information specific and recent?
- Have you introduced it with a signal phrase?
- Have you linked it back to the topic sentence?

By following these small, clear steps, you ensure that every piece of evidence you include works like a well■chosen puzzle piece, completing the picture that your topic sentence begins. This makes your paragraph stronger, more logical, and easier for anyone to understand.

## 4.3 3. Adding Analysis

When you have chosen a piece of evidence - a quotation, a statistic, or an example - the paragraph is not finished yet.

The reader still needs to know **why** that evidence is important and **how** it supports the topic sentence.

This step is called *adding analysis*.

First, think of analysis as the bridge between the raw fact and the idea you are trying to prove.

If the evidence is a stone, the analysis is the path that leads the reader from the stone to the hilltop where your main point stands.

### *1. State the obvious, then go deeper*

A simple way to start is to restate the evidence in your own words.

For example, if the evidence is:

> "In 2022, 68 % of high■school students reported feeling stressed about exams."

You might write:

*The survey shows that more than two■thirds of students feel exam■related stress.*

Now you have clarified the number for the reader. The next step is to explain **why** this matters.

### *2. Ask "so what?"*

After you have restated the fact, ask yourself: *What does this tell us about the larger issue?*

If your paragraph's topic sentence is about the need for better mental■health support in schools, the answer could be:

*Because a large majority of students are stressed, schools cannot ignore mental■health resources; the stress level indicates a systemic problem, not just isolated cases.*

### *3. Connect the evidence to the claim*

Make the logical link explicit. Use words such as **because**, **therefore**, **as a result**, or **thus** to show cause and effect.

*Because 68 % of students feel stressed, it follows that the current exam schedule may be overwhelming, suggesting that schools should provide counseling services and stress■management workshops.*

> **Note:** *Cause and effect* means one thing leads to another. "Because A happens, B follows." This wording helps the reader see the chain of reasoning.

### *4. Explain the significance*

Beyond the direct link, discuss the broader implications. Ask: *What does this mean for the future?*

*If stress remains unaddressed, students may experience lower academic performance, higher absenteeism, and long■term health issues. Therefore, investing in mental■health programs is not just compassionate - it is also academically beneficial.*

### *5. Use a mini■formula for analysis*

You can think of analysis as a small equation:

Evidence + Explanation of relevance = Support for the topic sentence

In words: **Evidence** plus **Explanation of relevance** equals **Support for the topic sentence**.

Whenever you add a new piece of evidence, plug it into this formula to check that you have completed the analysis step.

### *6. Keep the language clear*

Avoid jargon unless you have defined it. If you must use a term like *correlation*, explain it the first time:

> **Definition:** *Correlation* is a statistical relationship where two things change together, but it does not prove that one causes the other.

### *7. Balance description and interpretation*

Do not spend too many sentences merely describing the evidence; after the first restatement, shift quickly to interpretation. A good ratio is roughly **1 sentence of description** to **2-3 sentences of analysis**.

> **Remember:** The purpose of analysis is to show the reader *how* the evidence backs up your main idea, not just to repeat the evidence.

#### *8. Example paragraph (with analysis highlighted)*

*Topic sentence:* **Schools should provide regular mental■health workshops to reduce exam stress.**

*Evidence:* "In 2022, 68 % of high■school students reported feeling stressed about exams."

*Analysis: This high percentage shows that stress is widespread, not limited to a few individuals. Because most students feel this pressure, the current approach - relying only on teachers' informal advice - fails to address a systemic issue. Therefore, structured workshops, which teach coping strategies, can reach the majority and potentially lower the overall stress level.*

Notice how the analysis moves from restating the statistic, to explaining its importance, to linking it directly to the proposed solution.

> **In daily life:** Think of a detective gathering clues (evidence). The analysis is the detective's reasoning that connects each clue to the suspect (the main idea). Without the reasoning, the clues remain unrelated facts.

By consistently adding this "why it matters" step, every paragraph becomes a clear, persuasive argument rather than a list of disconnected facts.

### 4.4 4. Linking Ideas Within the Paragraph

When you write a paragraph, each sentence should feel like the next step in a short story.

Linking words and phrases are the "glue" that hold those steps together. They tell the reader how one idea relates to the next - whether it adds more information, shows a contrast, gives an example, or draws a conclusion.

**Why linking matters**

If sentences are placed side■by■side without any connection, the paragraph can sound choppy, like a list of unrelated facts. The reader then has to guess the relationship, which wastes time and can cause confusion. A smooth flow lets the reader see the logical path you are building, making your argument stronger and easier to follow.

**Everyday comparison**

Think of a paragraph as a train. The first carriage is the topic sentence, and each following carriage is a supporting sentence. Linking words are the couplers that join the carriages. Without couplers, the carriages would roll apart; with good couplers, the train moves smoothly along the tracks.

#### *Common linking categories*

- Purpose - Typical words/phrases
- **Add information** - moreover, furthermore, in addition, also, besides
- **Show contrast** - however, nevertheless, on the other hand, although, but
- **Give examples** - for example, for instance, such as, namely
- **Show cause & effect** - therefore, consequently, as a result, thus, because
- **Summarise or conclude** - in short, overall, in conclusion, to sum up, finally

You do not need to use every word in a paragraph. Choose the one that best matches the relationship you want to show.

> **Definition:** *Linking words* (also called *connectors* or *transitions*) are short phrases that signal how two ideas are related.

#### *How to insert a linking word*

- **Identify the relationship** between the current sentence and the one that follows.
- Are you adding a new point? -> use "moreover".
- Are you showing a difference? -> use "however".
- **Place the connector at the beginning of the new sentence** (or after a semicolon if the ideas are very close).
- Example without a link: "The experiment used 50 ml of acid. The temperature rose quickly."
- Example with a link: "The experiment used 50 ml of acid. **Consequently**, the temperature rose quickly."
- **Add a comma after the connector** (except for "however" when it appears in the middle of a sentence). This pause signals the shift to the reader.

#### *Small step practice*

- **Step 1:** Write two simple sentences about the same topic.

*Sentence A:* "Cats are independent animals."

*Sentence B:* "They often groom themselves."

- **Step 2:** Decide how the second sentence relates to the first. It **adds** more detail.
- **Step 3:** Insert an appropriate linker at the start of Sentence B.

"Cats are independent animals. **Furthermore**, they often groom themselves."

Now the paragraph feels like a single, flowing idea.

> **In daily life:** When you tell a friend a story, you naturally use words like "then", "but", or "so". Those are everyday linking words that help the listener follow the plot.

### *A quick formula for coherence*

If we think of each sentence as a node, the paragraph's coherence can be expressed as

Coherence = sum_i=1^n-1 Link(S_i, S_i+1)

where Link(S_i, S_i+1) is a value of 1 when a suitable connector is used between sentence S_i and S_i+1, and 0 otherwise. The higher the sum, the smoother the paragraph.

### *Tips to avoid over■linking*

- **Don't force a connector** if the sentences already flow naturally. Adding "however" where there is no contrast can confuse the reader.
- **Vary your links**. Repeating "also" in every sentence makes the paragraph sound monotonous. Mix "moreover", "in addition", and "besides" to keep the rhythm lively.

> **Common mistake:** Using "but" at the start of a sentence without a preceding contrast. This creates a logical gap because the reader expects a difference that was never introduced.

### *Remember the rhythm*

A well■linked paragraph has a gentle rise and fall, much like a conversation. Start with a clear topic, add supporting points, and use connectors to guide the listener from one point to the next. When you practice, read your paragraph aloud; if you feel a tiny pause where a connector should be, insert one. Over time, choosing the right link will become as natural as breathing.

## 4.5 5. Putting It All Together

The goal of this part is to show you how a paragraph looks when every piece is in the right place.

We will build the paragraph step■by■step, then write it out in full.

> **Definition:** *Topic sentence* - the first sentence that tells the reader what the whole paragraph will be about.

> **Note:** The topic sentence should be clear and specific; it is the "road sign" for the reader.

> **In daily life:** Think of a paragraph like a sandwich. The topic sentence is the top slice of bread, the evidence and analysis are the fillings, and the linking ideas are the bottom slice that holds everything together.

> **Remember:** Every sentence after the topic sentence must relate back to it.

### *1. Write the topic sentence*

Start with a simple claim that you can support.

Example: *Regular exercise improves students' concentration during lessons.*

- **Why this works:** It states a single idea that can be proved with facts.

### *2. Choose relevant evidence*

Pick a fact, statistic, or short quotation that directly backs the claim.

Example: *A 2022 study by the University of Cambridge found that pupils who exercised for 30 minutes before class scored 12 % higher on attention tests than those who did not.*

- **Why this works:** The evidence is recent, from a reputable source, and gives a concrete number.

### *3. Add analysis*

Explain *how* the evidence supports the claim. Do not just repeat the fact; interpret it.

Example: *The improvement suggests that physical activity increases blood flow to the brain, which helps students stay alert and process information more efficiently.*

- **Why this works:** It connects the statistic to the underlying reason, showing cause and effect.

#### *4. Link ideas within the paragraph*

Use transition words to show the relationship between sentences.

Common links: *therefore, because, moreover, as a result, consequently.*

Example linking phrase: *Consequently, teachers who schedule a short workout before lessons often notice fewer off■task behaviors.*

- **Why this works:** The word "consequently" signals that the next idea follows logically from the analysis.

#### *5. Put it all together*

Now combine the pieces, keeping the order: topic sentence -> evidence -> analysis -> link -> concluding remark (optional).

**Full paragraph**

*Regular exercise improves students' concentration during lessons. A 2022 study by the University of Cambridge found that pupils who exercised for 30 minutes before class scored 12 % higher on attention tests than those who did not. This improvement suggests that physical activity increases blood flow to the brain, which helps students stay alert and process information more efficiently. Consequently, teachers who schedule a short workout before lessons often notice fewer off■task behaviors, leading to smoother classroom management.*

- **Why this works:**
- The first sentence tells the reader the main point.
- The second sentence provides solid, quantifiable evidence.
- The third sentence interprets the evidence, linking it to the claim.
- The fourth sentence uses a transition word ("consequently") to show the logical result, and it adds a practical implication for teachers.

> **Common mistake:** Adding a quotation that does not directly support the topic sentence. This makes the paragraph feel disjointed and weakens the argument.

By following these steps, you can craft paragraphs that are clear, persuasive, and easy for readers to follow. Practice by picking a claim, finding one piece of evidence, explaining it, and linking it back to the claim. Over time, the process will become automatic, and your academic writing will feel much stronger.

## 4.6 6. Common Mistakes to Avoid

When you write a paragraph, it is easy to slip into habits that make the paragraph hard to read or weak in argument. Below are the most common mistakes, why they matter, and how to fix them.

> **Common mistake:** *Leaving out analysis*

A paragraph that only lists facts or quotations without explaining them is like a recipe that lists ingredients but never tells you how to mix them. The reader sees the pieces of information, but they do not understand why those pieces matter for your main point. Always ask yourself, "What does this evidence show?" After you present a piece of evidence, add a sentence that interprets it and links it back to the topic sentence. For example, if you write, "The city's traffic accidents rose by 12 % last year," follow with, "This increase suggests that the new traffic■light timing plan is not working, because more cars are forced to stop unexpectedly." The second sentence is the analysis that turns raw data into a meaningful claim.

> **Note:** *Using weak or irrelevant evidence*

Evidence should be strong, reliable, and directly related to the claim you are making. Weak evidence is like a shaky bridge - it might get you across, but it could collapse under scrutiny. A personal anecdote can be vivid, but unless the lesson is about personal experience, it does not count as solid proof. Prefer statistics, expert quotations, or documented observations that are recent and from reputable sources. If you must use a story, make sure it clearly illustrates the point and is supported by at least one factual source.

> **In daily life:** *Abrupt transitions*

Imagine you are telling a friend two separate stories without any link: "I went to the market. My car broke down." The listener will be confused because the two sentences are not connected. In writing, abrupt transitions happen when you jump from one idea to the next without a linking word or phrase. This makes the paragraph feel choppy and can cause the reader to lose the thread of your argument. Use transition words such as "however," "therefore," "for example," or "as a result" to show the relationship between sentences. A smooth transition might read: "The traffic accidents rose by 12 %; **therefore**, the city council decided to review the timing plan."

> **Remember:** *Mixing up the order of the paragraph parts*

A well■structured paragraph follows a clear order: topic sentence -> evidence -> analysis -> concluding or linking sentence. If you place the analysis before the evidence, the reader is left wondering what you are analyzing. If the concluding sentence appears too early, the paragraph may feel unfinished. Think of the paragraph as a mini■story: you introduce the scene (topic), show the action (evidence), explain why the action matters (analysis), and then wrap up or point to the next scene (link). Keeping this order helps the reader follow your logic step by step.

**Why these mistakes matter**

- **Clarity:** Missing analysis or weak evidence leaves the reader guessing.
- **Credibility:** Strong, relevant evidence shows you have done research and can be trusted.
- **Flow:** Smooth transitions keep the reader engaged and make the argument feel natural.

**How to check your own work**

- After writing, read the paragraph aloud. Does each sentence feel connected?
- Highlight the evidence and ask, "Does this directly support the topic sentence?"
- Look for a sentence that explains *why* the evidence matters. If none is present, add an analysis sentence.
- Scan for transition words. If two sentences feel unrelated, insert a linking phrase.

By spotting these common pitfalls early, you can turn a shaky paragraph into a clear, persuasive piece of academic writing. Keep the checklist handy, and with practice each paragraph will become stronger and more coherent.

## 4.7 7. Practice Activity

When you write a paragraph, think of it as a tiny story that has a clear beginning, a middle that shows why the beginning matters, and an ending that ties everything together.

The "story" you are telling is built from four parts:

- **Topic sentence** - the opening line that tells the reader what the paragraph is about.
- **Evidence** - a fact, statistic, quotation, or example that supports the claim in the topic sentence.
- **Analysis** - your own explanation of why the evidence matters; this is where you show you understand the connection.
- **Link** - a closing sentence that connects the paragraph to the next idea or restates the main point in a broader context.

Below is a step■by■step activity that lets you practice putting these four pieces together. Follow each step carefully; you will write one complete paragraph by the end.

### *Step 1 - Choose a simple claim*

Pick a statement you can support with a single piece of evidence. It should be something you can explain in a few sentences.

**Example claim:** "Regular exercise improves concentration in school."

> **Remember:** A good topic sentence is a clear, specific claim. It tells the reader exactly what the paragraph will prove.

### *Step 2 - Find one piece of evidence*

Look for a fact, statistic, or short quotation that backs up your claim. You can use a textbook, a reliable website, or a class handout.

**Example evidence:** "A 2022 study by the University of Minnesota found that students who exercised for 30 minutes a day scored 12% higher on attention■span tests than those who did not."

> **Definition:** *Evidence* is any information that helps prove your claim. It must be trustworthy and directly related to the topic sentence.

### *Step 3 - Write the analysis*

Explain in your own words why the evidence supports the claim. Ask yourself: *What does this result mean? How does it connect to the idea that exercise helps concentration?*

**Example analysis:** "The higher scores suggest that physical activity boosts blood flow to the brain, which in turn enhances the neural processes needed for sustained focus."

> **In daily life:** Think of analysis like the "why" behind a recipe. If a cake rises, you explain that it's because of the baking powder reacting with heat, not just that the cake is fluffy.

### *Step 4 - Create a linking sentence*

Finish the paragraph by linking back to the larger essay or by hinting at the next point you will discuss. This helps the reader see the flow of ideas.

**Example link:** "Therefore, schools that incorporate short workout breaks may see overall improvements in classroom attentiveness."

> **Common mistake:** Writing a link that simply repeats the topic sentence without adding new information. The link should move the discussion forward.

### *Your Turn: Write Your Own Paragraph*

- **Pick a claim** (one sentence).
- **Find one piece of evidence** (a fact, statistic, or short quote). Cite the source in parentheses.
- **Write an analysis sentence** that explains why the evidence backs up your claim.
- **Add a linking sentence** that connects this paragraph to a larger argument or to the next paragraph you might write.

**Prompt:**

*Write a paragraph about a habit that helps students learn better. Use the four components (topic sentence, evidence, analysis, link). Your paragraph should be 5-7 sentences long. Be sure to cite your evidence and keep the language clear and concise.*

### *Checklist before you submit*

- Does the first sentence state a clear claim?
- Is the evidence specific and properly cited?
- Does the analysis explain the "why" behind the evidence?
- Does the final sentence link the paragraph to a larger idea?

If you can answer "yes" to all four questions, you have successfully built a well■structured paragraph. Practice this pattern with different topics, and you will find paragraph writing becomes much easier and more logical.

## Terminology at a glance

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Topic sentence | The first sentence of a paragraph that states its main idea. |
| Main idea | The single most important point the paragraph wants to convey. |
| Relevant evidence | Facts, quotes, statistics, or examples that directly support the topic sentence. |
| Analysis | Explanation of why the evidence matters and how it backs the main idea. |
| Linking words | Words or phrases (e.g., however, furthermore) that show the relationship between sentences. |
| Paragraph structure | The order of topic sentence, evidence, analysis, and linking sentence. |
| Common mistake: missing analysis | Leaving out the explanation of evidence, making the paragraph feel like a list of facts. |
| Coherence | The smooth flow of ideas within a paragraph, achieved by logical connections. |

## Practical application

Exercise 4.1:

Exercise 4.2:

Exercise 4.3:

Exercise 4.4:

Exercise 4.5:

Exercise 4.6:

## Checklist

[ ] Identify the function of a topic sentence in a paragraph

[ ] Select appropriate evidence to support a claim

[ ] Explain how analysis connects evidence to the main idea

[ ] Use linking words to create smooth transitions between sentences

LESSON 5

# 5. Using Evidence

## Lesson overview

In this lesson students learn how to use quotations, paraphrase, and summarise sources effectively, and understand why over■quoting weakens an essay. They will also see practical steps to integrate evidence without relying too heavily on direct quotes.

## Learning outcomes

- Identify when to quote, paraphrase, or summarise a source
- Rewrite a passage in their own words while keeping the original meaning
- Create a concise summary of a longer text
- Avoid over■quoting by balancing their own voice with evidence

## 5.1 Why Use Different Types of Evidence?

When you write an essay or a report, you are not only showing what you think, but also showing that your ideas are backed up by reliable information.

The way you bring that information into your own writing can be done in three main ways: **quoting**, **paraphrasing**, and **summarising**. Each method has a purpose, and using the right one at the right time makes your argument clearer and more convincing.

First, think of evidence as pieces of a puzzle. A quotation is a single piece that fits perfectly because it is exactly the shape the original author gave you. You keep the piece unchanged, so the picture on it is exactly the same as in the original picture.

> **Definition:** *Quotation* - copying the exact words of a source, enclosed in quotation marks and followed by a citation.

A quotation is most useful when the original wording is especially powerful, memorable, or authoritative. For example, if Martin Luther King Jr. said, "I have a dream that one day...", you would quote those words because the phrasing itself carries a strong emotional weight that would be lost if you changed it.

Second, a paraphrase is like taking a puzzle piece, looking at its shape, and then carving a new piece that fits the same spot but matches the style of the rest of your puzzle. You keep the original idea, but you express it with your own words.

> **Note:** *Paraphrasing* means restating a source's idea in a different way while keeping the meaning the same, and you must still give credit to the original author.

Paraphrasing is handy when the idea is important, but the exact wording is not critical. It also shows that you understand the material well enough to explain it yourself. For instance, instead of quoting a long definition of "photosynthesis," you might write: *Plants turn sunlight into food through a process called photosynthesis.* This keeps the flow of your essay smooth while still acknowledging the source.

Third, a summary is like looking at several puzzle pieces together and drawing a quick sketch that captures the overall picture. You condense a larger section of text - sometimes a whole article - into a few sentences that convey the main points.

> **In daily life:** *Summarising* is like telling a friend the plot of a movie you just watched, without describing every scene.

Summaries are useful when you need to give background information or show the broader context of a debate without getting bogged down in details. If you are writing about climate change, you might summarise a 20■page report by stating: *The report concludes that human activities are the primary driver of recent global warming.* This gives readers the essential conclusion while leaving the detailed data for later reference.

Why mix these three? Imagine you are building a house. Quotations are the bricks that have a special decorative pattern - you keep them exactly as they are because they add character. Paraphrases are the standard bricks you shape to fit the walls, showing you can work with the material. Summaries are the foundation, giving the overall shape and stability. Using only one type would make the house either too repetitive, too vague, or too shallow.

> **Remember:** Use quotations for striking language, paraphrases for clear restatement of ideas, and summaries for concise overviews.

When you combine them wisely, your writing will have a strong voice (your own ideas) supported by solid evidence (the other authors). This balance helps readers trust your argument and understand the topic from multiple angles.

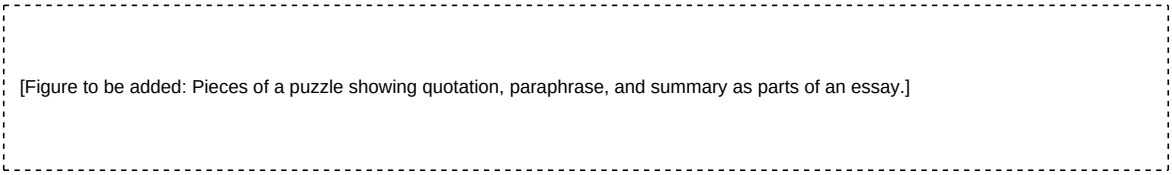



Figure 5.1. Pieces of a puzzle showing quotation, paraphrase, and summary as parts of an essay.

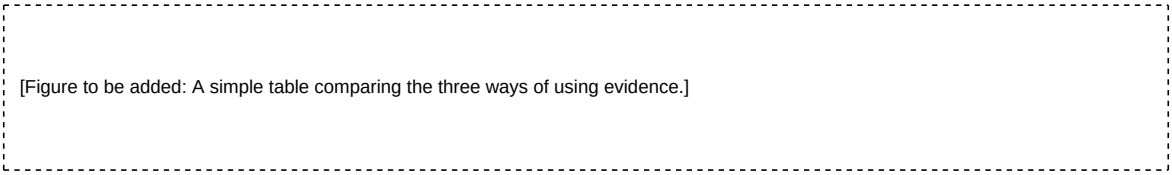



Figure 5.2. A simple table comparing the three ways of using evidence.

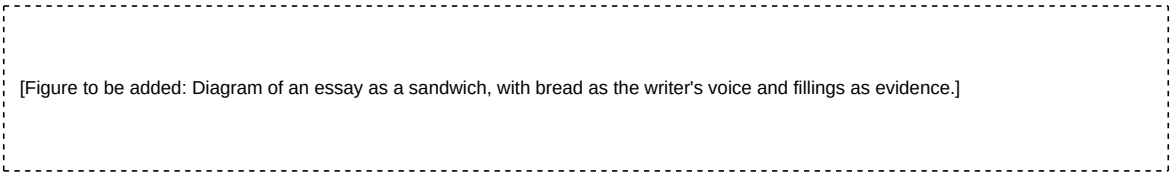



Figure 5.3. Diagram of an essay as a sandwich, with bread as the writer's voice and fillings as evidence.




Figure 5.4. Quote vs Paraphrase




Figure 5.5. Integrating Evidence into an Essay




Figure 5.6. Types of Evidence and Their Roles

## 5.2 How to Quote Correctly

When you want to use someone else's exact words in your essay, you are **quoting**. A quote is a tiny piece of another writer's text that you copy word■for■word and place inside quotation marks (" ").

> **Definition:** A *quote* is a verbatim (exact) reproduction of another author's words, enclosed in quotation marks.

Why quote at all? Because a quote can give your argument authority, show that you have read the source, and let the reader see the original wording that supports your point. Think of a quote like a short, trusted testimonial you might put on a product's advertisement: the original speaker's voice adds credibility that your own words alone might not have.

### *Step 1 - Choose a short, relevant fragment*

Only include the part of the source that directly backs up your claim. If the original sentence is long, cut it down to the essential words. A good rule of thumb is: **no more than 40 words** for a standard paragraph; longer passages need a block quote (which we will cover later).

> **Note:** Keeping quotes short helps your own voice stay dominant and prevents the essay from turning into a collage of other people's sentences.

### *Step 2 - Introduce the quote*

Never drop a quote abruptly. Lead into it with a signal phrase that tells the reader who is speaking and why the quote matters. Common signal verbs include *argues, claims, writes, observes,* and *states*.

Example:

*Smith (2020) argues that "students learn best when they can see the real■world relevance of the material" (p. 45).*

In this sentence, **Smith** is the author, **2020** is the year of publication, and **(p. 45)** tells the reader where to find the exact words in the source. The signal phrase ("Smith argues that") prepares the reader for the quoted material.

#### *Step 3 - Use quotation marks correctly*

Place double quotation marks at the very beginning and end of the quoted words. If you need to add a word for clarity, put it inside square brackets **[ ]** inside the quotation marks.

Example:

*The report states that "the [program] increased attendance by 15 %" (Doe, 2019, p. 12).*

Here, **[program]** clarifies what "it" refers to, without changing the original wording.

#### *Step 4 - Cite the source immediately*

After the closing quotation mark, include an in■text citation that matches the style you are using (APA, MLA, Chicago, etc.). The citation usually contains the author's last name, the year, and the page number. This lets readers locate the original passage and avoids plagiarism.

> **Remember:** Every quote must have a citation right after it; otherwise the quote looks like your own words.

#### *Step 5 - Explain the quote*

A quote never stands alone. After you present it, add a sentence (or two) that explains how the quoted words support your argument. This is where your own voice re■enters.

Example:

*Smith's claim highlights the importance of relevance, which explains why our curriculum redesign focuses on project■based learning.*

#### *Putting it all together*

Here is a complete example that follows every step:

*According to Johnson (2018), "students who write reflective journals show a 20 % improvement in critical■thinking scores" (p. 78). This statistic demonstrates that reflective writing is not just a feel■good activity; it has measurable academic benefits, which is why we will incorporate weekly journals into the course.*

#### *Common pitfalls to avoid*

> **Common mistake:** Using a quote that is too long or only loosely related to your point. Long quotes can drown out your analysis and may be flagged by teachers as "over■reliance on sources."

> **In daily life:** Think of a quote like a short excerpt from a movie you share with a friend to prove a point. You wouldn't recite the whole movie; you pick the exact line that matters.

#### *Quick checklist for quoting correctly*

- **Select** a brief, relevant fragment (<= 40 words).
- **Introduce** it with a signal phrase and the author's name.
- **Enclose** the exact words in double quotation marks.
- **Add** any clarifying words in square brackets, not altering the original meaning.
- **Cite** the source immediately after the quote (author, year, page).
- **Explain** why the quote matters for your argument.

By following these steps, you keep the balance between your own analysis and the evidence you borrow, making your academic writing clear, credible, and persuasive.

## 5.3 Paraphrasing: Putting Ideas into Your Own Words

Paraphrasing means taking someone else's idea and writing it again **in your own words**. It is not the same as copying, and it is not the same as just changing a few words. When you paraphrase well, you keep the original meaning but express it with a fresh sentence structure and vocabulary that fits the style of your own essay.

> **Definition:** Paraphrasing is the skill of restating a source's main point using different wording and sentence patterns, while still giving credit to the original author.

Why is this useful? First, it shows that you understand the material. If you can explain a concept without looking at the exact wording, you have processed it. Second, it helps you blend evidence smoothly into your own argument, so the paper sounds like *your* voice rather than a patchwork of quotations.

### *Step■by■step process*

- **Read the passage slowly**

Read the original sentence or short paragraph at least twice. Try to picture the idea in your mind, as if you were explaining it to a friend.

- **Identify the core idea**

Ask yourself: *What is the author really saying here?*

Write down a one■sentence summary in plain language. This is your "note" of the main point, not the exact words.

- **Highlight any key terms**

Some words are essential because they carry specific meaning (e.g., "photosynthesis," "market equilibrium"). Keep those terms, but you can replace surrounding words.

- **Switch the sentence structure**

Change the order of information. If the original starts with a cause and ends with an effect, try beginning with the effect and then give the cause. Use different grammatical forms (e.g., turn a passive voice into an active voice).

- **Replace synonyms carefully**

Use a thesaurus, but only for words that are not technical. For example, "increase" can become "rise," but "inflation" should stay "inflation" because the meaning is precise.

- **Write your version**

Combine the steps above into a new sentence. Make sure it still conveys the same meaning as the original.

- **Compare with the source**

Check that you have not accidentally kept a phrase that is too close to the original. If any part looks identical, re■word it again.

- **Cite the source**

Even though you have rewritten the words, the idea belongs to the original author. Add an in■text citation in the format required by your style guide (e.g., (Smith 2022)).

### *Example*

Original:

*"The rapid expansion of urban areas has led to a significant increase in surface runoff, which in turn raises the risk of flooding during heavy rainstorms."*

- Main idea: Urban growth causes more runoff, which makes flooding more likely.
- Key terms: "urban areas," "surface runoff," "flooding."
- Paraphrase: *Because cities are spreading quickly, more water runs off the ground, so heavy rains are more likely to cause floods (Smith 2022).*

Notice how the cause■effect relationship is kept, but the wording and order are different.

> **In daily life:** Think of paraphrasing like retelling a movie plot to a friend. You don't repeat the exact lines from the film; you describe the story in your own voice while still giving credit to the director when you mention the original idea.

### *Tips to avoid common pitfalls*

- **Don't just swap a word for a synonym.** Changing "big" to "large" while keeping the rest of the sentence identical is still too close to the source.
- **Watch out for "copy■and■paste" chunks.** Even a phrase of three or four words can be considered plagiarism if it is distinctive.
- **Keep the meaning exact.** A synonym that slightly changes the nuance (e.g., "help" vs. "assist") may alter the author's intent. If you are unsure, keep the original term.

> **Common mistake:** Re■ordering the words but leaving the same phrasing. This often results in a "patchwork" paraphrase that still looks like the original and can be flagged for plagiarism.

### *Quick checklist before you submit*

- Have I captured the **main idea** in my own words?
- Did I **change the sentence structure** and **use different phrasing**?
- Are all **technical terms** retained where necessary?
- Did I **add a proper citation** for the idea?

> **Remember:** Paraphrasing is a tool for showing understanding. If you can explain the concept to a classmate without looking at the text, you have successfully paraphrased it.

## 5.4 Summarising: Condensing Longer Texts

Summarising means taking a longer piece of writing - such as an article, a chapter, or a report - and turning it into a short paragraph that tells the reader only the most important ideas.

> **Definition:** A summary is a brief restatement of the main points of a source, using your own words and leaving out details, examples, and minor arguments.

Why do we need to summarise? When you write an essay, you cannot copy whole sections of other authors; the reader would be overwhelmed and you would run out of space for your own analysis. A good summary lets you show that you understand the source, and it gives your audience the background they need without getting bogged down in unnecessary information.

Think of a movie trailer. The trailer does not show every scene; it picks the key moments that explain the plot, the main characters, and the tone. In the same way, a summary selects the "key scenes" of a text - its central claim, the strongest evidence, and the conclusion - while leaving out the side plots.

### *Step■by■step process*

- **Read the whole text carefully.**

Do not try to summarise until you have a clear picture of what the author is arguing. If the text is long, read it in sections and note the purpose of each paragraph.

- **Identify the thesis or main argument.**

The thesis is the sentence (or a few sentences) that tells you what the author wants you to believe or what problem they are trying to solve. Write it down in your notebook in plain language.

- **Find the supporting points.**

Look for the major reasons, data, or examples that the author uses to back up the thesis. Usually there are three to five of these in a typical academic article.

- **Ignore the details.**

Specific statistics, anecdotes, or quotations are useful for a full analysis, but they are not needed in a short summary. You can safely leave them out unless they are the core of the argument.

- **Rewrite in your own words.**

Using the notes from steps 2 and 3, craft a paragraph that states the thesis first, then lists the main supporting points in the order they appear. Keep the language simple and avoid copying phrases directly from the source.

- **Check length.**

A good rule of thumb is that a summary should be about **10 %** of the original length. For a 2,000■word article, aim for roughly 200 words.

- **Compare with the original.**

After writing, glance back at the source to make sure you have not missed any crucial idea and that you have not added your own opinion.

> **Note:** A summary is *neutral*; it does not include your evaluation, agreement, or disagreement with the source. Those belong in the analysis part of your essay.

### *Example*

Original passage (120 words):

> "Climate change is accelerating because of increased greenhouse■gas emissions from human activities such as burning fossil fuels, deforestation, and industrial processes. Recent data show that atmospheric carbon dioxide levels have risen from 280 ppm in pre■industrial times to over 415 ppm today, a rise of nearly 50 %. This increase has led to higher average global temperatures, more frequent heatwaves, and melting polar ice caps, all of which threaten biodiversity and human livelihoods."

Summary (≈45 words):

> The author argues that human■driven greenhouse■gas emissions are causing rapid climate change. Carbon dioxide has risen from 280 ppm to over 415 ppm, leading to higher temperatures, more heatwaves, and melting ice, which endanger ecosystems and people.

Notice how the summary captures the main claim (human emissions cause climate change) and the three key pieces of evidence (CO■ rise, temperature increase, impacts), while omitting the specific percentages and detailed examples.

> **In daily life:** Summarising is like writing a quick text message to a friend about a news article you read - you tell them the headline and the main point, not every quote from the reporter.

#### *Common pitfalls*

> **Common mistake:** Copying whole sentences from the source. Even if you change a few words, this is still plagiarism. Always rewrite the idea in your own voice.

> **Remember:** After you have summarised, you can still use a short quotation for a particularly striking phrase, but the quotation must be clearly marked with quotation marks and a citation.

#### *Quick checklist for a solid summary*

- Have you read the whole source first?
- Does your paragraph start with the author's main argument?
- Are the supporting points listed in logical order?
- Have you removed examples, statistics, and minor details?
- Is the language completely yours, with no copied phrases?
- Is the length roughly 10 % of the original?

If you can answer "yes" to all of these questions, your summary is ready to be inserted into your essay. It will give readers the essential background they need, while leaving plenty of space for you to add your own analysis and voice.

## 5.5 Balancing Evidence and Your Own Voice

When you write an essay, the goal is to show that you understand the topic **and** that you can think for yourself. Evidence - quotes, paraphrases, and summaries - is the proof that supports your ideas, but it must not drown out your own voice. Think of your essay as a conversation: you are the host, and the evidence are the guests you invite to help explain your point. If the guests talk all the time, the host never gets a chance to speak.

> **Note:** *Balancing evidence and your own voice* means using just enough evidence to support your claim while keeping the majority of the text in your own words.

#### *Why a balance matters*

- **Shows critical thinking** - When you explain a quote in your own words, you demonstrate that you have understood it, not just copied it.
- **Keeps the reader engaged** - Readers get bored if they have to read long blocks of someone else's words without hearing your interpretation.
- **Avoids plagiarism** - Over■quoting can look like you are relying on someone else's work instead of creating your own argument.

#### *Step■by■step strategy*

- **Set a quote■length limit**
- Decide that no single quotation will be longer than **one sentence** or **15 words** (whichever is shorter).
- If a source contains a longer passage that seems essential, **summarise** it instead of quoting it verbatim.
- **Mix the three types of evidence**
- **Quote**: Use when the original wording is especially powerful, precise, or authoritative.
- **Paraphrase**: Restate the idea in a new sentence that fits your own style. This shows you can translate the source's meaning.
- **Summarise**: Condense several sentences or a whole paragraph into a brief statement. Use this when you need background information without getting bogged down in detail.

By alternating these three, you create a rhythm: quote -> explain -> paraphrase -> expand -> summary -> your own analysis.

- **Add a "bridge" sentence**

After any piece of evidence, write a sentence that links it back to your main argument. This is where your voice shines the brightest. For example:

> "This statistic shows that ..., which supports my claim that ..."

- **Use a "evidence■to■comment" ratio**

A simple rule of thumb is **2:1** - for every two lines of evidence, write at least one line of your own comment. If you notice you have more evidence than commentary, go back and add more of your own analysis.

- **Check the flow**

Read your paragraph aloud. If you hear more of the source than your own words, trim the quote or replace it with a paraphrase.

### *Everyday comparison*

Imagine you are baking a cake. The flour, sugar, and eggs are the **evidence** - they give the cake its structure and flavor. Your own mixing, timing, and decoration are your **voice**. If you pour in too much flour (over■quoting), the cake becomes dense and hard to eat. If you add just a pinch of each ingredient and then spend time frosting and arranging the cake, the result is balanced and enjoyable.

> **In daily life:** *Balancing evidence and your own voice is like seasoning a dish - a little salt (quote) enhances the flavor, but too much overwhelms the taste.*

### *Common pitfalls to avoid*

- **Copy■and■paste syndrome** - dropping a long quote without any explanation.
- **Paraphrase■only trap** - never using any direct quotes, which can make your work seem unsupported.
- **Summary■only approach** - condensing everything, losing the nuance that a well■chosen quote provides.

> **Common mistake:** *Leaving a quote without a follow■up sentence that tells the reader why it matters.*

### *Quick checklist*

- [ ] Is each quote <= 15 words or one sentence?
- [ ] Have I mixed quotes, paraphrases, and summaries?
- [ ] Does every piece of evidence have a bridge sentence that links it to my argument?
- [ ] Does the paragraph have at least as many of my own sentences as evidence sentences?
- [ ] Have I read the paragraph aloud to hear the balance?

> **Remember:** *Your essay is your conversation. Let your voice do most of the talking, and let evidence chime in at the right moments.*

## 5.6 Practice Activity: Integrating Evidence

Imagine you have a short article in front of you - maybe a news story about a new park opening in your town. Your task is to turn that article into a short paragraph for an essay, using three different ways to bring the information into your own writing: **quoting**, **paraphrasing**, and **summarising**.

First, read the article once all the way through. Highlight any sentence that sounds especially powerful or that contains a specific fact you will need to prove later. Those are the spots where a **quote** might work best.

Next, look for ideas that are important but are expressed in long, complicated sentences. Rewrite those ideas in your own words - that is **paraphrasing**.

Finally, find sections that give background or describe a series of events. Turn those whole sections into a brief overview - that is **summarising**.

Below is a step■by■step guide you can follow while you work on the article.

- **Choose a quote**
- Find a sentence that is short, clear, and directly supports the point you want to make.
- Copy it exactly as it appears, including punctuation, and put it inside quotation marks.
- Add a citation (author, year, page or paragraph number) right after the quote.
- **Paraphrase a paragraph**
- Read the original paragraph, then look away and write the main idea in your own words.
- Keep the meaning the same, but change the wording and sentence structure.

- Do **not** copy any phrase longer than three words unless you use quotation marks.
- **Summarise a section**
- Identify the overall purpose of a longer part of the article (e.g., a description of the park's design process).
- Write one or two sentences that capture the essential points, leaving out details, examples, and opinions.
- Cite the whole section, because the summary still relies on the original source.

> **Definition:** *Quote* - the exact words from a source, enclosed in quotation marks and followed by a citation.

> **Note:** *Paraphrase* means to restate the original idea in your own language, while keeping the same meaning.

> **In daily life:** Think of quoting like copying a friend's exact words when you repeat a joke, paraphrasing like retelling the joke in your own style, and summarising like giving the punchline without the whole story.

> **Remember:** Every piece of evidence you use must be linked to a clear reason why it supports your argument.

#### *Checklist for your draft*

- Step - What to look for - Yes / No
- Quote - Exact words, quotation marks, citation, relevant to your claim
- Paraphrase - Same meaning, different wording, no long phrases copied, citation
- Summarise - Main idea only, concise (1■2 sentences), citation for whole section
- Integration - Quote, paraphrase, and summary flow together; your own voice appears between them
- Attribution - Every piece of evidence has a citation in the correct format

#### *How to use the checklist*

- **Read your paragraph aloud.** Does it sound like a single, smooth piece of writing, or does it feel choppy? If it feels choppy, you may have over■quoted or not added enough of your own explanation.
- **Mark each piece of evidence** with a coloured pen: green for quotes, blue for paraphrases, orange for summaries. Then check the corresponding row in the table.
- **Ask yourself:** "Did I explain why this evidence matters?" If the answer is no, add a short sentence after the evidence that links it to your argument.
- **Double■check citations.** Make sure the author's name, year, and page/paragraph number are present and formatted consistently.

#### *Example (short excerpt)*

Original article sentence:

> "The new Riverside Park will feature a 2■kilometre walking trail, native■plant gardens, and a solar■powered playground."

Your paragraph might look like this:

> The city's latest project, Riverside Park, promises several eco■friendly amenities. As the council announced, "The new Riverside Park will feature a 2■kilometre walking trail, native■plant gardens, and a solar■powered playground" (City Council, 2024, para. 4). In other words, the park will include a long trail for walkers, gardens that use local plants, and a playground that runs on solar energy. Overall, the development aims to combine recreation with sustainability (City Council, 2024).

Notice how the quote gives the exact wording, the paraphrase rewrites it, and the summary at the end ties the whole idea back to the essay's focus on sustainable urban design.

Now you are ready to try it yourself. Choose a short article (about 300■400 words), apply the three techniques, and run your work through the checklist. When each row says **Yes**, you have successfully integrated evidence while keeping your own voice clear and strong. Good luck!

## 5.7 Reflection and Checklist

When you finish a draft, it is easy to feel that the work is complete because the ideas are all on the page.

But a good academic essay does more than just present facts - it shows that you have **chosen** the right evidence, **explained** it in your own voice, and **balanced** it so the reader can see how the evidence supports your argument.

Think of your essay like a sandwich. The bread slices are your own ideas; the fillings are the pieces of evidence you add. If you pile on too much filling, the sandwich becomes messy and hard to bite. If you use only a tiny bit of filling, the sandwich feels dry and unsatisfying. The reflection checklist below helps you taste the sandwich before you serve it to your teacher.

> **Remember:** A checklist is a short list of questions you ask yourself. It works like a quick self■test that catches common problems before you submit your work.

### *Self■assessment checklist for using evidence*

- ✔■ Question - Why it matters
- **1. Have I used at least three different types of evidence (facts, statistics, expert opinion, examples, or anecdotes)?** - Using a mix shows you can draw from many sources and makes your argument stronger.
- **2. Does each quotation include a proper citation and fit naturally into my sentence?** - Proper citations give credit and avoid plagiarism; smooth integration keeps the flow.
- **3. For every quotation, have I added a comment that explains *why* it matters to my point?** - The comment is the "bread" that holds the evidence together; without it the reader does not know its purpose.
- **4. Have I paraphrased or summarized at least as much as I have quoted?** - Paraphrasing shows you understand the source and keeps your own voice dominant.
- **5. Is the total length of quotations less than 30 % of the whole essay?** - Over■quoting can drown out your own analysis; the 30 % rule is a common guideline.
- **6. Did I check that every source is listed correctly in the bibliography?** - A complete bibliography proves you have done the research and lets readers find the original material.
- **7. Have I read the essay aloud to hear whether the evidence feels balanced?** - Reading aloud reveals awkward jumps between your voice and the sources.
- **8. Did I remove any "filler" quotes that repeat the same idea?** - Repeating evidence wastes space and can confuse the reader.

### *How to use the checklist*

- **Print or copy the table** onto a separate sheet of paper.
- **Read each question** carefully after you finish a draft.
- **Mark "yes" or "no"** for each item. If you answer "no," go back to the relevant paragraph and fix it.
- **Count the "yes" answers.** If you have at least 7■8 "yes" responses, your evidence handling is likely solid.

> **In daily life:** Think of the checklist like a grocery list before you shop. You look at the list, see what you already have, and add only the missing items. The same idea works for evidence: you see what you already have and add only what is needed.

### *Spotting over■quoting*

A quick visual cue can help: highlight every block of quoted text in a bright colour. Then, using a ruler or the cursor, count how many lines of your essay are highlighted. If the highlighted portion stretches across more than one■third of the total lines, you probably have too many quotes.

You can also use a simple equation to estimate the balance:

\text{Quote Ratio} = \frac{\text{Number of quoted words}}{\text{Total word count}}

If the Quote Ratio is greater than 0.30, rewrite some quotes as paraphrases or summaries.

### *Final reflection*

Before you click "submit," take a minute to ask yourself:

- **Did I let my own ideas shine through?**
- **Did every piece of evidence have a clear purpose?**
- **Is the essay readable without constantly stopping to check the bibliography?**

If the answer to any of these is "no," use the checklist to guide a quick revision. By treating your draft as a sandwich that you can taste and adjust, you ensure that the final product is both flavorful and well■balanced.

## Terminology at a glance

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Quotation | Exact words taken from a source, placed in quotation marks and cited. |
| Paraphrase | Restating a source's idea in your own words while keeping the original meaning and giving credit. |
| Summary | A brief restatement of the main points of a longer text, using your own words and omitting details. |

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Citation | Information that tells the reader where a quoted, paraphrased, or summarized idea came from. |
| Evidence | Any information - quotes, paraphrases, or summaries - that supports a claim in an essay. |
| Voice | The writer's own style and perspective that should dominate the essay. |
| Balance | Using enough evidence to support a claim without overwhelming the writer's own analysis. |
| Checklist | A short list of questions to review your draft for proper use of evidence and voice. |

### Practical application

Exercise 5.1:

Exercise 5.2:

Exercise 5.3:

Exercise 5.4:

Exercise 5.5:

Exercise 5.6:

### Checklist

- [ ] Identify when to quote, paraphrase, or summarise a source
- [ ] Rewrite a passage in their own words while keeping the original meaning
- [ ] Create a concise summary of a longer text
- [ ] Avoid over■quoting by balancing their own voice with evidence

LESSON 6

# 6. Citing Sources

### Lesson overview

In this lesson students learn how to correctly cite sources using different referencing styles, create in■text citations, and compile a reference list. Mastering these skills ensures their writing is credible and avoids plagiarism.

### Learning outcomes

- Identify the main features of common referencing styles (APA, MLA, Harvard).
- Create correct in■text citations for quotes, paraphrases, and summaries.
- Assemble a properly formatted reference list for a range of source types.
- Apply consistent citation practice throughout an essay.

### 6.1 Why Referencing Matters

When you write an essay, a report, or any piece of academic work, you are building on ideas that already exist.

A **citation** is a short note that tells the reader exactly where you found each idea, fact, or quotation.

> **Definition:** *Citation* - a brief reference in the text that points to a full description of the source in your reference list.

Why do we need these little notes?

- **Give credit where it is due** - Imagine a friend shows you a cool trick in a video game and you later describe the trick to another friend without saying where you learned it. Your first friend would feel ignored, right? In the same way, scholars deserve recognition for the work they have done. By citing, you acknowledge their contribution.
- **Show that your work is trustworthy** - Readers can check the original source to see if you have reported it correctly. If you claim that "the Earth's average temperature rose by 1.2 degreesC in the last decade" without a citation, a skeptical reader has no way to verify that number. Providing a source lets the reader see the evidence for themselves, which makes your argument stronger.
- **Avoid plagiarism** - *Plagiarism* is the act of using someone else's words or ideas and presenting them as your own. It is considered dishonest because it hides the true origin of the information. Academic institutions treat plagiarism as a serious breach of **academic integrity**, which is the principle of being honest and responsible in learning.

> **Note:** *Academic integrity* - the commitment to honesty, fairness, and responsibility in scholarly work.

- **Help others find more information** - A good citation works like a road sign. If a reader is interested in learning more about a topic, the citation points them to the exact book, article, or website where they can continue their research.

### *Everyday comparison*

Think of a recipe you found online. If you bake a cake using that recipe and then tell your friends "I made this amazing cake," you would normally mention where you got the recipe. That way, your friends can look up the original page if they want to try it themselves. The citation in an academic paper works the same way: it tells the reader, "Here is the source of this idea; you can read more if you wish."

### *Consequences of not citing*

- **Loss of marks** - Teachers and examiners often deduct points for missing citations because they cannot be sure the work is original.
- **Academic penalties** - In many schools and universities, plagiarism can lead to a failing grade, a formal warning, or even expulsion.
- **Damaged reputation** - If a published paper is found to have uncited material, the author's credibility suffers, and future publishers may be reluctant to accept their work.

> **Common mistake:** Forgetting to add a citation for a paraphrased idea (re■wording someone's point in your own words). Even if you change the wording, the idea still belongs to the original author and must be cited.

### *Linking citations to integrity*

Academic integrity is not just a rule; it is the foundation of trustworthy knowledge. When everyone cites properly, the whole community can trust that the information shared is reliable and that each contributor receives fair recognition. This creates a cycle: proper citation -> trust -> more collaboration -> better learning.

> **Remember:** Citing is a simple act that protects you, respects others, and keeps the flow of knowledge honest and clear.

In summary, citations are the glue that holds academic work together. They give credit, allow verification, prevent plagiarism, and guide readers to further information. Skipping them harms your grade, your reputation, and the whole scholarly conversation. By understanding why referencing matters, you are already taking the first step toward becoming a responsible and effective writer.

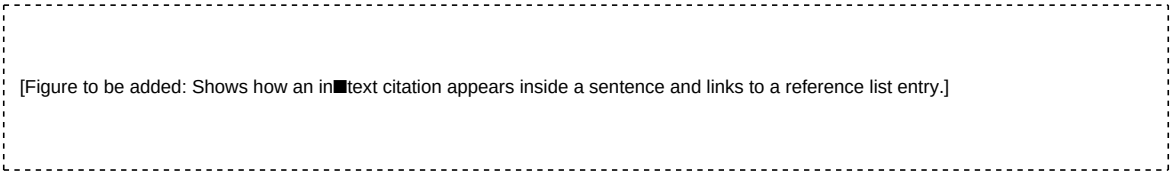



Figure 6.1. Shows how an in■text citation appears inside a sentence and links to a reference list entry.




Figure 6.2. A correctly formatted reference list in APA 7th style.

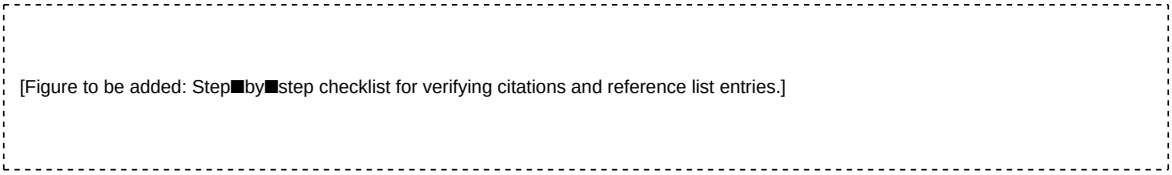



Figure 6.3. Step■by■step checklist for verifying citations and reference list entries.




Figure 6.4. Common Referencing Styles

[Figure to be added: Adding an In■Text Citation]

Figure 6.5. Adding an In■Text Citation

[Figure to be added: Special In■Text Citation Cases]

Figure 6.6. Special In■Text Citation Cases

[Figure to be added: Reference List Components (APA style)]

Figure 6.7. Reference List Components (APA style)

[Figure to be added: Final Checklist for Citations]

Figure 6.8. Final Checklist for Citations

## 6.2 Overview of Common Referencing Styles

When you write an essay, a report, or a research paper you are not working alone.

You are building on ideas that other people have already created.

A *referencing style* is simply a set of rules that tells you how to show where those ideas came from.

Using a consistent style lets readers find the original source quickly, and it shows that you respect other people's work.

### *The three most common styles*

- Style - When you usually see it - How it shows the source in the text
- **APA** (American Psychological Association) - Social sciences, psychology, education - **author■date**: (Smith, 2020)
- **MLA** (Modern Language Association) - Humanities, literature, arts - **author■page**: (Smith 45)
- **Harvard** - Many universities, especially in the UK and Australia - **author■date** (very similar to APA)

All three styles require two things:

- **In■text citation** - a short note inside your paragraph that points to the full reference.
- **Reference list** - a complete list of all sources at the end of your work.

The main visual difference is *what comes after the author's name*.

> **Definition:** *author■date* means you write the author's last name followed by the year of publication, e.g., (Brown 2018).

> **Definition:** *author■page* means you write the author's last name followed by the page number where the information appears, e.g., (Brown 23).

### *Why the two formats exist*

Think of a library.

If you ask the librarian for a book, you might give the **title** (like an author■date citation) or you might give the **shelf number** (like an author■page citation).

Both point to the same book, but the shelf number tells the librarian exactly where to find the specific page you need.

In the **author■date** system, the year tells the reader which version of a work you used. This is useful when a source has many editions or when research moves quickly, as in the sciences.

In the **author■page** system, the page number tells the reader exactly where the quoted or paraphrased idea appears. This is helpful in literature or history, where the exact wording on a page matters.

### *Quick visual comparison*

- **APA**:

In■text: Citation = (Author, Year)

Reference list entry: Author, A. A. (Year). *Title of the work*. Publisher.

- **MLA**:

In■text: Citation = (Author Page)

Works■Cited entry: Author, Firstname. *Title of the Work*. Publisher, Year.

- **Harvard**:

In■text: Citation = (Author, Year)

Reference list entry: Author, A., Year. *Title of the work*. Place of publication: Publisher.

> **Note:** The punctuation around the author, year, and page can differ. APA uses a comma between author and year, while MLA puts a space between author and page number. Harvard usually follows the APA pattern but may vary in the reference list layout.

### *How to choose which style to use*

- **Check the assignment guidelines** - teachers almost always tell you which style they expect.
- **Look at the subject area** - sciences -> APA, humanities -> MLA, many UK courses -> Harvard.
- **Be consistent** - once you pick a style, use it for every citation in that paper. Switching back and forth is a common mistake that confuses readers.

> **Common mistake:** Mixing APA's author■date in■text citations with MLA's author■page reference list. Always keep the whole paper in the same style.

### *Remember the purpose*

The goal of any referencing style is to make the trail from your writing back to the original source as clear as possible.

If a reader sees (Jones, 2015) they can go to the reference list, find Jones's 2015 work, and locate the exact page if needed.

If they see (Jones 78) they know you are pointing to page 78 of Jones's book, which they can look up directly.

> **Remember:** The style you use does not change the quality of your ideas; it only changes how you show where those ideas came from. A clean, consistent citation format lets your arguments shine without distraction.

## 6.3 In■Text Citations: Basics

When you write a paper you are talking to a reader who has never heard your ideas before.

If you use someone else's words or ideas, you must tell the reader **where** those words came from.

That short note inside the sentence is called an *in■text citation*.

> **Definition:** An *in■text citation* is a brief reference placed inside the body of your essay that points the reader to the full details of the source in your reference list.

Why it matters

- It shows respect for the original author's work.
- It lets readers check the source if they want more information.
- It protects you from accusations of plagiarism (using someone's work without credit).

### *The three ways you might use a source*

- **Direct quote** - you copy the exact words, word for word.
- **Paraphrase** - you restate the idea in your own words, keeping the meaning the same.
- **Summary** - you give a short overview of the main point, leaving out details.

All three need a citation, but the format changes slightly depending on the referencing style you are using. Below are the three most common styles: **APA (American Psychological Association)**, **MLA (Modern Language Association)**, and **Harvard**.

### *1. Direct quotes*

**APA** - put the author's last name, the year, and the page number in parentheses after the quote.

> "Learning is a lifelong process" (Smith, 2020, p. 15).

If the author's name is already part of the sentence, only the year and page go in parentheses.

> Smith (2020) writes, "Learning is a lifelong process" (p. 15).

**MLA** - use the author's last name and the page number, no year.

> "Learning is a lifelong process" (Smith 15).

If the author is named in the text, just add the page number.

> Smith argues that "learning is a lifelong process" (15).

**Harvard** - similar to APA but the page number follows a comma after the year.

> "Learning is a lifelong process" (Smith, 2020, p. 15).

### *2. Paraphrasing*

When you restate the idea, you still give credit, but you do not need a page number unless the source is very specific.

**APA** - author and year are enough.

> Smith (2020) suggests that learning continues throughout life.

If the author is not mentioned in the sentence, put both in parentheses.

> Learning continues throughout life (Smith, 2020).

**MLA** - author's name only; page number is optional.

> Smith argues that learning continues throughout life.

**Harvard** - author and year, like APA.

> Smith (2020) argues that learning continues throughout life.

### *3. Summarizing*

A summary condenses a whole chapter or article. The citation works the same as for a paraphrase.

**APA**

> Recent research shows that lifelong learning improves mental health (Jones, 2019).

**MLA**

> Recent research shows that lifelong learning improves mental health (Jones 42).

**Harvard**

> Recent research shows that lifelong learning improves mental health (Jones, 2019).

> **In daily life:** Think of an in■text citation like a quick "thank■you" note you slip into a conversation. You say, "I read that in a book by Dr. Lee," and later you give the full book details.

> **Common mistake:** Forgetting to add the page number for a direct quote. Remember, a quote is a *verbatim* copy, so the reader must know exactly where to find it.

> **Remember:** Every time you quote, paraphrase, or summarize, place a citation **immediately after** the borrowed material, before the period that ends the sentence.

Here is a simple formula you can keep in mind for each style:

\text{Citation} = \begin{cases}

(\text{Author}, \text{Year}, p.\ \text{Page}) & \text{APA / Harvard (quote)}\\[4pt]

(\text{Author}\ \text{Page}) & \text{MLA (quote)}\\[4pt]

(\text{Author}, \text{Year}) & \text{APA / Harvard (paraphrase/summary)}\\[4pt]

(\text{Author}) & \text{MLA (paraphrase/summary)}

\end{cases}

By following these patterns you will give clear credit, help your reader, and keep your work honest.

## 6.4 In■Text Citations: Special Cases

When you quote or paraphrase someone's ideas, you must tell the reader exactly where those ideas came from. This is called an **in■text citation**. Most of the time the citation is simple: (Smith 2020) or (Smith & Jones, 2020). But sometimes the source does not fit the usual pattern. Below are the special situations you may meet and how to handle each one correctly.

> **Definition:** *In■text citation* - a brief note inside the sentence that points the reader to the full reference in the reference list.

### *1. More than three authors*

If a work has **two** authors, list both every time: (Brown & Lee, 2019).

If a work has **three or more** authors, you do **not** write every name after the first mention. Instead use the first author's surname followed by "et al.", which is short for the Latin *et alii* meaning "and others".

Example:

- First citation: (Garcia, Patel, & Nguyen, 2021) - you can write all three if you wish.
- Later citations: (Garcia *et al.*, 2021).

Why? It keeps the text tidy and avoids long strings of names that distract the reader.

> **In daily life:** Think of a group project where you introduce the team once ("Alice, Bob, and Charlie worked on the experiment"). After that you just say "the team" instead of naming everyone again.

### *2. No author listed*

Sometimes a source, such as a webpage or a report, does not give a personal author. Use the **title** of the work instead. If the title is long, you can shorten it to the first few words, put it in quotation marks, and add the year.

Example:

- Full title: *Global Climate Change: Impacts and Solutions* (2022).
- In■text citation: ("Global Climate Change," 2022).

If the source is a **periodical** (like a newspaper) and the title is very short, you can use the **first few words** without quotation marks, but keep the year.

> **Note:** Always keep the same shortened title throughout the paper so the reader can match it to the reference list.

### *3. Corporate author*

When an organization, government agency, or company writes a document, the organization itself is the author. Write the full name of the organization in the citation.

Example:

- (World Health Organization, 2020)
- (National Aeronautics and Space Administration, 2018)

If the corporate name is very long and you will cite it many times, you may introduce an abbreviation the first time:

> **Definition:** *Abbreviation* - a shortened form of a longer name, introduced once and then used thereafter.

First citation: (National Aeronautics and Space Administration **[NASA]**, 2018)

Later citations: (NASA, 2018)

This mirrors how we often use nicknames for people we know well.

#### *4. Secondary citations (citing a source you found inside another source)*

Sometimes you read a useful idea in a book, but the original research is in an older article you do not have. You can still give credit, but you must show both the original author and the source you actually consulted. Write the original author's name and year, then add "as cited in" followed by the author and year of the source you read.

Example:

- Original: Miller (1975) argued that...
- You read it in: Johnson (2020).

In■text citation: (Miller, 1975, *as cited in* Johnson, 2020)

Why is this useful? It tells the reader that the idea originated with Miller, while also being honest that you did not examine Miller's work directly.

> **Common mistake:** Listing only the secondary source (Johnson, 2020) and pretending you read Miller's article. This can mislead readers and is considered poor academic practice.

#### *Putting the rules together*

When you write a sentence with a special case, follow these steps:

- Identify the type of source (multiple authors, no author, corporate author, secondary).
- Choose the correct format (surname et al., title, organization name, or "as cited in").
- Insert the year immediately after the name or title, separated by a comma.
- Keep the punctuation consistent: always use parentheses and separate multiple items with commas.

For example:

> "Recent climate models show faster warming trends (Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change, 2023)."

If the same report has three authors, you would write:

> "Recent climate models show faster warming trends (IPCC *et al.*, 2023)."

#### *Quick checklist*

- **Two authors:** list both each time.
- **Three or more:** first author + *et al.* after first full citation.
- **No author:** use shortened title in quotes.
- **Corporate author:** write full organization name; introduce abbreviation if needed.
- **Secondary citation:** original author *as cited in* secondary source.

> **Remember:** Consistency is key. Once you pick a style for a special case, use it the same way throughout your paper so the reader can easily follow your sources.

## 6.5 Building a Reference List

When you finish an essay, the **reference list** (sometimes called a bibliography) is the place where you give full details of every source you mentioned in the text.

Think of it like the "ingredients list" on a food package: just as a shopper can see exactly what went into the product, a reader can see exactly what you used to build your argument.

### *1. General rules for the whole list*

- **Order** - Arrange the entries alphabetically by the surname (last name) of the first author. If a source has no author, start with the title (ignore the word *The* or *A*).
- **Spacing** - Use a hanging indent: the first line of each entry is flush left, and any following lines are indented half an inch. This makes each entry easy to scan.
- **Punctuation** - Most styles separate the main parts of a citation with commas, and end the whole entry with a period.
- **Font** - Keep the same font and size you used in the essay (usually 12■point Times New Roman or Arial).

> **Remember:** Consistency is key. Pick one referencing style (e.g., APA, Harvard, Chicago) and apply its rules to every entry.

### *2. Books*

A typical book entry contains: author(s), year, title (italicised), edition (if not the first), place of publication, and publisher.

Smith, J. (2020). *Understanding Climate Change* (2nd ed.). London: Green Earth Press.

- **Author(s)** - List surname first, then initials. Use an ampersand (&) before the last author if there are multiple.
- **Year** - Put the year in parentheses right after the author(s).
- **Title** - Italicise the whole title; only the first word and proper nouns are capitalised (sentence case).
- **Edition** - Include only if it is not the first edition; write "2nd ed.", "3rd ed.", etc.
- **Place & Publisher** - Separate the city and the publisher with a colon.

### *3. Journal articles*

Journal articles need the article title, journal title, volume, issue, page range, and DOI (digital object identifier) if available.

Lee, A., & Patel, R. (2019). Social media and teenage anxiety. *Journal of Youth Studies*, 15(3), 210■225. https://doi.org/10.1080/13676261.2019.1601234

- **Journal title** - Italicise and use title case (capitalize major words).
- **Volume** - Italicise the volume number.
- **Issue** - Put the issue number in parentheses, not italicised.
- **Pages** - Use an en■dash (■) between the first and last page.
- **DOI** - A permanent link; start with "https://doi.org/". If no DOI, you may give the URL of the journal's homepage.

### *4. Websites*

Web sources often lack some of the details required for books or journals, so you include what you have: author (if known), year (or "n.d." for no date), title of the page, website name, and the full URL. Add the date you accessed the page if the content might change.

World Health Organization. (2022). Nutrition and health guidelines. WHO. https://www.who.int/nutrition/guidelines (accessed 10 Oct 2023)

- **Author** - If the organization is the author, write its full name.
- **Year** - Use the year the page was published or updated; if none, write "n.d." (no date).
- **Title** - Sentence case, not italicised.
- **Website name** - Usually the organization or the site's title; italicise if the style requires it.
- **URL** - Provide the complete web address; do not add a period after it to avoid confusion.

### *5. Other common sources*

- Source type - Typical elements - Example
- **Edited book chapter** - Author of chapter, year, chapter title, *In* editor(s) (Eds.), book title, pages, publisher - Brown, L. (2018). Climate policy in Europe. *In* M. Green & S. White (Eds.), *Environmental Law* (pp. 45■68). New York: Legal Press.
- **Conference paper** - Author, year, paper title, *In* conference name, location, pages - Kumar, S. (2021). AI in education. *In* Proceedings of the International Conference on Learning Technologies, Berlin, 112■119.
- **Report (government or NGO)** - Author/agency, year, title (italicised), report number (if any), publisher, URL - Department for Education. (2020). *Annual school performance report* (Report No. 2020■05). London: DfE. https://www.education.gov.uk/report2020

> **In daily life:** A reference list works like a "contact list" on your phone - it lets anyone quickly find the exact source you used, just as a phone number lets you call a friend.

### *6. Putting it together*

- Gather all sources you cited.

- Write each entry following the pattern for its type.
- Sort the list alphabetically.
- Apply the hanging indent and check punctuation.

> **Common mistake:** Forgetting the hanging indent makes the list look like a paragraph, which hides where one source ends and the next begins.

Finally, give the whole list a clear heading such as **References** or **Bibliography** (depending on the style) and place it on a new page after the main text. This tidy, consistent list shows respect for the original authors and helps your readers trust the quality of your work.

## 6.6 Putting It All Together

Imagine you have written a short paragraph about climate change and you now need to show where the ideas came from.

Below we will take a plain paragraph, add the correct **in■text citations**, and then create a **reference list** that matches the citations.

We will use the **APA 7th** style because it is common in many school subjects, but the same steps work for other styles - you only change the punctuation and order.

### *1. The original paragraph (no citations)*

> Climate change is causing more extreme weather events, such as heatwaves and heavy rainfall.

> Scientists say that the increase in greenhouse gases from human activities is the main driver of global warming.

> Reducing carbon emissions can limit future damage, but it requires cooperation from governments, businesses, and individuals.

### *2. Identify the sources you used*

- Idea in the paragraph - Source you will cite
- "more extreme weather events ... heatwaves and heavy rainfall" - IPCC, 2021 report
- "increase in greenhouse gases ... main driver of global warming" - NASA, 2022 climate overview
- "Reducing carbon emissions can limit future damage" - Smith & Lee, 2020 study on mitigation

> **Remember:** Write down every fact, statistic, or idea that is not your own. This makes it easy to add citations later.

### *3. Add in■text citations*

In APA style, an in■text citation includes the author's last name(s) and the year of publication, placed in parentheses right after the relevant sentence.

> Climate change is causing more extreme weather events, such as heatwaves and heavy rainfall (IPCC, 2021).

> Scientists say that the increase in greenhouse gases from human activities is the main driver of global warming (NASA, 2022).

> Reducing carbon emissions can limit future damage, but it requires cooperation from governments, businesses, and individuals (Smith & Lee, 2020).

> **Definition:** *In■text citation* - a brief reference inside the paragraph that points the reader to the full source in the reference list.

### *4. Build the reference list*

The reference list appears at the end of the essay on a new page titled **References**.

Each entry must contain enough information for a reader to locate the source. In APA, the order is: Author(s). (Year). *Title of work*. Publisher or journal, volume(issue), pages. DOI or URL if available.

Here are the three entries that match our citations:

References

Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change. (2021). *Climate Change 2021: The Physical Science Basis*. https://www.ipcc.ch/report/ar6/wg1/

National Aeronautics and Space Administration. (2022). *Climate change: How do we know?* https://climate.nasa.gov/evidence/

Smith, J., & Lee, R. (2020). Mitigation strategies to limit global warming. *Journal of Environmental Policy*, 15(3), 45■58. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jep.2020.01.004

> **Note:** The reference list is **alphabetical** by the first author's last name, not by the order you cited them in the text.

### *5. Put everything together*

Now copy the paragraph with citations, add a blank line, write **References**, and list the three entries exactly as shown. The final excerpt looks like this:

> Climate change is causing more extreme weather events, such as heatwaves and heavy rainfall (IPCC, 2021).

> Scientists say that the increase in greenhouse gases from human activities is the main driver of global warming (NASA, 2022).

> Reducing carbon emissions can limit future damage, but it requires cooperation from governments, businesses, and individuals (Smith & Lee, 2020).

> References

> Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change. (2021). *Climate Change 2021: The Physical Science Basis*. https://www.ipcc.ch/report/ar6/wg1/

> National Aeronautics and Space Administration. (2022). *Climate change: How do we know?* https://climate.nasa.gov/evidence/

> Smith, J., & Lee, R. (2020). Mitigation strategies to limit global warming. *Journal of Environmental Policy*, 15(3), 45■58. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jep.2020.01.004

> **In daily life:** Adding citations is like putting a label on a borrowed book. The label tells others where the book came from, so they can find it again if they want.

### *6. Quick checklist before you submit*

- Every claim that is not common knowledge has a citation.
- All citations in the text appear **once** in the reference list.
- The reference list is alphabetised and uses the correct punctuation for the chosen style.
- Font, spacing, and indentation follow the style guide (APA uses a hanging indent of 0.5 in).

Follow these steps for any short essay, and you will turn a plain paragraph into a properly referenced piece of academic writing.

## 6.7 Checking Your Work

When you finish writing a paper, the last thing you should do is **check** it.

Checking is like proofreading a road map before you hand it to a driver - you want to be sure every street name is spelled correctly, the symbols are clear, and there are no missing turns that could cause a crash. In academic writing, the "roads" are your citations and reference list. A careful check makes sure the reader can follow your trail of evidence without getting lost.

### *Step■by■step checklist*

- **Match every in■text citation to a reference entry**
- Scan the text from the beginning to the end. Each time you see a citation (e.g., (Smith 2020) or [1]), write down the author's name or number.
- Then go to the reference list and verify that the same author and year (or number) appear there.
- If you find a citation that has no matching entry, add it. If an entry has no citation in the text, delete it.
- **Check the order and format of the reference list**
- Different styles have different rules. For example, APA orders references alphabetically by the first author's last name, while Vancouver orders them numerically in the order they appear in the text.

- Make sure the list follows the rule for the style you are using.
- Look at each entry: are the author names, year, title, journal, volume, issue, and page numbers all present and in the right places?
- **Verify punctuation and spacing**
- Small marks such as commas, periods, and brackets can change the meaning of a citation.
- In APA, a typical journal article looks like:

Author, A. A., & Author, B. B. (Year). Title of article. *Journal Name*, 12(3), 45-67.

- Notice the period after the year, the italicised journal name, the comma after the volume number, and the en■dash between page numbers.
- Compare each entry to a reliable example from your style guide and correct any differences.
- **Watch out for common typographical errors**
- Misspelling an author's name or a journal title can make it impossible for a reader to locate the source.
- Double■check capitalisation: only the first word of a article title and proper nouns are capitalised in APA, while all major words are capitalised in MLA.
- **Confirm consistency of abbreviations and abbreviations**
- If you abbreviate a journal name (e.g., *J. Biol. Chem.*), use the same abbreviation everywhere.
- Do not mix full names and abbreviations in the same list.
- **Check that you have used the correct citation style throughout**
- It is easy to start with one style and slip into another, especially if you copy a reference from a source that uses a different format.
- Look at the first ten entries; if they all follow the same pattern, the rest likely do too.
- **Run a final spell■check and grammar check**
- Most word processors have built■in tools. They will not catch every citation error, but they will catch stray commas, missing periods, and other simple mistakes.

> **Note:** A consistent reference list is not just about looking tidy; it shows that you respect the work of other scholars and helps readers verify your claims.

> **Common mistake:** Forgetting to update the reference list after adding or deleting a citation in the text. This creates "orphan" entries that confuse readers and may be marked as plagiarism.

> **Remember:** Treat your reference list like a grocery receipt - every item you mention in the text must appear on the list, and every item on the list must have been bought (cited) in the text.

### *Quick self■test*

- **All citations present?** Tick each citation and match it to the list.
- **All entries used?** Cross■out any reference that has no citation.
- **Style correct?** Compare a sample entry to the official style guide.
- **Punctuation right?** Look for missing commas, periods, or italics.
- **Spelling checked?** Verify author names and journal titles.

If you can answer "yes" to every question, your paper's citations are ready for submission. Just like a driver checks the mirrors before leaving the garage, a writer checks the citations before handing in the work. This final step protects your credibility and makes your research easy for others to follow.

## Terminology at a glance

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Citation | A brief note in the text that points to a full source description in the reference list. |
| In■text citation | A short reference placed inside a sentence showing where an idea or quote came from. |
| Reference list | A list at the end of a work giving full details of all sources cited. |
| Paraphrase | Restating someone else's idea in your own words while keeping the meaning. |
| Summary | Condensing the main points of a source into a brief overview in your own words. |
| et al. | Latin abbreviation meaning "and others", used when a source has three or more authors. |

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Hanging indent | Formatting style where the first line of a reference is flush left and subsequent lines are indented. |
| Plagiarism | Using someone else's work or ideas without giving proper credit. |

### Practical application

Exercise 6.1:

Exercise 6.2:

Exercise 6.3:

Exercise 6.4:

Exercise 6.5:

Exercise 6.6:

### Checklist

[ ] Identify the main features of common referencing styles (APA, MLA, Harvard).

[ ] Create correct in■text citations for quotes, paraphrases, and summaries.

[ ] Assemble a properly formatted reference list for a range of source types.

[ ] Apply consistent citation practice throughout an essay.

LESSON 7

# 7. Avoiding Plagiarism

### Lesson overview

In this lesson students learn what actions count as plagiarism and how to paraphrase sources correctly. They will practice turning information into their own words while giving proper credit.

### Learning outcomes

- Identify different forms of plagiarism
- Explain why proper citation matters
- Paraphrase a short passage without copying the original wording
- Create a reference list entry for a paraphrased source

### 7.1 What Is Plagiarism?

Plagiarism is when you take someone else's words, ideas, or work and present them as if they were your own, without giving proper credit.

It is essentially a form of copying that hides the true source of the material.

> **Definition:** Plagiarism = using another person's text, ideas, data, or creative work without acknowledging the original author.

Why does this matter? In school and later in any research or professional setting, honesty about where information comes from is the foundation of trustworthy communication. If you claim another's work as yours, readers cannot know whether the ideas are original or borrowed, and the original creator does not receive the recognition they deserve.

Think of it like borrowing a friend's bike. If you ride the bike home and then tell people the bike is yours, you are hiding the fact that it belongs to someone else. The bike still works, but the story you tell about it is false. In academic writing, the "bike" is the information or wording you use.

**Key parts of plagiarism**

- **Copying text word■for■word** - taking a sentence or paragraph exactly as it appears in a source and inserting it into your work without quotation marks and a citation.
- **Using ideas without credit** - even if you rewrite the words, the underlying concept may still belong to the original author. If you do not mention where the idea came from, you are still plagiarising.
- **Presenting others' work as your own** - submitting a report, essay, or project that someone else wrote (or that you bought online) and signing it with your name.

> **In daily life:** Imagine you find a recipe online, copy the whole list of steps into your own cookbook, and put your name on the cover without saying who originally created the dish. That is plagiarism of the recipe's text and ideas.

Plagiarism can be **intentional** (you know you are copying and do it on purpose) or **unintentional** (you forget to cite, or you think re■phrasing is enough). Both are taken seriously because the result - misleading the reader - is the same.

**How to recognise plagiarism**

- Look for any passage that sounds too polished or uses vocabulary that does not match the rest of your writing.
- Check whether you have a citation for every fact, statistic, or specific claim that is not common knowledge.
- Ask yourself: "Did I write this myself, or did I borrow it from somewhere?" If the answer is "borrowed," you must give credit.

> **Note:** Common knowledge (e.g., "Water freezes at 0 degreesC") does not need a citation, but any specific study result, unique theory, or exact wording does.

**Why it is a problem for you**

- **Academic consequences:** Schools may give a zero on the assignment, place you on academic■integrity probation, or even expel you for repeated offenses.
- **Loss of trust:** Teachers, peers, and future employers may doubt the authenticity of any work you produce.
- **Stifled learning:** When you copy instead of thinking through the material, you miss the chance to understand and develop your own ideas.

> **Remember:** Giving credit does not make your work weaker; it shows you have done research, respect others' contributions, and can integrate multiple sources into a coherent argument.

In short, plagiarism is the act of presenting someone else's intellectual property as your own. It includes copying exact words, borrowing ideas, or submitting another person's complete work without acknowledgement. Recognising and avoiding it is the first step toward honest, effective academic writing.

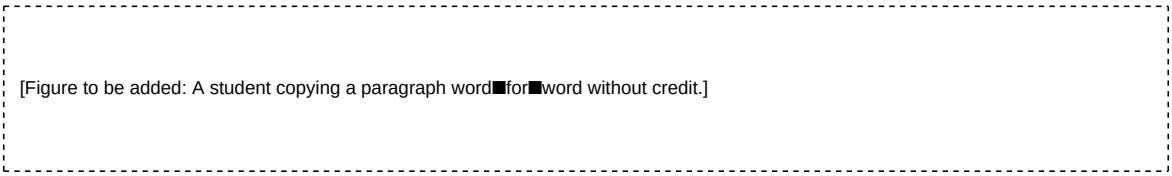



Figure 7.1. A student copying a paragraph word■for■word without credit.

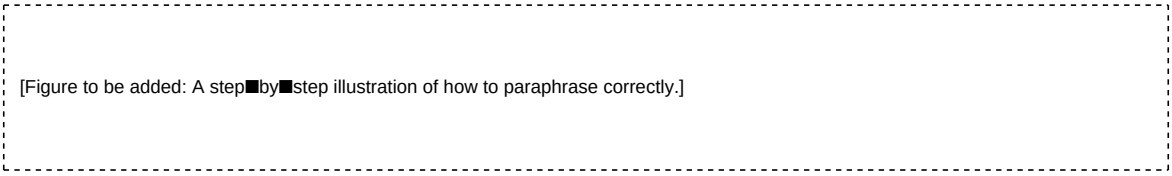



Figure 7.2. A step■by■step illustration of how to paraphrase correctly.

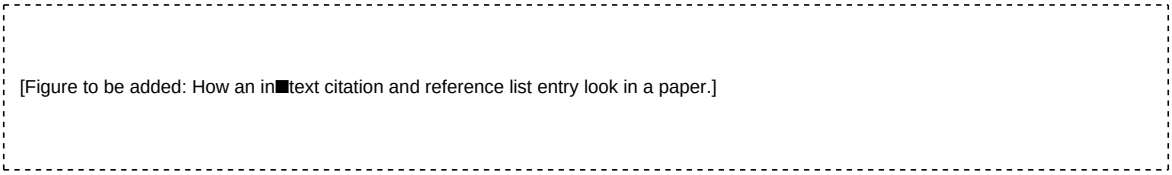



Figure 7.3. How an in■text citation and reference list entry look in a paper.




Figure 7.4. How to Paraphrase Correctly




Figure 7.5. Plagiarism vs. Proper Citation




Figure 7.6. Components of a Citation




Figure 7.7. Avoiding Common Mistakes

## 7.2 Why Plagiarism Is a Problem

Plagiarism is more than just copying someone else's words; it is a breach of trust that hurts the student, the teacher, and the whole learning community.

When you present another person's ideas as your own, you are saying that you created something you did not. This false claim creates several problems that can be grouped into three areas: ethical, academic, and legal.

**Ethical consequences** deal with right■and■wrong. In everyday life we value honesty. If you tell a friend you built a model airplane when you actually bought it ready■made, the friend will feel deceived when the truth comes out. The same feeling of betrayal happens in school when a teacher discovers that a paper contains plagiarised sections. The teacher's trust is broken, and classmates may feel that the dishonest student has an unfair advantage. Trust is the glue that holds a classroom together; plagiarism weakens that glue.

**Academic consequences** affect grades, reputation, and future opportunities. Most schools have rules that treat plagiarism as a serious offense. If a teacher finds copied text, the typical penalties are:

- A lower grade on the assignment, often zero for the plagiarised part.
- A mark on the student's record that may appear on transcripts.
- In severe cases, suspension or expulsion.

These penalties are not meant to punish arbitrarily; they protect the integrity of the learning process. When a student copies instead of thinking, the student misses the chance to practice critical skills such as analysis, synthesis, and original writing. Learning is like exercising a muscle: if you never use it, it does not grow. Plagiarism stops that growth.

**Legal consequences** arise because many ideas, words, and images are protected by copyright law. Copyright gives the creator the exclusive right to reproduce, distribute, or display their work. If you copy a paragraph from a published article without permission or citation, you are infringing that right. The law can impose fines, and in extreme cases, lawsuits. While most schools handle plagiarism internally, the same act could lead to legal action if the original author decides to protect their work.

> **Note:** *Integrity* means being honest and having strong moral principles. In academic work, integrity means always giving credit where it is due.

Beyond these direct consequences, plagiarism undermines the very purpose of education: learning. When you copy, you bypass the mental effort required to understand the material. Imagine trying to learn to ride a bike by watching a video and then immediately claiming you can ride without ever getting on the bike. You may look confident, but you lack the skill to balance, steer, or stop safely. Similarly, a plagiarised essay may look impressive, but the writer has not developed the ability to think critically, organise ideas, or argue persuasively.

> **In daily life:** Think of plagiarism like using someone else's recipe without saying who created it. The dish may taste good, but you never learned how the flavors work together, and the original chef does not receive recognition.

The ripple effect of plagiarism can also damage the reputation of the institution. Universities and schools are judged by the quality and originality of their research. If many students plagiarise, the institution may lose credibility, making it harder for graduates to be trusted by employers or other schools.

> **Remember:** Plagiarism is not just "getting caught"; it is a shortcut that steals learning, harms trust, and can lead to serious penalties.

To avoid these problems, always treat sources as you would treat a friend's hard■won ideas: give them credit, understand them fully, and then express them in your own words. This habit builds both knowledge and character, preparing you for success far beyond the classroom.

## 7.3 Key Principles of Proper Paraphrasing

When you paraphrase, you are not just swapping a few words for synonyms.

You are showing that you have **read** the original, **understood** its meaning, and can **rewrite** the idea in a way that sounds like your own voice. Finally, you must **cite** the source so the reader knows where the idea came from.

> **Definition:** *Paraphrasing* means expressing someone else's ideas in your own words and sentence structure while keeping the original meaning.

#### *1. Read the passage carefully*

Start by reading the source sentence or paragraph slowly, maybe more than once. Ask yourself: *What is the main point?* If a word is unclear, look it up. This step is like listening to a song before you try to hum the tune - you need the whole melody before you can create your own version.

#### *2. Make sure you understand it*

After the first read, close the text and try to explain the idea out loud or in a quick note, using plain language. If you can tell a friend what the author meant without looking at the original, you have understood it. Understanding is the foundation; without it, any rewrite will be inaccurate.

> **In daily life:** Think of a recipe you read online. Before you copy it, you first read the steps, then picture how you would actually cook the dish. Only after you know the process do you write your own version of the recipe.

#### *3. Rewrite in your own words and structure*

Now take the idea and express it anew. Change **both** the wording *and* the sentence structure. Here are two simple techniques:

- **Swap the order of information.** If the original says, "The experiment showed that temperature rises when pressure increases," you could write, "When pressure goes up, the temperature also climbs, as the experiment demonstrated."
- **Use a different grammatical form.** Turn a passive sentence into an active one, or replace a noun phrase with a verb phrase. For example, change "The results were analyzed by the researchers" to "The researchers analyzed the results."

Avoid the temptation to replace only a few words with synonyms; that often leaves the sentence looking too similar to the source.

#### *4. Cite the source immediately*

After you have finished your rewritten sentence, add a citation in the style your teacher requires (APA, MLA, Chicago, etc.). The citation tells the reader that the idea is not originally yours, even though the wording is.

> **Remember:** Even a perfect paraphrase must include a citation. The citation is the "thank■you note" to the original author.

#### *Why each step matters*

- **Reading** ensures you do not miss subtle qualifiers (like "usually" or "under certain conditions") that could change the meaning.
- **Understanding** prevents you from unintentionally adding or omitting information.
- **Rewriting** both words and structure shows genuine intellectual effort and avoids accidental plagiarism.
- **Citing** gives credit and lets readers trace the original work if they want more detail.

#### *Quick checklist before you submit*

- Have I read the original more than once?
- Can I explain the idea without looking at the text?
- Does my version use different words *and* a different sentence pattern?
- Is a proper citation attached right after the paraphrase?

If you can answer "yes" to all four questions, your paraphrase is likely safe and scholarly.

> **Common mistake:** Changing only a few words while keeping the same sentence order. This still looks too much like the source and can be flagged as plagiarism.

By following these four steps - read, understand, rewrite, cite - you turn someone else's insight into a contribution that fits smoothly into your own writing, while respecting the original author's work.

## 7.4 How to Paraphrase Effectively

When you paraphrase, you are **re■writing someone else's ideas in your own words** while keeping the original meaning. Think of it like retelling a story you heard from a friend: you can change the words you use, the order you tell the events, and even combine a few short sentences into one longer one, but the plot must stay the same.

Below is a step■by■step method you can follow each time you need to paraphrase a paragraph from a source. Follow the steps in order; skipping a step often leads to accidental plagiarism.

- **Read the original passage carefully**

Read it at least twice. The first reading gives you a general sense of the idea; the second helps you notice details such as cause■effect relationships, examples, or numbers.

- **Cover the source and write a short summary from memory**

Put the text out of sight and try to explain the main point in one or two sentences using your own voice. If you can do this, you have understood the meaning, which is the foundation of a good paraphrase.

- **Identify key terms that must stay unchanged**

Some words are technical or proper nouns (e.g., "photosynthesis," "World Health Organization"). Keep these exactly as they appear, but you can still change the surrounding wording.

- **Replace words with synonyms**

Look for everyday synonyms for the remaining words. Use a thesaurus, but be careful: not every synonym fits the same context. For example, "increase" can become "rise," but "increase" in a scientific sense may be better kept as "grow."

- **Alter the order of ideas**

Change the sequence in which the ideas appear, as long as the logical flow remains clear. If the original says, "First the plant absorbs light; then it converts the energy," you could write, "The conversion of energy follows the plant's absorption of light."

- **Combine or split sentences**

Short sentences can be merged to improve readability, and long sentences can be broken up if that makes the meaning clearer. For instance, "The experiment was costly. It lasted three months." can become, "The three■month experiment was costly."

- **Check that the meaning is unchanged**

Compare your version with the original (still visible). Ask yourself: *Did I keep the same facts, relationships, and emphasis?* If any detail is missing or altered, revise.

- **Add a citation**

Even though you have used your own words, the ideas belong to the original author. Place an in■text citation right after the paraphrase, following the style your teacher requires (APA, MLA, etc.).

> **Note:** A good paraphrase is not just a list of synonyms. It shows you have processed the information and can express it in a new structure while preserving the original intent.

> **In daily life:** Imagine you are explaining a recipe you read online to a friend. You wouldn't repeat the exact wording; you'd say, "First, whisk the eggs, then fold in the flour," perhaps swapping "whisk" for "beat" and rearranging the steps to match how you actually work in the kitchen. That is paraphrasing in action.

> **Common mistake:** Changing only a few words (e.g., "big" -> "large") while keeping the sentence order and structure is still plagiarism. The text is too close to the source and shows you did not truly re■express the idea.

> **Remember:** After you finish, read your paraphrase aloud. If it sounds like something you might have written yourself, you have likely succeeded. If it still sounds like the original, go back and adjust synonyms, order, or sentence structure.

By practicing these eight steps, you will develop a reliable habit of creating original■sounding paraphrases that respect the author's work and keep your own writing clear and honest.

## 7.5 Citing Paraphrased Material

When you rewrite someone else's ideas in your own words, you are still using that person's work.

To show that you are being honest, you must **cite** the source - both right after the paraphrase (an *in■text citation*) and again at the end of your paper in the *reference list*.

> **Definition:** *In■text citation* - a brief note placed inside the sentence that tells the reader where the paraphrased idea came from.

> **Definition:** *Reference list* - a full list of all sources you cited, placed at the end of your essay or article.

***Step■by■step: Adding an in■text citation***

- **Read the original passage.** Make sure you understand the main point.
- **Write the paraphrase.** Use your own sentence structure and vocabulary, but keep the original meaning.
- **Insert the citation immediately after the paraphrase.**
- In most styles (APA, MLA, Chicago), the citation includes the author's last name and the year of publication, or the author and page number, depending on the style.
- Example in APA style:

*Original*: "Climate change is accelerating the melting of polar ice caps, leading to rising sea levels" (Smith, 2020, p. 45).

*Paraphrase*: Recent research shows that warming temperatures are causing the polar ice to melt faster, which in turn raises ocean levels. **(Smith, 2020)**

- Notice that the citation **(Smith, 2020)** comes right after the paraphrased sentence, before the period. This tells the reader that the whole sentence is based on Smith's 2020 work.
- **If you mention the author in the sentence, you only need the year.**

*Paraphrase*: Smith (2020) argues that the rapid loss of polar ice is a direct result of global warming.

Here the author's name is already part of the sentence, so the citation is just the year.

> **In daily life:** Think of a recipe you borrowed from a friend. You might change the wording of the steps, but you still write "Recipe from Alex, 2023" at the top so Alex gets credit.

### *Step■by■step: Adding the source to the reference list*

The reference list gives all the details a reader needs to locate the source themselves. The exact format depends on the citation style you are using. Below are two common examples.

### *APA (7th edition) - journal article*

Smith, J. A. (2020). The impact of climate change on polar ice melt. *Journal of Environmental Studies*, 15(3), 40■55. https://doi.org/10.1234/jes.2020.0153

### *MLA (9th edition) - book*

Smith, John A. *The Impact of Climate Change on Polar Ice Melt*. Green Earth Press, 2020.

Place the reference entry on a new line, double■spaced, with a hanging indent (the second and later lines are indented). The list is alphabetized by the author's last name.

> **Remember:** Every in■text citation must have a matching entry in the reference list, and every reference list entry must be cited somewhere in the text. Missing one or the other is considered plagiarism.

### *Why this matters*

- **Transparency:** Readers can see where each idea originated, which builds trust.
- **Academic integrity:** Proper citation prevents accusations of stealing ideas.
- **Research trail:** Future students can follow your citations to learn more about the topic.

### *Quick checklist for citing a paraphrase*

- [ ] Have I changed the wording and sentence structure enough to make it my own?
- [ ] Did I place the in■text citation **immediately after** the paraphrased sentence?
- [ ] Does the citation match the style guide (author, year, page number if required)?
- [ ] Is the full source listed in the reference list with the correct format?
- [ ] Is the reference list entry alphabetized and properly indented?

Following these small steps ensures that even when you put ideas into your own words, you give proper credit and keep your writing honest and credible.

## 7.6 Common Mistakes to Avoid

When you try to rewrite someone else's ideas, it is easy to slip into habits that still count as plagiarism. Below are the most common traps, why they matter, and how to keep your writing clean.

**Common mistake:** *Copying too closely*

If you change only a few words or rearrange the order of a sentence, the result is still too similar to the original. Imagine you are copying a recipe: you might replace "mix" with "stir" and "bake" with "cook," but you keep the exact list of ingredients and the same step■by■step order. A reader could still recognise the original recipe, and the chef who created it would not get credit. In academic writing the same idea applies - the structure and wording of the source must be transformed enough that it becomes your own expression, while still giving credit

to the original author.

**Remember:** *Paraphrase, don't just swap synonyms*

A good paraphrase does three things:

- Reads the source carefully and understands the main point.
- Writes the idea in your own words and sentence structure.
- Adds a citation that points to the original work.

If you only replace words with synonyms, you are likely to keep the same sentence pattern, which is still considered plagiarism. For example, the original sentence "Climate change accelerates the melting of polar ice caps" could be turned into "The warming of the planet speeds up the melting of the Arctic ice sheets." Here we have changed both the wording and the order, showing we have processed the information.

**Common mistake:** *Forgetting to cite paraphrased material*

Even when you have rewritten the idea completely, you must still tell the reader where the idea came from. Think of a map: the road you travel may be different from the one drawn by the cartographer, but you still need to label the map so others know whose map you used. In a paper, the citation is that label. If you omit it, readers may think the idea is yours, which is dishonest and can lead to accusations of plagiarism.

**In daily life:** *Over■reliance on quotations*

Quotations are useful when the original wording is especially clear, powerful, or historically important. However, filling a paper with long quotes can make it look like a collage of other people's words rather than your own argument. It is like decorating a room with many pictures but never adding any furniture of your own - the space feels empty of personal contribution. Use quotes sparingly, and always surround them with your own analysis.

**Note:** *Mixing sources without clear attribution*

When you combine information from several sources in one paragraph, it is easy to lose track of which idea belongs to which author. This can lead to "source blending," where the reader cannot tell the origin of each claim. To avoid this, insert a brief citation after each distinct idea, or use a signal phrase such as "According to Smith (2020)..." before the paraphrase. This keeps the trail of evidence clear.

**Common mistake:** *Assuming that a bibliography alone is enough*

A bibliography lists all the works you consulted, but it does not replace in■text citations. It is like a grocery list at the end of a recipe book - it tells you what you bought, but not which ingredient was used in which dish. Each paraphrase or quote needs an in■text citation at the point where the idea appears, so the reader can match the claim to the correct source.

**Remember:** *Check your work with a plagiarism detector*

Even after you think you have paraphrased correctly, a plagiarism■checking tool can highlight any passages that are still too similar to the source. Treat the report as a safety net, not a substitute for careful writing. If the tool flags a sentence, rewrite it again in your own voice and add the proper citation.

By watching out for these pitfalls - too■close paraphrasing, missing citations, over■quoting, mixing sources without attribution, and relying only on a bibliography - you will keep your academic writing honest and credible. Each step may feel slow at first, but with practice it becomes a natural part of the research process, just like checking your work before turning in a math assignment.

## 7.7 Practice Activity

You will work with a short paragraph taken from a textbook about climate change.

Your task is to **rewrite the paragraph in your own words** (that is, paraphrase it) and then **add a correct citation** that shows where the original idea came from.

Below is the original paragraph. Read it carefully, then follow the steps that come after it.

> *"The concentration of carbon dioxide (CO■) in the Earth's atmosphere has risen dramatically since the Industrial Revolution. This increase is primarily due to the burning of fossil fuels such as coal, oil, and natural gas, which release CO■ when they are combusted. Higher CO■ levels trap more heat in the atmosphere, leading to a rise in global average temperatures, a phenomenon known as the greenhouse effect."*

### *Step■by■step guide*

- **Identify the main ideas**
- CO■ levels have gone up a lot since the Industrial Revolution.
- The rise is mainly because we burn fossil fuels (coal, oil, natural gas).
- More CO■ means more heat is trapped, causing global temperatures to rise (the greenhouse effect).
- **Replace the words with synonyms**

Find different words that mean the same thing. For example, "concentration" can become "amount," "dramatically" can become "sharply," and "combusted" can become "burned."

- **Change the sentence structure**
- You can split a long sentence into two shorter ones.
- You can combine two short sentences into one, using a connector like "because" or "which means that."
- **Keep the meaning exact**

Do not add new facts or leave out any of the points listed in step 1. Your version must still say that CO■ has increased, that fossil■fuel burning is the main cause, and that this leads to more heat being trapped (the greenhouse effect).

- **Write the paraphrase**

Using the ideas above, write a new paragraph of roughly the same length as the original.

- **Add a citation**

After your paraphrase, place a parenthetical citation that includes the author's last name and the year of publication. If the source you are using is a textbook called *Climate Science Today* written by Jane Smith in 2022, the citation would look like this: (Smith 2022).

If you are using a reference list at the end of your paper, the full entry would be:

> Smith, J. (2022). *Climate Science Today*. New York: Academic Press.

### *Example (not the answer you will submit)*

Original paragraph ->

> "The concentration of carbon dioxide (CO■) in the Earth's atmosphere has risen dramatically since the Industrial Revolution. This increase is primarily due to the burning of fossil fuels such as coal, oil, and natural gas, which release CO■ when they are combusted. Higher CO■ levels trap more heat in the atmosphere, leading to a rise in global average temperatures, a phenomenon known as the greenhouse effect."

Paraphrased version ->

> "Since the start of the Industrial Revolution, the amount of carbon dioxide in the air has increased sharply. The main reason is the combustion of fossil fuels - coal, oil, and natural gas - which emit CO■. Because more CO■ stays in the sky, it captures additional heat, causing worldwide temperatures to climb, a process called the greenhouse effect." (Smith 2022)

Notice how the example uses different words ("amount" instead of "concentration," "sharp" instead of "dramatically") and rearranges the sentences, yet it still contains all three original ideas.

### *Your turn*

Write **your own paraphrase** of the paragraph given at the top of this activity. Then add the correct citation in parentheses right after your paraphrase.

When you are finished, compare your work with the example. Ask yourself:

- Did I keep every original idea?
- Did I use my own wording and sentence order?
- Did I give proper credit with a citation?

> **Remember:** A paraphrase must be *your own* wording *and* must include a citation. Without the citation, it is still plagiarism.

> **Note:** If you are unsure whether a word is too close to the original, replace it with a synonym or rewrite the whole sentence.

> **In daily life:** Think of paraphrasing like explaining a movie plot to a friend. You don't copy the exact script; you tell the story in your own voice while still giving credit to the movie's creators if you mention the title.

> **Common mistake:** Leaving out the citation because you think "I changed the words enough." The citation is required no matter how much you re■word the source.

Once you have completed the activity, you can share your paraphrase with a classmate or teacher for feedback. This practice will help you build confidence in avoiding plagiarism and mastering academic writing.

## Terminology at a glance

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Plagiarism | Using another person's text, ideas, data, or creative work without acknowledging the original author. |
| Paraphrasing | Restating someone else's ideas in your own words and sentence structure while keeping the original meaning, followed by a citation. |
| In■text citation | A brief note inside the sentence that tells the reader the source of a paraphrased idea or quotation. |
| Reference list | A full list of all sources cited in a paper, placed at the end of the document. |
| Ethical consequences | The moral impact of plagiarism, such as loss of trust and unfair advantage. |
| Academic consequences | School■related penalties for plagiarism, like lower grades or disciplinary action. |
| Legal consequences | Potential copyright infringement penalties that can arise from using someone else's work without permission. |
| Synonym swapping | A common mistake where only a few words are replaced with synonyms, leaving the original structure largely unchanged. |

### Practical application

Exercise 7.1:

Exercise 7.2:

Exercise 7.3:

Exercise 7.4:

Exercise 7.5:

Exercise 7.6:

### Checklist

- [ ] Identify different forms of plagiarism
- [ ] Explain why proper citation matters
- [ ] Paraphrase a short passage without copying the original wording
- [ ] Create a reference list entry for a paraphrased source

LESSON 8

# 8. Clear and Concise Style

### Lesson overview

In this lesson students learn how to make their academic writing clear and concise by removing unnecessary words, using the active voice, and choosing precise vocabulary. They will practice editing sentences to improve readability and impact.

### Learning outcomes

- Identify and remove wordy phrases in a paragraph
- Convert passive■voice sentences into active voice
- Select more specific words to replace vague terms
- Rewrite a short passage to be clearer and more concise

### 8.1 Why Wordiness Hurts

When we write, every word should have a purpose.

If a sentence contains words that do not add new information, the reader has to work harder to find the main idea. This extra effort can make the text feel heavy, like trying to walk through a crowded hallway when there is a clear path on the side.

> **Definition:** *Wordiness* is the use of more words than necessary to express a thought. It includes filler words, redundant phrases, and overly long constructions.

Why does wordiness hurt? First, it slows down reading speed. The brain reads by recognizing familiar patterns; when a sentence is packed with unnecessary words, those patterns are broken, and the brain must pause to re■interpret. Second, extra words can hide the central point. Imagine a spotlight shining on a stage: the main idea is the actor, but if the stage is filled with fog (extra words), the actor becomes hard to see.

Consider the sentence:

*"In order to achieve a successful outcome, it is essential that we make a concerted effort to carefully plan each step of the process."*

The core message is simply: *"We must plan carefully."* All the other words are decorative and do not change the meaning. Removing them makes the sentence quicker to read and easier to remember.

> **In daily life:** Think of a text message you receive from a friend. "Hey, I just wanted to let you know that I am on my way to the coffee shop now, and I will be there in about ten minutes." The same idea can be sent as, "I'm on my way; I'll be there in ten minutes." The shorter version is clearer and gets the point across faster.

Why is clarity important in academic writing? Academic work aims to share knowledge efficiently. If readers spend time untangling wordy sentences, they may miss the argument or become frustrated and stop reading. Moreover, teachers and examiners often look for concise expression as a sign of understanding. A concise sentence shows that the writer has thought carefully about what is essential.

Wordiness also dilutes emphasis. When you repeat the same idea with different words, the impact of the original statement is weakened. For example:

*"The experiment was successful because the results were positive, indicating that the hypothesis was confirmed."*

The phrase "indicating that the hypothesis was confirmed" repeats what "the results were positive" already tells us. By cutting the repetition, the sentence becomes stronger: *"The experiment was successful; the results confirmed the hypothesis."*

> **Common mistake:** Adding phrases like "it is important to note that" or "the fact that" before a statement. These often do not add information and can be removed without loss of meaning.

A useful rule of thumb is the "one■idea■per■sentence" principle. If a sentence tries to convey several ideas, it tends to become wordy. Break it into two shorter sentences, each focusing on a single point. This not only reduces length but also improves logical flow.

Another tip is to replace vague words with precise ones. Instead of saying "a large number of participants," say "many participants" or give the exact number if known. Precise language eliminates the need for extra qualifiers.

> **Remember:** Concise writing is not about making sentences as short as possible; it is about keeping every word meaningful. Remove what does not add new information, and the remaining words will shine brighter.

In practice, after you finish a paragraph, read it aloud. If you stumble over a phrase or feel you are "filling space," ask yourself whether that phrase tells the reader something they could not already infer. If the answer is no, delete it or replace it with a shorter alternative. Over time, this habit will make your academic writing clearer, more persuasive, and easier for anyone to read.

[Figure to be added: A backpack filled with stones shows how extra words make writing heavier.]

Figure 8.1. A backpack filled with stones shows how extra words make writing heavier.

[Figure to be added: Active voice puts the doer first; passive voice puts the receiver first.]

Figure 8.2. Active voice puts the doer first; passive voice puts the receiver first.

[Figure to be added: A detailed map uses specific labels, just like precise words improve clarity.]

Figure 8.3. A detailed map uses specific labels, just like precise words improve clarity.

[Figure to be added: How to Cut Wordiness]

Figure 8.4. How to Cut Wordiness




Figure 8.5. Active vs. Passive Voice




Figure 8.6. Components of Precise Vocabulary

## 8.2 Common Wordy Phrases

When we write, every extra word is like adding a stone to a backpack that we have to carry. The more stones we add, the heavier the sentence feels, and the harder it is for the reader to move forward. By spotting and removing wordy phrases, we make our writing lighter, clearer, and more persuasive.

> **Definition:** *Wordy phrases* are groups of words that say the same thing as a shorter expression. They do not add new meaning; they only make the sentence longer.

Below is a list of common filler phrases that often appear in essays, reports, and emails. For each one, a concise alternative is given. Try reading the two versions out loud; the shorter version usually sounds crisper and more confident.

- Wordy phrase - Shorter alternative - Example (wordy) -> Example (concise)
- in order to - to - *We conducted the experiment **in order to** test the hypothesis. -> We conducted the experiment **to** test the hypothesis.*
- due to the fact that - because - *The project was delayed **due to the fact that** the supplier missed the deadline. -> The project was delayed **because** the supplier missed the deadline.*
- at this point in time - now - At this point in time, we cannot guarantee a refund. -> Now, we cannot guarantee a refund.
- with regard to - about / regarding - *Please see the attached file **with regard to** the budget. -> Please see the attached file **about** the budget.*
- in the event that - if - In the event that you have questions, contact the office. -> If you have questions, contact the office.
- despite the fact that - although - Despite the fact that it was raining, we continued the hike. -> Although it was raining, we continued the hike.
- has the ability to - can - *The new software **has the ability to** process data faster. -> The new software **can** process data faster.*
- is able to - can - *She **is able to** speak three languages. -> She **can** speak three languages.*
- in the near future - soon - *The results will be published **in the near future**. -> The results will be published **soon**.*
- for the purpose of - to - *He traveled abroad **for the purpose of** studying marine biology. -> He traveled abroad **to** study marine biology.*
- a large number of - many - *A **large number of** students attended the workshop. -> Many students attended the workshop.*
- in the majority of cases - usually - In the majority of cases, the system resets automatically. -> Usually, the system resets automatically.
- as a result of - because of - *The delay occurred **as a result of** traffic. -> The delay occurred **because of** traffic.*
- at this moment - now - *We cannot proceed **at this moment**. -> We cannot proceed **now**.*
- due to the fact that - because - *The meeting was cancelled **due to the fact that** the speaker was ill. -> The meeting was cancelled **because** the speaker was ill.*

> **In daily life:** Think of wordy phrases as the "extra toppings" on a pizza. A slice with just cheese, sauce, and crust is tasty and easy to eat. Adding too many toppings can overwhelm the flavor and make it harder to enjoy. In writing, the "toppings" are the filler words - remove the ones you don't need, and the main idea shines through.

Why does this matter? When a reader meets a long, tangled phrase, they must pause to decode it, which interrupts the flow of ideas. Shorter phrasing reduces that pause, letting the reader stay focused on the argument rather than on the wording.

> **Remember:** If you can replace a phrase with a single word or a shorter phrase **without changing the meaning**, do it. The goal is to keep the sentence's core meaning intact while shedding unnecessary weight.

### *How to spot wordiness while you edit*

- **Read aloud.** If you stumble over a group of words, it may be too long.
- **Ask "Can I say this in fewer words?"** Write the original phrase on a sticky note, then try to rewrite it in half the length.
- **Look for "to be" verbs** (is, are, was, were) followed by a noun phrase; often they can be replaced with a stronger verb.

Example: *The report **is** a summary of the data -> The report **summarizes** the data.*

By practicing these steps, you will gradually develop an eye for unnecessary filler and learn to replace it with crisp, direct language. This habit not only improves academic essays but also makes everyday communication - emails, messages, and presentations - more effective.

## 8.3 Practice: Cutting Wordiness

Take the following short paragraph and try to make it shorter without losing its meaning.

Read it carefully, look for words that repeat the same idea, and think about whether each word adds new information.

> **Definition:** *Wordiness* is the use of more words than necessary to say something.

> **Note:** Removing unnecessary words makes your writing clearer and easier to read.

> **In daily life:** Imagine you are giving directions to a friend. Saying "go straight ahead and continue moving forward without turning left or right" takes longer and is harder to follow than simply saying "go straight." The same principle works in writing.

**Original paragraph**

*The results of the experiment that was conducted last week clearly demonstrate that the participants who were given the new type of training program, which was designed specifically to improve their problem■solving abilities, performed significantly better on the post■test assessments when compared with the participants who did not receive the new training program and who continued with the standard training that had been used in previous years.*

Your task is to rewrite this paragraph so that it says the same thing but uses fewer words. Follow these steps:

- **Identify redundant phrases** - Look for groups of words that repeat the same idea. For example, "the results of the experiment that was conducted last week" can be shortened because "results" already imply an experiment, and "last week" may not be essential for the main point.
- **Replace long expressions with single words** - Phrases like "clearly demonstrate" often can be replaced by "show."
- **Cut filler words** - Words such as "actually," "very," "really," and "that was" often do not add meaning.
- **Combine ideas** - If two sentences or clauses say similar things, see if they can be merged.
- **Check meaning** - After you have removed words, read the new version aloud. Make sure it still tells the reader that the new training helped participants solve problems better than the old training.

**Guided rewrite**

- Start with the subject: *The participants who received the new training*
- State the main result: *performed better on the post■test*
- Add the comparison: *than those who kept the old training.*

Putting it together gives a concise version:

*Participants who received the new training performed better on the post■test than those who kept the old training.*

Now compare your own rewrite with this example. Did you keep the essential information? Did you remove any extra words that did not change the meaning?

> **Remember:** Every word should serve a purpose - either to add new information or to clarify. If a word can be removed without losing meaning, delete it.

**Practice worksheet**

- Original wording - Is it necessary? - Reason / Replacement
- "the results of the experiment that was conducted last week" - No - "the results" already implies an experiment; "last week" is not essential.
- "clearly demonstrate" - No - "show" conveys the same idea more directly.
- "participants who were given the new type of training program, which was designed specifically to improve their problem■solving abilities" - Partially - Shorten to "participants who received the new training."
- "performed significantly better on the post■test assessments when compared with" - Partially - "performed better on the post■test than" is sufficient.

- "the participants who did not receive the new training program and who continued with the standard training that had been used in previous years" - No - "those who kept the old training" captures the meaning.

Use the table to practice on your own sentences. Write the original, decide if each part is needed, and then rewrite it in a shorter form.

When you finish, exchange your revised paragraph with a partner. Read each other's versions and discuss whether any meaning was lost or if any extra words remain. This peer check helps you develop an eye for wordiness and reinforces the habit of editing for concision.

## 8.4 Active vs. Passive Voice

When we talk about **active** and **passive** voice, we are really talking about who is doing the action in a sentence.

**Definition:**

> **Active voice** is when the subject of the sentence performs the verb.

> **Passive voice** is when the subject receives the verb's action.

### *Why active voice is usually clearer*

- **It tells the reader straight away who is doing what.**

In an active sentence the order is *subject -> verb -> object*. This mirrors the way we think about events: first the doer, then the action, then the receiver.

- **It uses fewer words.**

Passive constructions often need an extra form of "to be" (is, was, were) and the word "by". Those extra words can hide the main point.

- **It sounds more confident.**

Writing in the active voice shows that the writer knows who is responsible for the action, which makes arguments stronger.

**In daily life:**

Think of a sports commentary. A commentator says, "The striker scores the goal," not "The goal is scored by the striker." The first version tells us instantly who did the scoring; the second drags the listener through extra steps.

### *Converting passive to active*

The basic pattern of a passive sentence is

object + form of "to be" + past participle (+ by + subject)

To change it to active, follow these three steps:

- **Identify the true subject** - the person or thing that performed the action. It usually appears after the word "by".
- **Move that subject to the front of the sentence.**
- **Replace the "to be + past participle" with the simple past (or present) form of the verb.**

**Remember:**

> **Passive:** The report *was written* **by** the committee.

> **Active:** The committee *wrote* the report.

### *Practice with common patterns*

- Passive example - Active conversion
- The experiment **was conducted by** the students. - The students **conducted** the experiment.
- A new rule **has been introduced by** the board. - The board **has introduced** a new rule.
- The results **are being analyzed by** the researcher. - The researcher **is analyzing** the results.

Notice how each active sentence is shorter and puts the doer first.

### *When passive can be useful*

Passive voice is not always wrong. Use it when:

- The doer is unknown or unimportant: "The window was broken last night."
- You want to emphasize the object rather than the subject: "The prize was awarded to the youngest participant."

But in academic writing, especially in the "methods" and "results" sections, active voice usually makes the description of procedures and findings sharper.

***Quick checklist for editing***

> **Note:**

> - Look for a form of "to be" (am, is, are, was, were, be, been) followed by a verb ending in ■*ed* or an irregular past participle.

> - Ask yourself: *Who performed this action?* If the answer is hidden after "by", rewrite the sentence so that answer comes first.

By consistently applying these steps, your writing will become more direct, easier to read, and more persuasive.

## 8.5 Practice: Changing to Active Voice

When we write in the active voice, the subject of the sentence does the action.

In the passive voice, the subject receives the action, and a "by■phrase" often tells us who performed it.

> **Definition:** *Active voice* - the subject **does** the verb.

> **Definition:** *Passive voice* - the subject **receives** the verb, usually with a form of *to be* + past participle.

Why does this matter?

Active sentences are usually shorter and clearer. They tell the reader **who** is responsible right away, so the meaning is easier to follow. Think of a sports commentary: "The striker scores" (active) feels more immediate than "A goal is scored by the striker" (passive). The active version puts the action in the foreground, just like a camera that follows the player instead of staying fixed on the goal.

**In daily life:** When you give directions, you say "Turn left at the corner" rather than "A left turn is made at the corner." The first tells the listener exactly what to do; the second sounds indirect and can confuse.

Now let's practice. Below are sentences written in the passive voice. Your task is to rewrite each one in the active voice. Keep the meaning the same, but make the subject the doer of the action. Try to use as few words as possible while staying clear.

- The experiment **was conducted** by the students last week.
- A new library **has been opened** by the city council.
- The final report **will be reviewed** by the committee tomorrow.
- The ancient manuscript **was discovered** by archaeologists in 1923.
- The results **are being analyzed** by the research team.
- The award **was given** to her for outstanding service.
- The homework **has been completed** by every student in the class.
- The novel **was written** by an unknown author.
- The meeting **will be postponed** by the manager if the room is unavailable.
- The cake **was baked** by my sister for the party.

Take a moment to change each sentence. When you finish, compare your version with the original:

- Does the active version start with a clear "doer"?
- Is the sentence shorter or about the same length?
- Does it sound more natural to you?

**Common mistake:** Leaving the verb form unchanged. Remember that passive verbs use a form of *to be* plus a past participle (e.g., *was conducted*). In the active voice you usually need only the simple past (*conducted*) or the appropriate tense (*will postpone*).

Now try a slightly harder set. These sentences include extra words that often appear in passive constructions. Remove the unnecessary parts while you switch to active voice.

- The policy **was approved** by the board after a long discussion.
- The painting **has been admired** by visitors for many years.
- The data **were collected** by the sensors during the experiment.
- The song **was sung** by the choir at the ceremony.
- The problem **was solved** by the engineers using a new algorithm.

**Remember:** An active sentence follows the pattern **Subject + Verb + Object**. If you can identify who performed the action, place that person or thing at the beginning of the sentence.

Finally, write one original sentence about something you did yesterday, first in passive voice, then rewrite it in active voice. Example:

- Passive: *The basketball game was watched by me after school.*
- Active: *I watched the basketball game after school.*

Use this exercise to see how easy it is to switch perspectives. When you get comfortable, you will naturally choose the active voice, making your academic writing sharper and more engaging.

## 8.6 Choosing Precise Vocabulary

When you choose a word that tells the reader exactly what you mean, your argument becomes clearer and more convincing.

Think of a map: a map that marks "river" tells you more than one that simply says "water". The same idea works with language. A precise word points the reader straight to the intended meaning, while a vague word makes the reader wander.

**Why precision matters**

A precise word reduces the number of extra explanations you need. If you write *"The temperature increased by 5 degreesC"* the reader instantly knows the direction (up) and the amount (5 degreesC). If you write *"The temperature went up a little"* the reader must guess how much "a little" means, and may wonder whether the change is important. In academic writing, where evidence and exactness are valued, this extra guessing weakens your claim.

> **Definition:** *Precise vocabulary* means using words that convey a specific, unambiguous meaning rather than general or vague terms.

**Step■by■step comparison**

- **Identify the idea** - What are you trying to say?

Example: *Students performed better on the test after the new teaching method.*

- **Find the core action or quality** - In this case, the change in performance.
- **Choose a word that quantifies that change** -
- Vague: *got better*
- Precise: *improved* or *increased*
- **Add any measurable detail if you have it** -
- *Improved by 12 %*

Now the sentence reads: *Students' scores improved by 12 % after the new teaching method.* The reader sees the direction (improved), the size (12 %), and the cause (new method) all at once.

> **In daily life:** When you tell a friend, "I'm a little tired," they don't know if you can still run a marathon. Saying, "I'm exhausted after a 10■km run," tells them exactly how you feel and why.

**Avoiding vague terms**

Words like *"thing," "stuff," "a lot," "some,"* or *"very"* are placeholders that hide meaning. They force the reader to pause and ask, "What exactly?" Replace them with concrete nouns or adjectives.

- *"A lot of data" -> "3 000 data points"*
- *"Very big" -> "massive"* (if size is the only attribute) or give the measurement: *"weighed 250 kg"*

When you cannot find a precise number, give a range or a descriptive phrase that narrows the meaning.

> **Common mistake:** Using *"increase"* and *"go up"* interchangeably. *Increase* is a noun or verb that already implies a rise, so adding *"go up"* repeats the idea and adds unnecessary words.

**A quick checklist for precise vocabulary**

- Does the word tell *how much* or *how many*? If not, can you add a figure?
- Does the word describe *direction* (up, down, higher, lower) clearly?
- Is there a more specific synonym that eliminates ambiguity?

If the answer to any question is "no," look for a better word.

**Putting it together in a sentence**

Suppose you have the draft:

*"The number of participants went up a lot after the advertisement."*

Apply the steps:

- Identify: change in participant count.
- Core action: increase.
- Precise word: *increased*.
- Add measurement: *increased from 150 to 420* (or *increased by 180 %*).

Revised sentence: *"The number of participants increased from 150 to 420 after the advertisement."* The reader now knows the magnitude and can judge the significance.

> **Remember:** Precise words act like a spotlight, highlighting exactly what matters and leaving no room for doubt.

By consistently choosing precise vocabulary, you make your academic writing tighter, more persuasive, and easier for readers to follow.

## 8.7 Final Editing Exercise

When you finish a piece of writing, the last thing you should do is **edit** it.

Think of editing like polishing a stone you have just carved. The shape is already there, but a few careful strokes make it shine and remove the rough edges. In this exercise you will practice three polishing skills at once:

- **Cutting wordiness** - removing unnecessary words that make sentences longer than needed.
- **Changing passive voice to active voice** - putting the do■er of the action in front of the verb.
- **Choosing precise vocabulary** - swapping vague words for ones that tell the reader exactly what you mean.

Doing all three together may feel like a lot, but you can handle it step by step. Below is a short paragraph taken from a typical student essay. Follow the three■step process described after the paragraph, and rewrite the whole excerpt so that it is clear, concise, and vivid.

**Original excerpt**

> The results of the experiment were observed by the researchers, and it was found that there was a significant increase in the amount of growth that occurred in the plants that had been given the special fertilizer. This increase was considered to be quite large when compared with the growth that was seen in the control group, which did not receive any fertilizer at all. The researchers also noted that the plants in the experimental group seemed to be healthier overall, and they were also observed to have a deeper green colour in their leaves, which was an indication that the plants were thriving.

### *Step■by■step editing guide*

- **Identify wordy phrases** - Look for groups of words that could be expressed with fewer words. Common culprits are phrases like "the results of the experiment were observed by the researchers" or "it was found that there was".
- **Spot passive constructions** - A passive sentence usually contains a form of *to be* plus a past participle, and the real actor (the do■er) appears after the verb or is omitted. Change it so the actor comes first.
- **Find vague words** - Words such as *quite large*, *seemed*, *overall*, *indication* are vague. Ask yourself: what exact amount, what specific sign, what precise quality can replace them?

> **Note:** *Passive voice* is a grammatical structure where the subject receives the action instead of performing it. For example, "The ball was thrown by John" (passive) versus "John threw the ball" (active).

> **In daily life:** When you give directions, you naturally use the active voice: "Turn left at the corner." Saying "The corner should be turned left at" would sound odd and confusing.

> **Common mistake:** Trying to cut words without checking the meaning can accidentally delete important information. Always keep the core idea intact.

### *Your revised paragraph*

Write your new version on a separate sheet or in a text editor. Follow the checklist below as you work:

- **Cut wordiness** - Delete filler words like *quite*, *actually*, *in order to*. Replace long phrases with single words when possible (e.g., "in order to" -> *to*).
- **Switch to active voice** - Put the researchers, the plants, or the experiment at the start of each sentence.
- **Use precise vocabulary** - Replace *significant increase* with the exact percentage if you know it, or with *doubling* if that is accurate. Change *healthier overall* to *had 20 % more leaf mass* (or another concrete measure). Replace *deeper green colour* with *darker green leaves*.

**Example of a possible rewrite (do not copy; create your own):**

> The researchers observed that the fertilizer■treated plants grew 45 % taller than the untreated control group. This growth was double that of the control plants. The treated plants also showed 20 % more leaf mass and displayed darker green leaves, indicating vigorous health.

***Checklist for the final edit***

- [ ] Every sentence starts with the actor (researcher, plant, etc.).
- [ ] No phrase longer than 15 words contains unnecessary filler.
- [ ] All vague adjectives (*significant*, *quite large*, *overall*) have been replaced by numbers, specific descriptors, or concrete nouns.
- [ ] The paragraph still conveys the three main ideas: (1) the fertilizer caused more growth, (2) the growth was larger than the control, (3) the plants looked healthier.

> **Remember:** Editing is a *process*, not a one■time event. Read the paragraph aloud; if you stumble over a phrase, it probably needs tightening.

When you have finished, compare your version with the original. Notice how many words you removed, how the actions become clearer, and how the precise terms paint a vivid picture. This practice will help you write essays that are easy for readers to understand and that earn higher marks for clarity and style.

## Terminology at a glance

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Wordiness | Using more words than necessary, including filler and redundant phrases. |
| Wordy phrase | A group of words that can be replaced by a shorter expression without losing meaning. |
| Active voice | The sentence structure where the subject performs the action (subject■verb■object). |
| Passive voice | The sentence structure where the subject receives the action, often using a form of "to be" plus a past participle. |
| Precise vocabulary | Choosing words that convey exact meaning, reducing the need for additional explanation. |
| Redundant | Repeating the same idea with different words, adding no new information. |
| Concise | Expressing an idea clearly using as few words as necessary. |
| Clarity | The quality of being easy to understand, with a clear main point. |

## Practical application

Exercise 8.1:

Exercise 8.2:

Exercise 8.3:

Exercise 8.4:

Exercise 8.5:

Exercise 8.6:

## Checklist

[ ] Identify and remove wordy phrases in a paragraph

[ ] Convert passive■voice sentences into active voice

[ ] Select more specific words to replace vague terms

[ ] Rewrite a short passage to be clearer and more concise

LESSON 9

# 9. Argument and Critical Thinking

## Lesson overview

In this lesson students learn how to build a strong argument by using claims, reasons, counterarguments, and evidence. They also practice weighing evidence to support their position effectively.

## Learning outcomes

- Identify and write clear claims
- Provide logical reasons to support a claim
- Recognise and formulate counterarguments
- Evaluate and weigh different pieces of evidence

## 9.1 What Is a Claim?

A claim is simply a statement that says **what you think** about a topic.

It is not just any sentence; it is a sentence that takes a position and therefore needs evidence or reasoning to convince others that it is true.

> **Definition:** A claim is a statement that expresses a point of view or argument that needs support.

Think of a claim like the **thesis** of an essay or the main idea you would put on a billboard to attract attention. If you say, "*Chocolate ice cream is the best flavor*," you are making a claim. Someone else could say, "*Vanilla is better*." Because the two statements cannot both be true at the same time, each one invites a discussion about why it might be right. That discussion is where the support comes in.

Why is it useful to label something as a claim?

When you know a sentence is a claim, you automatically know two things:

- **You must back it up.** A claim on its own is just an opinion. Readers will ask, "Why do you think that?"
- **You can test it.** If you can find evidence that disproves the claim, you have a reason to revise or reject it.

> **Note:** A claim is different from a fact. A fact is a statement that can be proven true or false without needing opinion (e.g., "Water freezes at 0 degreesC"). A claim is a statement that *needs* reasons or evidence to be accepted.

### *Everyday comparison*

Imagine you are at a restaurant and you tell the waiter, "*The soup is too salty*." That is a claim about the soup's taste. The waiter might respond, "*Really?*" and then you would explain: "*It has three teaspoons of salt, which is more than the recipe calls for*." Your explanation is the **support** for the claim. Without it, the waiter has no reason to change the soup.

In school, a claim works the same way. If you write, "*Reading fiction improves empathy*," you must provide reasons - perhaps studies that show readers score higher on empathy tests, or personal examples of how a story made you understand another person's feelings.

> **In daily life:** Saying "*I should study more*" is a claim about your own habits. To convince a friend (or yourself), you might list reasons like upcoming exams, past grades, or a schedule that shows you have free time.

### *Breaking down the parts*

- **Point of view** - the angle you are taking. It can be positive ("*X is good*"), negative ("*X is bad*"), or neutral but evaluative ("*X is better than Y*").
- **Argument** - the broader reasoning that connects your claim to evidence. A claim is the starting point; the argument is the road that leads from the claim to a conclusion.
- **Support** - facts, statistics, expert opinions, examples, or logical reasoning that make the claim believable.

When you write an academic paragraph, the claim usually appears as the **topic sentence** - the first sentence that tells the reader what the paragraph will discuss. The rest of the paragraph then supplies the support.

### *Simple formula*

You can think of a claim■support structure as a tiny equation:

Claim + Evidence rightarrow Persuasion

In words: a claim plus evidence leads to persuasion. If either part is missing, the equation does not balance, and the reader remains unconvinced.

> **Common mistake:** Stating a claim without any evidence. Many students write, "*Climate change is dangerous*," and stop there. Without data, examples, or expert quotes, the statement remains an unsubstantiated opinion.

### *How to test your own claim*

- **Ask "Why?"** - For every claim you write, ask yourself why you believe it. Write the answer down; that becomes your first piece of support.
- **Look for counter■examples.** - Think of situations where the claim might not hold. If you can address those, your argument becomes stronger.
- **Check for clarity.** - Make sure the claim is specific enough to be testable. "*Technology is good*" is vague; "*Using tablets in middle■school math classes improves test scores*" is precise and easier to support.

> **Remember:** A good claim is clear, debatable, and ready for evidence. It is the anchor of any argumentative paragraph, and every other sentence should help keep that anchor steady.

[Figure to be added: A billboard showing the claim "Chocolate ice cream is the best flavor".]

Figure 9.1. A billboard showing the claim "Chocolate ice cream is the best flavor".

[Figure to be added: A visual map of claim, reasons, evidence, counterargument, and conclusion.]

Figure 9.2. A visual map of claim, reasons, evidence, counterargument, and conclusion.

[Figure to be added: A toolbox filled with items representing different types of evidence.]

Figure 9.3. A toolbox filled with items representing different types of evidence.

[Figure to be added: Building an Argument Paragraph]

Figure 9.4. Building an Argument Paragraph

[Figure to be added: Claim vs Counterargument]

Figure 9.5. Claim vs Counterargument

[Figure to be added: Reliable Sources of Evidence]

Figure 9.6. Reliable Sources of Evidence

[Figure to be added: Parts of an Argument]

Figure 9.7. Parts of an Argument

[Figure to be added: Evaluating Evidence Reliability]

Figure 9.8. Evaluating Evidence Reliability

## 9.2 Reasons: Supporting Your Claim

When you make a claim - for example, "School uniforms improve student focus" - you need reasons that show **why** the claim could be true. A *reason* is a statement that explains the connection between your claim and the evidence you will later present. Think of a reason as the bridge that lets a reader travel from the idea you are defending to the facts that support it.

> **Definition:** A *reason* is a logical explanation that links a claim to evidence, showing how the evidence makes the claim plausible.

### *How a Reason Works*

- **State the claim clearly.**

*Claim:* "School uniforms improve student focus."

- **Identify a cause■and■effect relationship.**

A reason often points to a cause (something that happens) that leads to an effect (the result you claim). In our example, the cause might be "students spend less time deciding what to wear each morning."

- **Explain the link.**

You must spell out why the cause matters for the effect. Here you could say, "When students do not have to think about clothing choices, they start class sooner and are less distracted by fashion competition."

Putting these pieces together gives a full reason:

*Because students spend less time deciding what to wear, they begin lessons earlier and stay more focused during class.*

### *Building Strong Reasons*

- **Be specific.** Vague reasons like "it helps" do not tell the reader how the help happens.
- **Use everyday logic.** Ask yourself, "If I did X, would Y naturally follow?" If the answer is yes, you have a solid reason.
- **Connect to evidence.** A reason is only useful when you can later point to data, examples, or expert testimony that backs up the cause you described.

> **In daily life:** Imagine you tell a friend, "Eating breakfast makes me feel better at school." A good reason would be, "Because breakfast gives my brain glucose, which is the fuel it needs to think clearly." The reason explains the *how* behind the claim.

### *Linking Reasons to the Claim*

The link is created with **signal words** that show the relationship. Common signal words include:

- because
- since
- as a result of
- therefore
- leads to

Using these words makes the logical connection explicit. For example:

- *Since* students spend less time choosing clothes, *they* are able to start lessons earlier.
- *Because* breakfast provides glucose, *the brain* can work more efficiently.

### *Multiple Reasons*

Often one reason is not enough to convince a reader. You can provide several, each supporting the claim from a different angle. For the uniform claim, you might add:

- **Reduced peer pressure:** Uniforms eliminate competition over brand names, so students worry less about fitting in.
- **Simplified morning routine:** Parents spend less time washing and ironing, which means families have more calm time before school.

When you list multiple reasons, keep them organized:

- Start each reason with a clear signal word.
- Make sure each reason is distinct; avoid repeating the same idea.
- After presenting the reasons, you will later add evidence that matches each one.

#### *From Reason to Evidence*

A reason tells *why* something might be true; evidence shows *that it is true*. The transition looks like this:

> Claim -> Reason (why it could be true) -> Evidence (proof that it is true)

For instance:

- **Reason:** Uniforms reduce peer pressure.
- **Evidence:** A 2022 survey of 1,200 high school students found a 30 % drop in reported bullying about clothing after uniforms were introduced.

Notice the formula that often appears in academic writing to show a simple logical structure:

$$\text{Claim} \; \Longleftarrow \; \text{Reason} \; + \; \text{Evidence}$$

#### *Checking Your Reasons*

Before you finish the paragraph, ask yourself:

- Does each reason directly relate to the claim?
- Have I used a signal word to make the link clear?
- Is the reason specific enough to be supported by evidence later?

If the answer to any question is "no," revise the reason until it meets the criteria.

> **Remember:** A good reason is specific, logically linked with signal words, and ready to be backed up by evidence.

By mastering reasons, you give your argument a sturdy framework that guides the reader from the claim you make to the proof you will provide. This step■by■step bridge is the heart of persuasive academic writing.

## 9.3 Introducing Counterarguments

When you write an argument, you are not just shouting your own opinion. A strong piece of writing shows that you have thought about the other side of the issue. This is called **introducing counterarguments**.

> **Definition:** *Counterargument* - a statement that disagrees with, or challenges, the main claim you are trying to prove.

First, imagine a simple claim: *"School should start later in the morning."* Most readers will immediately think of reasons like "students are more rested." But some people might say, "Later start times make it harder for parents to get kids to school." If you ignore that objection, your essay feels one■sided and less convincing. By mentioning the opposing view, you show that you understand the whole picture and that you are fair.

#### *Why present the other side first?*

- **Builds credibility** - Readers trust writers who admit there are other opinions.
- **Creates a logical path for refutation** - Once the objection is on the table, you can explain why it does not outweigh your own reasons.
- **Strengthens your own argument** - Showing that you have considered alternatives makes your evidence seem more solid.

Think of it like a courtroom. The prosecutor presents the evidence for guilt, but the defense lawyer first acknowledges the prosecution's points before showing why they are mistaken. The jury feels the process is balanced, so they are more likely to accept the final verdict.

#### *Steps to introduce a counterargument fairly*

- **Identify the strongest opposing view** - Choose the objection that most people could raise, not a weak straw■man that is easy to knock down.
- **State it clearly and neutrally** - Use language that does not sound hostile or dismissive. For example: *"Some parents argue that a later start time would require them to adjust their morning schedules, which could be stressful."*
- **Give a brief reason for the opposition** - Explain why the counterargument makes sense. This shows you understand its logic.
- **Transition to your refutation** - Use linking words such as "however," "nevertheless," or "on the other hand" to move smoothly to your response.

> **In daily life:** When a friend suggests, "You should buy a cheaper phone," you might reply, "I see that price matters, but the cheaper model lacks a good camera, which I need for my school projects." You first acknowledge the cost concern before explaining why it isn't the only factor.

#### *How to refute without sounding dismissive*

- **Use evidence** - Cite statistics, expert opinions, or real■world examples that directly address the counterargument.
- **Explain the limitation** - Show where the opposing view falls short. For instance, "While a later start may inconvenience some parents, a 2023 study found that 70 % of families reported improved sleep for their children, outweighing the scheduling challenge."
- **Offer a compromise if possible** - Sometimes a middle ground strengthens your position: "Schools could provide a flexible drop■off window to help parents adjust."

#### *A short template you can copy*

Some people claim that [counterargument]. They argue that [reason they find it plausible]. However, [your evidence] shows that [why the counterargument is less convincing]. Therefore, [restate your original claim].

> **Note:** Avoid the *straw■man* fallacy, which is when you misrepresent the opposing view so it is easier to defeat.

#### *Practice tip*

Before you write the final paragraph, list at least two possible objections to your claim. Choose the one that seems strongest, write it in a neutral sentence, and then plan a single piece of evidence that directly challenges it. This small exercise will make the full paragraph flow naturally.

By learning to anticipate and address counterarguments, you turn a simple opinion into a well■rounded, persuasive argument that respects the reader's intelligence and encourages critical thinking.

## 9.4 Weighing Evidence

When you look at evidence, think of it like a toolbox. Each piece of evidence is a tool, and the stronger the tool, the better it can help you build a solid argument.

> **Definition:** *Evidence* is any fact, statistic, example, or expert opinion that you use to support a claim.

First, ask yourself **how reliable** the evidence is. Reliability means you can trust that the information is accurate and not made up. Reliable evidence usually comes from sources that check their facts carefully, such as peer■reviewed journals, official government reports, or reputable news organizations.

> **Note:** *Peer■reviewed* means other experts have examined the work before it is published, which reduces the chance of mistakes.

Next, consider **relevance**. Relevance asks whether the evidence directly relates to the point you are trying to make. A statistic about the number of bicycles sold last year is relevant if your claim is about the popularity of cycling, but it is not relevant if you are arguing that schools should have more science labs.

Then, think about **currency** - how recent the evidence is. In fast■changing fields like technology or medicine, a study from ten years ago might be outdated. For historical topics, older sources can be appropriate, but you still need to check whether newer research has changed the picture.

> **In daily life:** When you buy a phone, you compare recent reviews (currency) from trusted tech sites (reliability) that talk about battery life (relevance) to decide which model fits your needs.

Another important criterion is **bias**. Bias is a tendency to favor a particular outcome, often because of personal, financial, or political interests. A study funded by a soda company that claims sugary drinks are harmless is likely biased. Look for disclosures about who paid for the research and whether the authors have a stake in the results.

> **Common mistake:** Assuming that because something is printed, it is automatically trustworthy. Print does not guarantee reliability; always check the source's reputation and review process.

Now, let's compare two pieces of evidence using these criteria. Imagine you have:

- A 2023 report from the World Health Organization (WHO) stating that air pollution causes 7 million deaths each year.
- A blog post from a popular travel website saying "air pollution isn't a big problem; you can't even see it."

Apply the checklist:

- Criterion - WHO report - Travel blog
- Reliability - High (peer■reviewed, expert organization) - Low (no expert review)
- Relevance - Directly about health impacts of air pollution - Only mentions personal perception
- Currency - 2023 (very recent) - No date, likely older
- Bias - Minimal (public health mission) - Possible bias toward promoting travel

The WHO report scores high on all four criteria, so it is strong evidence. The blog post scores low, making it weak evidence.

When you have multiple strong sources, you can **triangulate** - use them together to reinforce each other. If three independent studies all find the same result, the combined weight is stronger than any single study alone.

> **Remember:** Strong evidence is *reliable, relevant, current, and unbiased*. Use several pieces that meet these standards to build a convincing argument.

Finally, be aware of **quantity vs. quality**. Having many weak pieces of evidence does not outweigh a few high■quality ones. For example, ten personal anecdotes about a new teaching method are less persuasive than one well■designed experimental study that shows measurable improvement.

To practice, take a claim you care about - say, "electric cars reduce climate change." Find at least two pieces of evidence. Rate each on reliability, relevance, currency, and bias. Then decide which one is stronger and why. This systematic approach will help you weigh evidence like a careful judge, ensuring your arguments rest on the best possible foundation.

## 9.5 Putting It All Together in a Paragraph

When you write an argumentative paragraph, think of it as building a tiny **mini■essay** that fits on one line of paper.

First you state **your main point** (the claim). Then you give one or two reasons that support it. After that you show that you have thought about the other side (the counterargument). Finally you compare the evidence for both sides and explain why your claim still stands.

> **Definition:** *Claim* - a clear statement that says what you believe or want others to believe.

### *1. Start with a clear claim*

Write the claim as the first sentence so the reader knows exactly what you are arguing. Keep it short and specific.

*Example:*

**Claim:** *School days should start later because teenagers need more sleep.*

### *2. Add reasons that back up the claim*

Each reason is a piece of evidence or a logical explanation. Use facts, statistics, or simple observations that are easy to verify.

*Reason 1:* Research shows that most teenagers do not get the recommended 8■9 hours of sleep on school nights.

*Reason 2:* Lack of sleep hurts concentration, making it harder to learn in class.

### *3. Introduce a counterargument*

A counterargument is the main objection someone might raise against your claim. Mention it politely, using words like *some people argue* or *others say*.

*Counterargument:* Some parents worry that a later start time will cut into after■school activities and homework time.

### *4. Weigh the evidence*

Now compare the strength of the reasons you gave with the counterargument. Show why the reasons outweigh the objection, using additional data or logical reasoning.

*Weighed evidence:* While a later start may shift the schedule, studies from schools that moved the bell later found that students actually spent **more** time on homework because they were less tired and could work more efficiently.

### *5. Finish with a concluding sentence*

Tie everything together by restating the claim in light of the evidence you have just weighed.

*Conclusion:* Therefore, starting school later benefits students' health and learning more than it harms extracurricular planning.

Putting all these pieces together gives a complete paragraph:

> **School days should start later because teenagers need more sleep.** Research shows that most teenagers do not get the recommended 8■9 hours of sleep on school nights, and lack of sleep hurts concentration, making it harder to learn in class. *Some parents worry that a later start time will cut into after■school activities and homework time.* However, schools that have shifted the bell later report that students actually spend **more** time on homework because they are less tired and can work more efficiently. **Therefore, starting school later benefits students' health and learning more than it harms extracurricular planning.**

> **In daily life:** Think of this paragraph like a balanced meal: the claim is the main dish, the reasons are the vegetables, the counterargument is a small side, and the weighed evidence is the sauce that brings everything together.

> **Remember:** Every paragraph needs a **single** claim, at least one reason, a counterargument, and a clear explanation of why the reasons win.

> **Common mistake:** Adding many unrelated facts after the claim. Stick to the few strongest pieces of evidence; extra information can confuse the reader and dilute your argument.

By following these steps, you can turn a scattered list of ideas into a tight, persuasive paragraph that shows you have thought critically about the issue. Practice by choosing a simple topic - like "Why homework should be optional" - and write a paragraph using the same structure. The more you practice, the more natural the process will become.

## 9.6 Common Pitfalls and How to Avoid Them

When you start writing an argument, it is easy to slip into habits that make your essay weaker. Below are the most common pitfalls and simple ways to fix them, step by step.

First, a **weak claim** is a statement that is too vague, too broad, or simply an opinion without any basis.

> **Common mistake:** *"People should be healthier."*

This claim tells the reader what you think, but it does not tell **why** you think it or what you will actually argue. To strengthen a claim, make it **specific** and **debatable** - something that someone could reasonably disagree with.

> **Remember:** A good claim answers the question *"What exactly am I trying to prove?"*

For example, change the weak claim to: *"High schools should require at least three hours of physical education each week because regular exercise improves students' concentration and reduces stress."* Now the claim tells the reader the exact policy you support and hints at the reasons you will give.

Second, many writers give **unsupported reasons**. A reason is a piece of evidence or logic that explains why the claim is true. If you simply state a reason without backing it up, the reader is left unconvinced.

> **Note:** *"Exercise helps concentration."*

Without proof, this is just another opinion. To avoid this pitfall, always attach **evidence** - facts, statistics, expert quotes, or concrete examples - to each reason. For instance: *"A 2022 study by the University of Michigan found that students who participated in daily physical activity scored 12% higher on attention tests than those who did not."* The evidence makes the reason credible.

Third, **ignoring counterarguments** weakens your essay because it suggests you have not considered other points of view. A counterargument is a reason someone might disagree with your claim. If you pretend the opposition does not exist, readers may think you are biased or uninformed.

> **In daily life:** Imagine you are trying to convince a friend to buy a hybrid car. If you only talk about fuel savings and never mention the higher purchase price, your friend may doubt your honesty.

To handle counterarguments, first **acknowledge** them, then **refute** or **reconcile** them with your own argument. For example: *"Some critics say hybrid cars are too expensive, but the long■term fuel savings and tax credits often offset the initial cost within three years."* This shows you have thought about the other side and have a reasoned response.

Fourth, **mixing up evidence and explanation** can confuse readers. Evidence is the raw data; explanation shows how that data supports your claim. If you present a statistic and then jump to a new point without linking them, the reader may lose the thread. Always follow the pattern: **Claim -> Reason -> Evidence -> Explanation**.

> **Definition:** *Explanation* is the sentence that tells the reader *why* the evidence matters for your claim.

Finally, **overloading a paragraph** with too many ideas makes it hard to follow. Keep each paragraph focused on a single main reason. Start with a topic sentence that states the reason, then add evidence and explanation, and end with a brief link back to the overall claim. If you have another reason, start a new paragraph.

### *Quick checklist to avoid these pitfalls*

- **Is my claim specific and debatable?**
- **Does each reason have clear evidence?**
- **Have I mentioned at least one counterargument?**
- **Do I explain how the evidence supports the reason?**
- **Is each paragraph about one main idea only?**

By checking these points as you draft, you turn common mistakes into strong, persuasive writing. Remember, good arguments are built like a sturdy bridge: a solid foundation (claim), strong pillars (reasons with evidence), and guardrails (counterarguments) that keep the whole structure safe and convincing.

## 9.7 Mini-Exercise: Build Your Own Argument

Imagine you are writing a short paragraph that tries to convince someone that **school uniforms improve learning**.

We will build the paragraph step■by■step, using every tool you just learned.

**Step 1 - State the claim**

A *claim* is the main idea you want the reader to accept.

> **Definition:** A claim is a clear, debatable statement that you will try to prove.

Write it in one sentence:

*"School uniforms improve learning outcomes for students."*

**Step 2 - Add reasons (supporting evidence)**

A *reason* explains **why** the claim might be true. Each reason should be backed by *evidence* - a fact, statistic, or example that shows the reason is real.

- **Reason 1:** Uniforms reduce distractions.

*Evidence:* A 2018 study of 5,000 high■school students found a 12 % drop in classroom disruptions after uniforms were introduced.

- **Reason 2:** Uniforms promote equality.

*Evidence:* Survey results show 78 % of students feel less pressure to wear expensive clothes when everyone dresses alike.

Write each reason as a short sentence, then attach the evidence:

- *Uniforms reduce distractions, as shown by a 2018 study that recorded a 12 % decline in classroom interruptions.*
- *Uniforms promote equality; 78 % of students reported feeling less pressure to wear costly outfits.*

**Step 3 - Introduce a counterargument**

A *counterargument* is an opposing view you acknowledge. It shows you have thought about other sides of the issue.

> **In daily life:** Think of a friend who says, "Uniforms limit personal expression." That is a counterargument.

Write it briefly:

*Some people argue that uniforms limit students' ability to express themselves through clothing.*

**Step 4 - Refute the counterargument**

To *refute* means to show why the counterargument does not outweigh your claim. Use evidence or reasoning.

- *While personal expression is important, research shows that the academic benefits of reduced distraction outweigh the modest loss of clothing choice.*
- *Moreover, schools can offer other outlets for expression, such as art projects or extracurricular clubs.*

**Step 5 - Weigh the evidence**

Now compare the strength of your reasons and the counterargument. Use a simple weighing sentence:

*Overall, the evidence that uniforms cut distractions and foster equality is stronger than the concern about limited fashion freedom.*

**Step 6 - Put everything together in one paragraph**

Combine the pieces, keeping the order: claim -> reasons + evidence -> counterargument -> refutation -> weighing -> concluding sentence.

> *School uniforms improve learning outcomes for students. Uniforms reduce distractions, as shown by a 2018 study that recorded a 12 % decline in classroom interruptions, and they promote equality; 78 % of students reported feeling less pressure to wear costly outfits. Some people argue that uniforms limit students' ability to express themselves through clothing, but while personal expression is valuable, the academic benefits of reduced distraction outweigh this modest loss, and schools can provide other creative outlets. Overall, the evidence that uniforms cut distractions and foster equality is stronger than the concern about limited fashion freedom, so adopting uniforms is a sensible step toward better learning.*

Read it aloud. Does each sentence flow logically? Does every claim have a reason and evidence? Is the counterargument addressed fairly?

> **Note:** When you write your own argument, always check that each reason is paired with concrete evidence; a reason without evidence is just an opinion.

> **Common mistake:** Forgetting to *refute* the counterargument. If you only mention the opposing view, the reader may think you agree with it.

Now try it yourself. Choose a familiar topic - like "homework helps students learn" or "reading fiction improves empathy" - and follow the six steps above. Write a paragraph of 5■7 sentences that includes a claim, at least two reasons with evidence, a counterargument, a refutation, and a final weighing sentence. When you're done, compare your paragraph to the example and see if you used every element.

## Terminology at a glance

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Claim | A clear, debatable statement that expresses what you think and needs support. |
| Reason | A logical explanation that connects a claim to the evidence. |
| Evidence | Facts, statistics, examples, or expert opinions used to support a claim. |
| Counterargument | A statement that opposes or challenges the main claim. |
| Reliability | The degree to which evidence can be trusted as accurate. |
| Relevance | How directly evidence relates to the claim being made. |
| Thesis | Another term for the main claim of an essay, often placed at the beginning. |
| Credibility | The trust readers place in a writer, built by acknowledging other views and using solid evidence. |

## Practical application

Exercise 9.1:

Exercise 9.2:

Exercise 9.3:

Exercise 9.4:

Exercise 9.5:

Exercise 9.6:

## Checklist

- [ ] Identify and write clear claims
- [ ] Provide logical reasons to support a claim
- [ ] Recognise and formulate counterarguments
- [ ] Evaluate and weigh different pieces of evidence

LESSON 10

# 10. Revising and Editing

## Lesson overview

In this lesson students learn how to revise the overall structure of their essay, improve clarity, and proofread for errors. They will practice step■by■step techniques to make their writing stronger and more polished.

## Learning outcomes

- Identify and reorganise weak sections to improve essay structure
- Check sentences for clear meaning and logical flow
- Spot and correct common grammar, punctuation and spelling mistakes
- Apply a checklist to edit a complete draft independently

## 10.1 1. Why Revision Matters

When you sit down to write an essay, the first thing you usually do is **draft** it. A draft is a rough version where you get your ideas onto the page. Think of it as the "raw dough" of a pizza: you spread the flour, add the sauce, and sprinkle the cheese, but you haven't yet baked it or cut it into slices. The draft gets the main ingredients - your arguments, evidence, and examples - into place, but it is not yet polished.

> **Definition:** *Drafting* is the process of creating an initial version of a text, focusing on getting ideas down without worrying about perfection.

After the draft is finished, you move on to **revising**. Revising is like baking that pizza and then tasting it to see if it needs more seasoning, a different crust thickness, or a better arrangement of toppings. In writing, revising means looking at the whole piece again and asking:

- Does each paragraph support my main point?
- Are my ideas ordered in a logical way?
- Have I explained any terms that might be new to the reader?

These questions force you to see the essay from a higher level, not just from the point of view of the sentence you just typed.

> **Note:** *Revising* focuses on big■picture issues - structure, argument strength, and overall flow - while *editing* (which comes later) deals with small details like spelling and punctuation.

Why does doing several passes matter? Imagine you are building a LEGO model. The first step is to snap the big blocks together to get the shape right. If you stop there, the model might look correct from far away, but up close you could see loose pieces or missing connections. By stepping back, checking the instructions again, and tightening each joint, the model becomes sturdy and looks better from every angle. The same idea applies to writing: each pass lets you catch a different kind of problem.

- **First pass - Content check**

You ask whether the essay actually answers the prompt. This is the "does it work?" question. If you discover that a paragraph drifts off■topic, you can move it, rewrite it, or delete it.

- **Second pass - Organization check**

Here you look at the order of paragraphs and sentences. Does the introduction set up the thesis? Does each paragraph begin with a clear topic sentence? Are transitions (words like "however," "for example," "therefore") used to guide the reader? Rearranging sections can make the argument flow more naturally.

- **Third pass - Clarity check**

Now you focus on the reader's understanding. Replace vague words ("things," "very good") with precise ones ("statistics," "excellent"). Break long sentences into shorter ones if they become hard to follow. Adding a brief definition for a technical term is a simple way to avoid confusion.

- **Fourth pass - Mechanics check**

Finally, you look at grammar, spelling, and punctuation. This is where you catch missing commas, mismatched verb tenses, or misspelled names. Even a strong argument can lose credibility if it contains many mechanical errors.

> **In daily life:** Think of revising like proofreading a text message before you send it. You might first type what you want to say, then read it again to make sure the tone is right, the facts are correct, and there are no autocorrect mistakes.

Multiple passes are useful because our brains work best when they focus on one kind of problem at a time. If you try to fix spelling while also judging whether your argument is logical, you will likely miss both kinds of errors. By separating the tasks, you give each issue the attention it deserves.

> **Common mistake:** Trying to do everything in one go - checking grammar, structure, and content all at once - often leads to a shallow review where many errors slip through.

Research on writing processes shows that students who revise their work at least three times produce essays that are clearer, more persuasive, and better organized than those who submit the first draft. The improvement comes from the cumulative effect of each pass: the first pass adds ideas, the second shapes them, the third sharpens them, and the fourth polishes them.

> **Remember:** Revision is not a chore; it is a chance to make your ideas shine. Each round of reading is an opportunity to ask, "How can I make this clearer, stronger, and more convincing for my reader?" By treating drafting and revising as separate steps, you give yourself the space to think, edit, and ultimately produce higher■quality academic writing.

[Figure to be added: A pizza dough with toppings shows how a draft contains the main ideas before polishing.]

Figure 10.1. A pizza dough with toppings shows how a draft contains the main ideas before polishing.

[Figure to be added: A simple map of an essay's parts helps students see the big■picture order.]

Figure 10.2. A simple map of an essay's parts helps students see the big■picture order.

[Figure to be added: A hand polishing a glass illustrates the final proofreading step.]

Figure 10.3. A hand polishing a glass illustrates the final proofreading step.

[Figure to be added: Revision Process]

Figure 10.4. Revision Process

[Figure to be added: Draft vs. Revised Essay]

Figure 10.5. Draft vs. Revised Essay

[Figure to be added: Main Parts of an Essay]

Figure 10.6. Main Parts of an Essay

[Figure to be added: Editing Checklist Passes]

Figure 10.7. Editing Checklist Passes

## 10.2 2. Reviewing Essay Structure

When you finish a first draft, the ideas are on the page, but they may not be arranged in the most effective order. **Reviewing essay structure** means looking at the big picture: does each paragraph follow logically from the one before it? Are the main parts of the essay (introduction, body, conclusion) balanced, so no section is too short or too long? And does the whole piece stay true to the thesis statement - the single sentence that tells the reader what the essay will prove or explain?

**Why this matters**

If the order of paragraphs is confusing, a reader can lose track of your argument and may think you are not convincing. A well■structured essay guides the reader step by step, just like a map shows a clear route from start to finish.

> **In daily life:** Think of a story you tell a friend about a movie you watched. You would first say what the movie is about, then describe the most exciting scenes, and finally give your opinion. If you started with your opinion, the friend might be puzzled because they don't yet know what you are judging.

### *Step 1: Locate the thesis and check alignment*

- Find the thesis statement, usually placed at the end of the introduction.
- Write it on a sticky note or a separate line.
- For each body paragraph, ask: *Does this paragraph give evidence or analysis that supports the thesis?* If a paragraph drifts into a side topic, it may belong elsewhere or be cut.

> **Definition:** *Alignment* means the degree to which each part of the essay points back to the thesis, like spokes of a wheel all leading to the hub.

### *Step 2: Map the logical order*

- List the topic sentence of each paragraph in the order they appear.
- Look for a clear progression:
- **Chronological** (time order) - events happen from earliest to latest.
- **Cause■and■effect** - one idea explains why another occurs.
- **Problem■solution** - first present a problem, then offer ways to fix it.
- Ask yourself whether each step naturally leads to the next. If paragraph 4 jumps to a new idea that would make more sense after paragraph 6, rearrange the numbers.

> **Common mistake:** Moving a paragraph without adjusting the transition sentences. After you reorder, rewrite the first and last sentences of the moved paragraphs so they connect smoothly.

### *Step 3: Check the balance of sections*

An essay that spends ten lines on the introduction but only two lines on each body paragraph is unbalanced. Use a ruler or the word■count feature to compare lengths:

- Introduction: 10■15 % of total words
- Each body paragraph: roughly equal, usually 20■30 % each
- Conclusion: 10■15 %

If one body paragraph is twice as long as the others, ask: *Is this extra detail essential?* If not, trim it and move the useful parts to a shorter paragraph.

> **Note:** Balance does not mean every paragraph must be exactly the same length, but the differences should reflect the importance of each point, not accidental wordiness.

### *Step 4: Verify transitions and coherence*

Even with the right order, the essay can feel choppy if the connections are missing. Look for transition words such as *therefore*, *however*, *next*, *as a result*. If a paragraph ends abruptly, add a sentence that hints at what comes next. Conversely, if a paragraph starts with a sudden new idea, insert a brief link to the previous paragraph.

### *Quick checklist for structure*

- Thesis is clear and appears early.
- Every paragraph ties back to the thesis.
- Paragraph order follows a logical pattern (chronological, cause■effect, etc.).
- Sections are roughly balanced in length.
- Transitions guide the reader smoothly from one idea to the next.

By following these steps, you turn a collection of ideas into a coherent, persuasive essay that readers can follow without getting lost. Remember, the structure is the skeleton; without a strong skeleton, even the most brilliant arguments will collapse.

## 10.3 3. Checking Clarity and Coherence

When we read our own essay, we often think we already know what each sentence means. But the reader does **not** share that inside knowledge.

Checking **clarity** means making sure every word says exactly what we intend.

Checking **coherence** means making sure the ideas flow smoothly from one sentence to the next, so the reader can follow the argument without getting lost.

First, look for **vague wording**. A vague word is one that could mean many different things, leaving the reader guessing.

Example: "The results were **significant**." *Significant* could refer to statistical significance, importance to the writer, or emotional impact. To be clear, replace it with a precise description: "The results were **statistically significant (p < .05)**" or "The results were **important because they showed a 20 % increase in sales**."

> **Definition:** *Vague wording* - words or phrases that are imprecise, ambiguous, or too general, making the meaning unclear.

Next, hunt for **ambiguous references**. An ambiguous reference is a pronoun or noun that could point to more than one earlier idea.

Example: "Maria told **her** brother that **she** would win." Who is *her*? Who is *she*? The reader may wonder whether *her* refers to Maria's sister or to someone else mentioned earlier. Rewrite: "Maria told her brother, **John**, that **Maria** would win." Now each pronoun is tied to a specific name.

> **Common mistake:** Using pronouns like *it, they, this* without a clear antecedent, which forces the reader to guess the referent.

After vague words and ambiguous references, examine the **transitions** between sentences and paragraphs. A transition is a word, phrase, or sentence that links one idea to the next. Without a good transition, the essay can feel choppy, as if the writer is jumping from one point to another.

Consider the paragraph pair:

*"The experiment showed that temperature affects reaction speed. The data were recorded over three days."*

The second sentence starts abruptly; the reader does not see the logical connection. Add a transition:

*"The experiment showed that temperature affects reaction speed. **Consequently**, the data were recorded over three days to observe how the effect changed over time."*

> **In daily life:** Think of transitions like road signs. A sign that says "Next turn: left" tells drivers what to expect. Without the sign, drivers might miss the turn and get confused.

### *A step■by■step checklist for clarity and coherence*

- **Read aloud** - Hearing the words forces you to notice awkward phrasing and missing links.
- **Highlight** every pronoun (*he, she, it, they, this, that*) and ask, "What does this refer to?" Write the noun next to it if needed.
- **Find vague adjectives or adverbs** (*good, many, often, important*) and replace them with specific details or numbers.
- **Mark each paragraph's main idea** in the margin. Then check that the first sentence of the next paragraph relates to that idea. If not, insert a transition phrase such as *"In addition," "However," "Therefore,"* or rewrite the sentence.
- **Look for "one■sentence jumps."** If a sentence seems to appear out of nowhere, ask, "Why is this here?" Add a linking sentence that explains the connection.

### *Practice rewrite*

Original excerpt:

*"The survey asked students about their study habits. Most answered that they study late at night. This can affect their grades."*

Problems:

- *"This"* is ambiguous - does it refer to studying late or to the survey?
- The link between late studying and grades is missing.

Rewritten:

*"The survey asked students about their study habits. **Most students reported that they study late at night.** Research shows that **studying late can reduce sleep quality, which often leads to lower grades.**"*

Now the pronoun is replaced, the cause■effect relationship is explicit, and the paragraph flows logically.

> **Remember:** Clear, coherent writing is like a well■lit hallway - every step is visible, and the path from the start to the finish is easy to follow. By removing vague words, fixing ambiguous references, and adding smooth transitions, you guide your reader confidently through your ideas.

## 10.4 4. Proofreading for Grammar and Mechanics

When you finish a draft, the words are already in the right place, but tiny mistakes can still hide in the sentences.

Proofreading is the last, careful scan that catches those slips in spelling, punctuation, and grammar before the essay is handed in. Think of it like polishing a piece of glass: the shape is already there, but a quick wipe removes the smudges so the light can shine through clearly.

**Why it matters** - A single misplaced comma can change the meaning of a whole sentence, and a misspelled word can distract the reader or make you look careless. By checking each line deliberately, you protect your ideas from being misunderstood.

### *Step■by■step system*

- **Read aloud, slowly**

When you say the words, you hear where a pause feels wrong or a word sounds odd. This slows you down enough to notice errors that silent reading often skips.

- **Focus on one type of error at a time**

Trying to catch everything in one go is overwhelming. Instead, make separate passes:

- **First pass:** spelling
- **Second pass:** punctuation (periods, commas, apostrophes, quotation marks)
- **Third pass:** grammar (subject■verb agreement, verb tense consistency, pronoun reference)
- **Use a ruler or a digital "highlight"**

Slide a ruler under each line, or highlight the line on the screen, and move it down after you finish. This forces your eyes to stay on one line and reduces the chance of skipping.

- **Mark the text**

Keep a simple set of symbols:

- ✎ for spelling
- ¶ for punctuation
- ∑ for grammar

Write the symbol in the margin next to the line that needs attention. Later you can go back and fix each marked spot.

- **Employ tools wisely**

Spell■checkers and grammar■checkers are helpful, but they are not infallible. Treat them as assistants, not replacements. After the software flags a word, ask yourself if the suggestion fits the meaning you intend.

- **Do a peer check**

A fresh pair of eyes often spots errors you have become blind to. Give a classmate a printed copy and ask them to look for the same three types of errors you practiced.

### *Common trouble spots*

- **Spelling** - English has many homophones (words that sound the same but are spelled differently), such as *their* vs. *there* vs. *they're*.
- **Punctuation** - A missing comma before a coordinating conjunction (for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so) can create a run■on sentence.
- **Grammar** - The subject and verb must agree in number: *The list of items **is** on the table* (singular "list"), not *are*.

> **Note:** A "run■on sentence" occurs when two independent ideas are joined without proper punctuation or a conjunction. Splitting them with a period or adding a comma + conjunction fixes the error.

### *Quick checklist for the final pass*

- **Spelling:** Look for red underlines, then verify each flagged word in a dictionary.
- **Punctuation:** Check that every sentence ends with a period, question mark, or exclamation point. Ensure commas are placed after introductory phrases (e.g., *After the lecture, we discussed the article.*).
- **Grammar:** Confirm that each pronoun clearly refers to a noun, and that verb tenses stay consistent throughout the paragraph.

> **In daily life:** Proofreading is like checking the expiration dates on food before you eat it. You wouldn't want to consume something spoiled; similarly, you don't want to submit writing that's "spoiled" by avoidable errors.

### *Using technology*

- **Built■in spell check:** Turn it on in your word processor; it underlines unknown words in red.
- **Grammar extensions:** Tools such as Grammarly or the Hemingway Editor highlight passive voice, complex sentences, and common grammar slips.
- **Search function:** Press *Ctrl+F* (or *Cmd+F* on a Mac) to find repeated words like "very very" or to locate every instance of a particular punctuation mark.

> **Remember:** Even the best software can miss context■dependent errors. Always combine automated checks with your own careful reading.

### *Final tip*

After you have corrected all marks, give the essay one last read■through without any markers or tools. Imagine you are a reader who knows nothing about the topic. If the text flows smoothly and no errors jump out, you have completed a solid proofreading round. This systematic approach turns a messy draft into a polished piece that lets your ideas shine without distraction.

## 10.5 5. Editing Checklist and Practice

When you edit a paragraph you are doing three things at once:

- **Checking the big picture** - does the paragraph fit the essay's overall shape?
- **Making each sentence clear** - are the ideas easy to follow?
- **Cleaning up the surface** - are spelling, punctuation and grammar correct?

Below is a step■by■step checklist that blends these three tasks. Follow the list in order, and you will turn a rough draft into a polished piece. After the checklist, you will practice on a short sample paragraph.

> **Note:** A checklist works best when you use it *once* for each pass. Trying to do everything at once can make you miss small errors.

### *Editing Checklist*

- Step - What to do - How to do it
- **1. Structure Scan** - Verify that the paragraph has a clear topic sentence, supporting sentences, and a concluding sentence. - • Look for a sentence that tells the reader *what* the paragraph is about (topic). <br>• Make sure the middle sentences give evidence, examples, or explanation. <br>• Check that the last sentence wraps up or links forward.
- **2. Idea Order** - Ensure the sentences follow a logical order (chronological, cause■effect, compare■contrast, etc.). - • Read the paragraph aloud and ask, "Does the next sentence naturally follow the one before?" <br>• If not, move the sentence or add a transition word (e.g., *first*, *however*, *as a result*).
- **3. Clarity Check** - Look for vague words, wordy phrases, and jargon. Replace them with specific, simple language. - • Highlight any word you would need to look up. <br>• Ask, "Can I say this in fewer words?" <br>• Replace "utilize" with "use", "in the event that" with "if".
- **4. Coherence Scan** - Make sure each sentence connects to the next. - • Insert linking words where needed (e.g., *because*, *therefore*, *for example*). <br>• Delete sentences that repeat the same idea.
- **5. Grammar & Mechanics** - Correct spelling, punctuation, verb tense, subject■verb agreement, and pronoun reference. - • Use a ruler or finger to look at one line at a time. <br>• Check common trouble spots: <br> - **Subject■verb agreement**: singular subject -> singular verb (e.g., *The list **is** long*). <br> - **Pronoun reference**: make sure "it", "they", etc., clearly refer to a noun.
- **6. Final Read■Aloud** - Hear the rhythm and catch any remaining awkward spots. - • Read slowly, pausing at commas and periods. <br>• If you stumble, rewrite that part.

> **In daily life:** Editing a paragraph is like cleaning a kitchen. First you clear the clutter (structure), then you wipe the counters (clarity), and finally you sweep the floor (grammar). Skipping any step leaves the kitchen messy.

### *Practice: Full Edit of a Sample Paragraph*

**Original paragraph**

> The internet has changed the way we learn because it gives us a lot of information. Many students use it for homework and they can find many resources. Some teachers think that it is a good tool but others think that it can be a distraction. Also, the internet can help students learn faster because they can watch videos and read articles.

**Step 1 - Structure Scan**

- **Topic sentence?** Yes, the first sentence states the main idea.
- **Supporting sentences?** Three sentences give examples and counter■views.

- **Concluding sentence?** The last sentence repeats a benefit but does not wrap up. We will add a brief conclusion.

**Step 2 - Idea Order**

The counter■view ("some teachers think...") appears after two examples of benefits. It would be clearer to present all benefits first, then the opposing view. Move the third sentence to the end.

**Step 3 - Clarity Check**

- "gives us a lot of information" -> "provides easy access to information".
- "many resources" -> "articles, videos, and interactive quizzes".
- "it can be a distraction" -> "it can distract students from their work".

**Step 4 - Coherence Scan**

Add transition words: after the second sentence, insert *however* before the counter■view. After the counter■view, add *nevertheless* before the final benefit sentence.

**Step 5 - Grammar & Mechanics**

- Subject■verb agreement: "The internet **has** changed" is correct.
- Pronoun reference: "it" clearly refers to "the internet".
- Punctuation: add commas after introductory words (*However,*).

**Step 6 - Final Read■Aloud**

Read the revised paragraph to ensure smooth flow.

**Revised paragraph**

> The internet provides easy access to information, which has transformed the way we learn. Many students use it for homework and can find articles, videos, and interactive quizzes. **However**, some teachers think it is a useful tool, **but** others argue that it can distract students from their work. **Nevertheless**, the internet can help students learn faster because they can watch videos and read articles. **In summary**, when used wisely, online resources enhance learning while requiring careful classroom management.

Now run through the checklist one more time. Does the paragraph have a clear topic sentence, logical order, concise language, smooth transitions, and correct grammar? If the answer is "yes," the edit is complete.

> **Remember:** Editing is a cycle. If you discover a new problem while fixing another, return to the appropriate step in the checklist. This systematic approach builds confidence and produces cleaner, more persuasive writing.

## Terminology at a glance

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Drafting | Creating an initial version of a text to get ideas down without worrying about perfection. |
| Revising | Re■examining the whole piece to improve content, organization, and argument strength. |
| Essay structure | The logical order of introduction, body paragraphs, and conclusion that supports the thesis. |
| Clarity | Using precise words so the reader understands exactly what is meant. |
| Coherence | Ensuring ideas flow smoothly from one sentence to the next. |
| Vague wording | Words that can be interpreted in many ways, making the meaning unclear. |
| Proofreading | A final careful scan for spelling, punctuation, and grammar errors. |
| Checklist | A short, ordered list of tasks to guide each pass of editing. |

## Practical application

Exercise 10.1:

Exercise 10.2:

Exercise 10.3:

Exercise 10.4:

Exercise 10.5:

Exercise 10.6:

### Checklist

- [ ] Identify and reorganise weak sections to improve essay structure
- [ ] Check sentences for clear meaning and logical flow
- [ ] Spot and correct common grammar, punctuation and spelling mistakes
- [ ] Apply a checklist to edit a complete draft independently

LESSON 11

# 11. Writing Introductions and Conclusions

## Lesson overview

In this lesson students learn how to craft effective essay introductions and conclusions, focusing on hooks, context, and strong closing statements. They will practice techniques to engage readers at the start and leave a lasting impression at the end.

## Learning outcomes

- Identify and create three different types of hooks for essay introductions
- Explain how to provide necessary context that leads to the thesis
- Write a concise conclusion that restates main points and offers a final thought
- Combine hook, context, and thesis into a complete introductory paragraph
- Combine summary, implications, and closing sentence into a complete concluding paragraph

## 11.1 What Is a Hook?

When you begin an essay, the first few sentences are like the front door of a house. If the door is inviting, people want to step inside; if it is dull or broken, they may turn away. In academic writing that "front door" is called a **hook**.

> **Definition:** A hook is the opening sentence (or short paragraph) that grabs the reader's attention and makes them want to keep reading.

A hook does not have to be flashy or dramatic, but it must do one thing: **capture interest**. When a reader feels curious, surprised, or personally connected, the writer gains a small but powerful advantage. The reader is more likely to read the whole introduction, understand the thesis, and follow the argument.

Why does this work? Human brains are wired to notice novelty. When we see something we haven't expected - a question we haven't thought about, a striking fact, a vivid story - our attention spikes. That spike is exactly what a hook creates. In the same way that a bright billboard catches drivers' eyes on a highway, a well■chosen hook catches a reader's eyes on the page.

There are four main types of hooks that work well in most school essays. You can think of them as four different keys that open the same door; you choose the key that fits the lock of your topic.

- **Question hook** - Pose a question that the reader can't immediately answer.

Example: *"What would happen if every city banned private cars for a day?"*

The question makes the reader pause and think, creating a mental "I want to know the answer" feeling.

- **Quote hook** - Use a short, relevant quotation from a well■known person or a primary source.

Example: *"'The only thing we have to fear is fear itself,' said Franklin D. Roosevelt, reminding us that..."*

A quote works because it brings authority and often a familiar voice that the reader recognizes.

- **Anecdote hook** - Share a brief, personal or historical story that illustrates the topic.

Example: *"When I missed the last bus home on a rainy night, I realized how dependent my city is on public transport."*

Stories are easy for the brain to picture, so they create an instant emotional link.

- **Startling fact hook** - Present a surprising statistic or piece of information.

Example: *"Every minute, the world loses an area of forest the size of 48 football fields."*

Numbers that are shocking make the reader say, "Wow, I didn't know that," and they want to learn why.

> **In daily life:** Think of a hook like the opening line of a movie trailer. The trailer shows a quick, exciting scene to make you want to watch the whole film. An essay hook does the same for your writing.

When you pick a hook, match it to your topic and audience. A scientific report might favor a startling fact, while a literature essay could start with a relevant quote. Avoid using a hook that feels unrelated; otherwise the reader will feel misled.

> **Common mistake:** Using a hook that is too vague or generic, such as "In this essay I will discuss...". This does not capture interest because it tells the reader exactly what will happen, removing the element of surprise.

Finally, remember that the hook is only the beginning. After you have caught the reader's attention, you must quickly provide **context** - a few sentences that explain why the hook matters and lead smoothly to your thesis statement. The transition from hook to context is the bridge that turns curiosity into understanding.

> **Remember:** A good hook is clear, relevant, and followed by a brief explanation that connects it to the main argument. With practice, you'll be able to choose the right key for every essay door.

[Figure to be added: An inviting front door representing a strong essay hook.]

Figure 11.1. An inviting front door representing a strong essay hook.

[Figure to be added: A bridge linking the hook to the thesis, illustrating the role of context.]

Figure 11.2. A bridge linking the hook to the thesis, illustrating the role of context.

[Figure to be added: Two bookends holding an essay, symbolising introduction and conclusion.]

Figure 11.3. Two bookends holding an essay, symbolising introduction and conclusion.

[Figure to be added: Building an Introduction]

Figure 11.4. Building an Introduction

[Figure to be added: Common Hook Types]

Figure 11.5. Common Hook Types

[Figure to be added: Parts of a Strong Conclusion]

Figure 11.6. Parts of a Strong Conclusion

## 11.2 Choosing the Right Hook for Your Topic

When you pick a hook, think of it as the "first impression" you give your reader.

Just like a shop window that shows the most eye■catching item to draw people inside, a hook shows the most interesting part of your essay right away.

> **Definition:** A **hook** is the opening sentence (or short paragraph) that grabs the reader's attention and makes them want to keep reading.

Why does the match matter? Different subjects and audiences expect different kinds of "first impressions." A science report, a literary analysis, and a persuasive essay each have their own style, and the people who will read them - teachers, classmates, or a broader public - have different expectations. If the hook feels out of place, the reader may lose interest before the main ideas even start.

### *1. Factual or Statistical Hook - Best for Science and Social■Science Topics*

If your essay is about climate change, a new technology, or a demographic trend, start with a striking fact or a short statistic. Numbers are concrete; they give the reader a clear picture instantly.

Example:

> "In the last decade, global sea levels have risen by an average of **3.3 mm per year**, a rate that threatens coastal cities worldwide."

The equation below shows how a simple rate can be expressed:

Rise per year = fracTotal riseNumber of years

Using a factual hook tells the audience - often teachers who value evidence - that you are grounded in real data from the start.

### *2. Question Hook - Ideal for Essays that Explore Ideas or Opinions*

When the essay asks "why" or "how," a thought■provoking question works well. It invites the reader to think along with you.

Example:

> "What would happen to our daily lives if every car suddenly ran on electricity?"

This type of hook fits philosophy, ethics, or any persuasive piece where the audience expects you to argue a point. The question signals that the essay will guide them through a line of reasoning.

### *3. Anecdotal Hook - Perfect for Personal, Narrative, or Literature Essays*

A short, vivid story or personal experience creates an emotional connection.

Example:

> "I still remember the first time I saw a hummingbird hover, its wings beating so fast they were a blur."

Anecdotes work best when the reader is likely to be a peer or a teacher who appreciates a human touch. They set a tone of relatability before you move to analysis.

### *4. Quotation Hook - Useful for Literary Analysis and Historical Essays*

If you are writing about Shakespeare, Martin Luther King Jr., or any well■known figure, a brief, relevant quote can lend authority.

Example:

> "'All the world's a stage,' wrote Shakespeare, reminding us that every action is performed for an audience."

Make sure the quote is directly linked to your thesis; otherwise it feels like name■dropping.

> **Note:** A quotation should never be used just because it sounds impressive. It must support the main argument you will develop.

### *5. Contrast or Paradox Hook - Works for Critical Essays*

Presenting two opposite ideas side by side can spark curiosity.

Example:

> "Although smartphones connect us instantly, they also isolate us in silent rooms."

This hook signals that the essay will examine a tension, which is common in critical or argumentative writing.

### *Matching Hook to Audience*

- Essay Type - Typical Audience - Recommended Hook
- Scientific report - Teachers, experts - Factual/Statistical
- Persuasive essay - General public, classmates - Question or Contrast
- Literary analysis - Teachers, literature lovers - Quotation or Anecdote

- Personal narrative - Peers, teachers - Anecdotal
- Historical essay - Teachers, scholars - Quotation

> **In daily life:** Choosing the right hook is like picking the right opening line when you meet someone new. If you're at a science conference, you start with a recent discovery; at a party, you might tell a funny story. The setting (your audience) tells you which opening will work best.

### *Quick Checklist*

- Identify your essay subject (science, literature, opinion, etc.).
- Ask: Who will read this? (teacher, classmates, wider public).
- Select the hook type that matches both the subject and the audience's expectations.
- Keep the hook short - one sentence or a brief paragraph.
- Make sure the hook leads naturally into the background information you will give next.

> **Remember:** A good hook is not just "cool"; it must be relevant to the topic and set up the direction of your essay. If the hook and the essay's main idea don't connect, the reader will feel misled and may lose trust in your argument.

## 11.3 Providing Context After the Hook

When you have caught the reader's attention with a hook, the next job is to give them the information they need to understand why the hook matters. This part is called **providing context**. Think of it as the bridge that carries the reader from the exciting opening to the main idea of your essay, the thesis statement.

> **Definition:** *Context* is the background information that helps the reader see how the hook relates to the topic you will discuss.

Why do we need this bridge? Imagine you walk into a room where someone is shouting, "You won't believe what happened!" If they immediately start talking about the details of a scientific experiment, you would feel lost. You need a short explanation that tells you *why* the shout is relevant before the main story begins. In writing, the context does exactly that: it tells the reader what the hook is about and why it matters for the argument you will make.

**Step 1: Identify the key idea of the hook.**

Look at the hook you chose. If it is a surprising statistic, the key idea is the fact that the statistic reveals. If it is a short anecdote, the key idea is the situation or problem shown in the story. Write this idea down in one simple sentence.

**Step 2: Connect the key idea to the broader topic.**

Take the sentence from Step 1 and ask, "How does this relate to the subject of my essay?" Add a phrase that links the two. Common linking words are *because*, *which means*, *therefore*, or *as a result*. For example:

- Hook: "Every year, more than 8 million tons of plastic end up in the ocean."
- Key idea sentence: "This massive amount of waste harms marine life."
- Context sentence: "Because plastic pollution is so widespread, it threatens the health of entire ocean ecosystems."

**Step 3: Provide just enough background.**

Now give the reader a brief overview of the larger issue, but avoid a full literature review. One or two sentences are enough. Include only facts that the reader needs to understand the next step - your thesis. For instance:

> **In daily life:** Think of a kitchen sink that is slowly filling with water. If you only tell someone the faucet is leaking (the hook) and then jump straight to "We need to fix the pipe," they won't know why the leak matters. You first explain that the water will overflow and damage the kitchen (the context) before suggesting a solution.

**Step 4: Lead directly to the thesis.**

Your last context sentence should end with a logical step toward your main claim. Use a transition word such as *therefore*, *thus*, or *consequently*. This signals that the introduction is moving from background to argument.

Example full transition:

> "Because plastic pollution is so widespread, it threatens the health of entire ocean ecosystems. **Consequently**, we must adopt stricter regulations on single■use plastics to protect marine life."

Notice how the word *consequently* tells the reader that the next sentence will present the thesis.

> **Remember:** The context should be *short* (usually 2■3 sentences) and *focused* on what the reader needs to know before the thesis.

**Common mistake:** Adding too much detail or unrelated facts. If you start describing every type of plastic ever made, the reader will lose the thread and may forget the hook's purpose. Keep the background tight and directly tied to the thesis.

**Step■by■step checklist**

- Write one sentence that states the main point of the hook.
- Link that sentence to the overall topic with a clear connector.
- Add one or two sentences of essential background information.
- End with a transition word that leads into the thesis statement.

By following these small, ordered steps, you create a smooth flow: Hook -> Context -> Thesis. The reader feels guided, not jolted, and is ready to see how the rest of the essay will answer the question raised by the hook.

## 11.4 Crafting a Strong Closing Sentence

When you finish a conclusion, you want the reader to leave with a clear sense of what the essay was about **and** why it matters. The last sentence does this job. Think of it as the "final handshake" after a conversation - it should be firm, friendly, and leave a good impression.

> **Definition:** A **closing sentence** is the final sentence of a conclusion that briefly restates the main idea and adds a final thought, such as a recommendation, a prediction, or a call■to■action.

Why does a closing sentence matter?

If you end abruptly, the reader may feel the essay is unfinished, just as a story that stops mid■sentence feels unsatisfying. A strong closing sentence ties everything together and gives the reader a clear takeaway.

### *Step 1: Restate the Main Point in New Words*

First, remind the reader of the essay's central claim, but don't copy the thesis word■for■word. Use synonyms or a slightly different phrasing. This shows you understand the idea well enough to express it in more than one way.

*Example:*

Original thesis: "Renewable energy reduces carbon emissions and protects the environment."

Restated in the conclusion: "Switching to renewable power cuts greenhouse gases and safeguards our planet."

> **Note:** Avoid simply repeating the thesis; the restatement should feel fresh, not redundant.

### *Step 2: Summarize One or Two Key Supporting Ideas*

Next, pick the most important pieces of evidence you presented. Summarize them in a very short phrase or clause. This reminds the reader why the main point is credible.

*Example:*

"Because solar panels have become cheaper and wind farms generate power even in remote areas, the transition to clean energy is both affordable and practical."

### *Step 3: Add a Final Thought*

Now decide what you want the reader to do or think after finishing. There are three common types of final thoughts:

- **Call■to■action** - ask the reader to act (e.g., "Vote for policies that fund renewable projects.")
- **Prediction** - look ahead (e.g., "In ten years, most homes will run on solar power.")
- **Broader implication** - connect to a larger issue (e.g., "Our energy choices today will shape the climate for generations.")

Choose the type that fits the purpose of your essay.

### *Step 4: Keep It Concise*

A closing sentence should be a single, well■crafted sentence. Aim for 15■25 words. Too long, and the impact is lost; too short, and it may feel abrupt.

### *Putting It All Together*

Combine the three parts in the order: restate -> summarize -> final thought. Use transition words like "Therefore," "Thus," or "In short" to signal the conclusion.

*Full example:*

"Therefore, adopting renewable energy not only cuts greenhouse gases and protects the environment, but also offers affordable, reliable power - so we must support policies that accelerate this transition."

> **In daily life:** Think of a closing sentence like the last line of a text message that says, "Let's meet at 5 pm," after you've already explained why the meeting is important and where it will be. It wraps up the conversation and tells the friend what to do next.

### *Common Pitfalls to Avoid*

> **Common mistake:** Adding new information that was never discussed in the essay. This confuses the reader and weakens the argument.

> **Remember:** The closing sentence should only reflect ideas already presented, not introduce fresh evidence.

### *Quick Checklist*

- [ ] Restated the main idea in different words.
- [ ] Summarized one or two key supporting points.
- [ ] Included a final thought (call■to■action, prediction, or broader implication).
- [ ] Kept the sentence clear and concise (15■25 words).

By following these steps, you turn the conclusion from a simple ending into a purposeful final statement that reinforces your argument and leaves the reader with a clear, memorable impression.

## 11.5 Putting It All Together: Full Intro and Conclusion

When you write an essay, the introduction and the conclusion are like the two bookends that hold everything together.

First, the **introduction** catches the reader's attention, tells them why the topic matters, and states the main point (the thesis).

Second, the **conclusion** reminds the reader of that main point, shows why it still matters, and ends with a memorable final sentence.

Below is a step■by■step walk■through of how to combine the pieces you have already learned - hook, context, thesis, summary, implications, and closing sentence - into a smooth, complete introduction and conclusion.

### *1. Build the introduction piece by piece*

- **Hook** - a short, interesting opening that makes the reader want to keep reading.
- **Context** - one or two sentences that explain the background or why the topic is relevant.
- **Thesis statement** - a clear, single sentence that tells the reader exactly what you will argue or explain.

**Example prompt:** *"Explain how social media influences teenage friendships."*

- Step - Sentence (example)
- Hook - *"Imagine scrolling through your phone and seeing a friend's smile appear before you even hear their voice."*
- Context - *"In the past decade, social media platforms like Instagram and TikTok have become the primary way teenagers communicate."*
- Thesis - *"This essay argues that social media reshapes teenage friendships by increasing contact frequency, altering how emotions are expressed, and creating new pressures to present a perfect image."*

Notice how the hook is vivid, the context gives a quick fact, and the thesis tells exactly what the essay will cover.

> **Note:** A good thesis is specific; it does not just say "social media is important," but names the three ways you will discuss.

### *2. Build the conclusion piece by piece*

- **Restate the thesis** - use different words, but keep the same idea.
- **Summarize the main points** - briefly remind the reader of the evidence you presented.
- **Implications or broader significance** - explain why the argument matters beyond the essay.
- **Closing sentence** - a final thought that leaves a lasting impression; it can be a call■to■action, a striking quote, or a vivid image.

**Continuing the same essay:**

- Step - Sentence (example)
- Restate thesis - *"In sum, social media has fundamentally changed teenage friendships through more frequent contact, new emotional cues, and heightened self■presentation pressures."*

- Summarize points - *"We saw how daily messages keep friends connected, how emojis replace facial expressions, and how curated profiles create unrealistic expectations."*
- Implications - *"Understanding these effects helps parents, educators, and teens navigate digital life more responsibly."*
- Closing sentence - *"If we can teach young people to balance online sharing with authentic interaction, the next generation may enjoy friendships that are both virtual and truly human."*

The conclusion mirrors the introduction's structure but works backward: it starts with the big idea, then narrows to the details, and finally expands again to a broader view.

> **In daily life:** Think of a movie trailer. It shows the most exciting scenes (hook), tells you the setting (context), and promises the main story (thesis). After the movie, the credits recap the key moments and leave you with a final thought - just like an essay's conclusion.

#### *3. Practice with a new prompt*

**Prompt:** *"Discuss the advantages and disadvantages of remote learning for high school students."*

**Step■by■step introduction**

- Hook: *"When the school bell rings, some students now hear it from their kitchen table instead of a hallway."*
- Context: *"Since 2020, remote learning has become a common option for high schools worldwide."*
- Thesis: *"This essay argues that remote learning offers flexibility and access to resources, but it also creates challenges in motivation, social interaction, and equitable technology."*

**Step■by■step conclusion**

- Restate thesis: *"Overall, remote learning provides both freedom and obstacles for high school students."*
- Summarize points: *"Flexible schedules let students study at their own pace, while online libraries expand research options; yet, many struggle with staying motivated, miss face■to■face collaboration, and lack reliable internet."*
- Implications: *"Policymakers must design hybrid models that keep the benefits while addressing the drawbacks."*
- Closing sentence: *"Only by blending the best of both worlds can education prepare students for a future that is both digital and deeply human."*

#### *4. Checklist for a polished intro and conclusion*

- **Hook** is vivid, relevant, and no more than one sentence.
- **Context** gives just enough background; avoid long histories.
- **Thesis** is one clear sentence that lists the main points you will cover.
- In the **conclusion**, the thesis is restated in new words.
- The **summary** touches each main point once, using brief phrases.
- **Implications** connect the essay to a larger issue or future action.
- The **final sentence** is memorable and ties back to the hook or a larger theme.

> **Remember:** The introduction invites the reader in; the conclusion says goodbye while leaving a lasting thought. If both follow the same logical pattern, your essay will feel balanced and professional.

## Terminology at a glance

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Hook | An opening sentence or short paragraph that captures the reader's interest. |
| Context | Background information that explains why the hook matters and leads to the thesis. |
| Thesis Statement | A single sentence that states the main argument or purpose of the essay. |
| Closing Sentence | The final sentence of a conclusion that restates the main idea and adds a final thought. |
| Factual Hook | A hook that uses a surprising fact or statistic, often used in science or social■science essays. |
| Narrative Hook | A hook that begins with a brief story or anecdote to draw the reader in. |
| Implication | A statement in the conclusion that shows why the essay's findings matter beyond the paper. |
| Restate in New Words | Paraphrasing the thesis in the conclusion without copying it verbatim. |

## Practical application

Exercise 11.1:

Exercise 11.2:

Exercise 11.3:

Exercise 11.4:

Exercise 11.5:

Exercise 11.6:

### Checklist

- [ ] Identify and create three different types of hooks for essay introductions
- [ ] Explain how to provide necessary context that leads to the thesis
- [ ] Write a concise conclusion that restates main points and offers a final thought
- [ ] Combine hook, context, and thesis into a complete introductory paragraph
- [ ] Combine summary, implications, and closing sentence into a complete concluding paragraph

LESSON 12

# 12. Writing Under Exam Conditions

## Lesson overview

Students learn how to plan quickly, manage their time, and write effective essays under exam pressure. The lesson provides practical steps to meet deadlines without sacrificing quality.

## Learning outcomes

- Plan an essay outline in under five minutes
- Allocate time for each essay stage during an exam
- Write a clear introduction, body, and conclusion within the time limit
- Check work quickly for common errors before submitting

## 12.1 Understanding the Exam Prompt

When you sit down to write an essay in an exam, the first thing you must do is **understand the exam prompt**. The prompt is the short piece of text that tells you what you are supposed to write about. It may look simple, but if you miss even one part of it, you can lose marks even though the rest of your essay is good.

> **Definition:** *Exam prompt* - the question or statement given by the exam board that tells you the topic, the task, and any limits you must follow.

### *1. Read the prompt slowly, twice*

Start by reading the whole prompt at a normal speed. Then put the paper down for a few seconds, close your eyes, and picture the question in your mind. Open the paper again and read it a second time, this time **out loud** if it helps. Speaking the words forces you to notice details that you might skim over when reading silently.

> **Note:** The exam timer usually starts as soon as you read the prompt, so give yourself only 30■45 seconds for this double reading.

### *2. Spot the key tasks*

Most prompts contain **action words** - verbs that tell you what to do. Common action words are:

- *Explain* - give reasons or causes.
- *Discuss* - present different sides of an issue and give your own view.
- *Compare* - show similarities and differences.
- *Evaluate* - judge the value or importance, using evidence.
- *Analyse* - break the idea into parts and show how they work together.

Write these verbs down in the margin of your answer sheet. They are the **tasks** you must complete. If a prompt contains more than one verb, you have to address each one. For example:

> "**Discuss** the advantages of renewable energy **and evaluate** its limitations **within 300 words**."

Here you have two tasks: *discuss* and *evaluate*. Both must appear in your essay, and you must stay inside the word limit.

### *3. Identify the subject and scope*

After the verbs, the next important part is the **subject** - the thing you are talking about. In the example above the subject is *renewable energy*. Sometimes the subject is a specific theory, a historical event, or a piece of literature. Write the subject next to the verbs you have noted.

The **scope** tells you how far you should go. Words like *briefly*, *in detail*, *in the context of...*, or a specific time period narrow the range of what you need to cover. Ignoring scope can make your answer too broad or too narrow.

> **In daily life:** Think of a recipe. The action words are the cooking steps (mix, bake, serve) and the subject is the dish (chocolate cake). If the recipe says "bake for 20 minutes at 180 degreesC," that is the scope - you must follow it exactly, otherwise the cake will not turn out right.

### *4. Note any word limits or formatting rules*

Exams often give a maximum word count, for example "*Write up to 250 words*". This is not a suggestion; it is a strict rule. Writing 300 words when the limit is 250 can lead to a penalty, even if the extra 50 words are good. Write the limit in the margin and keep a running total of words as you draft.

Some prompts also require a specific structure (e.g., "*use a three■paragraph format*") or ask you to include a quotation, a diagram, or a reference. Treat these as additional tasks and add them to your checklist.

> **Common mistake:** Ignoring the word limit or forgetting a required element (like a quotation). This often happens when students rush to the writing stage without a clear checklist.

### *5. Turn the prompt into a short checklist*

Now that you have highlighted verbs, subject, scope, and limits, turn them into a quick bullet list that you can glance at while you write. For the earlier example the checklist would look like:

- **Discuss** advantages of renewable energy
- **Evaluate** limitations of renewable energy
- Keep total **<= 300 words**
- Use **two■paragraph** structure (if required)

Having this list visible prevents you from drifting off■topic. As you finish each point, tick it off. It also helps you see if you have time left for a final proofread.

### *6. Why this matters*

When you follow these steps, you reduce the risk of misreading the prompt, which is a common cause of low marks. Exams test not only your knowledge but also your ability to follow instructions. By treating the prompt as a set of clear, separate instructions, you turn a potentially confusing sentence into a simple to■do list.

> **Remember:** The exam prompt is your roadmap. Read it carefully, extract verbs, subject, scope, and limits, then make a checklist. Follow the checklist while you write, and you will stay on track, use your time wisely, and maximise the marks you can earn.

[Figure to be added: A printed exam prompt with key parts underlined.]

Figure 12.1. A printed exam prompt with key parts underlined.

[Figure to be added: A simple hand■drawn outline showing introduction, body points and conclusion.]

Figure 12.2. A simple hand■drawn outline showing introduction, body points and conclusion.

[Figure to be added: A short checklist students can use in the last minutes of the exam.]

Figure 12.3. A short checklist students can use in the last minutes of the exam.




Figure 12.4. Exam Writing Process




Figure 12.5. Quick Brainstorm vs Mini Outline




Figure 12.6. Parts of a Short Essay




Figure 12.7. Typical Time Allocation (45■minute essay)




Figure 12.8. Rapid Revision Checklist

## 12.2 Quick Brainstorming Techniques

When you first read an exam prompt, you only have a few minutes before the clock starts ticking. The fastest way to turn that short reading time into useful material is **quick brainstorming** - a rapid, focused way of pulling out ideas that you can later turn into paragraphs.

> **Definition:** *Quick brainstorming* is a short, timed activity (usually 2-3 minutes) where you write down every idea that comes to mind about the prompt, without judging whether it is perfect or not.

Why does this work?

Your brain can generate many connections in a short burst, but if you try to think too carefully you will waste precious minutes. By allowing yourself to write anything that seems even a little related, you keep the flow of thoughts moving and avoid the "blank page" feeling.

### *Step■by■step process*

- **Read the prompt once, then underline key words.**
- *Key words* are the parts that tell you **what** you must discuss (e.g., "advantages", "causes", "compare").
- Underlining helps you see the focus instantly.
- **Set a timer for 2 minutes.**
- Use a phone, watch, or the exam clock. The timer creates a small pressure that keeps you from over■thinking.
- **Write a rapid list of ideas.**
- Use short phrases, not full sentences.
- Start each line with a dash "-".
- If an idea seems only loosely related, still write it down; you can discard it later.
- **Group similar ideas together.**
- After the timer ends, glance at the list and draw simple brackets or headings (e.g., "Economic reasons", "Social reasons").

- This grouping will become the skeleton of your mini■outline.
- **Pick the three strongest groups.**
- Choose the groups that directly answer the prompt and that you feel most confident explaining.
- Mark them with a star "*" so they stand out.

### *Example prompt and quick brainstorm*

**Prompt:** *"Discuss two main reasons why renewable energy is becoming more popular worldwide."*

**Key words:** discuss, two main reasons, renewable energy, becoming more popular, worldwide.

**2■minute brainstorm (what a student might write):**

- falling cost of solar panels
- government subsidies
- climate change awareness
- job creation in green sector
- battery technology improvements
- media coverage of climate protests
- international agreements (Paris Accord)
- public demand for clean air

Now group them:

- **Cost & Technology**
- falling cost of solar panels
- battery technology improvements
- **Policy & Public Opinion**
- government subsidies
- climate change awareness
- media coverage of climate protests
- international agreements
- **Economic Benefits**
- job creation in green sector

From the groups, the two strongest that match "two main reasons" are **Cost & Technology** and **Policy & Public Opinion**. Mark them with a star.

> **In daily life:** Think of quick brainstorming like making a grocery list before you shop. You write down everything you might need, then later you sort the list into categories (fruits, dairy, etc.) and decide what to actually buy. The initial list is messy, but it saves time when you're at the store.

### *Mind■map shortcut (if you prefer pictures)*

If you are comfortable drawing, you can turn the same process into a tiny mind map:

- Write the **prompt** in the centre of the page.
- Draw three short branches for the three main idea groups you notice.
- On each branch, add 2-3 quick sub■points (the bullet ideas).
- Highlight the two branches you will use with a thick circle.

A mind map takes the same 2-3 minutes, but it gives you a visual cue that can be easier to recall while writing.

> **Note:** The purpose of a mind map is *visual organization*, not artistic perfection. Simple lines and words are enough.

### *Why you should not edit while brainstorming*

During the 2■minute burst, avoid:

- **Checking spelling** - it slows you down and interrupts the flow.
- **Evaluating each idea** - you might discard a good point too early.
- **Writing full sentences** - this uses up time that could be spent generating more ideas.

> **Common mistake:** *Stopping to perfect one idea before moving on.* This reduces the total number of ideas you collect, leaving you with fewer options for your outline.

### *Turning the list into a mini■outline (next step)*

Once you have your starred groups, write a one■sentence *topic sentence* for each. This becomes the backbone of your essay:

- *The falling cost of solar panels and advances in battery storage make renewable energy financially attractive.*
- *Government subsidies and growing public concern about climate change drive worldwide adoption of renewables.*

These two sentences are ready to be expanded into paragraphs during the writing phase.

> **Remember:** Quick brainstorming is a *tool*, not the final answer. Its job is to give you a pool of ideas that you can select, organize, and develop quickly under exam pressure. By mastering this 2■minute habit, you turn a vague prompt into a clear plan before you even start the main writing.

## 12.3 Creating a Mini Outline

When the exam clock starts, you already have a list of ideas from your quick brainstorm.

The next step is to turn that list into a **mini outline** - a tiny roadmap that shows you exactly what you will write and in what order.

> **Definition:** *Mini outline* - a brief plan that contains only the main parts of your essay: an introduction, two or three body points, and a conclusion, together with a rough idea of how many minutes you will spend on each part.

### *1. Why a mini outline matters*

Think of the outline as a **GPS for your essay**. Without it, you may wander into irrelevant details, run out of time, or forget to finish your conclusion. With a clear route, you know when to turn left (introduce your thesis), when to go straight (develop each point), and when to stop (wrap up).

> **In daily life:** When you cook a simple pasta dish, you first check the recipe, then measure the ingredients, and finally set a timer for each step. The recipe is the outline; it keeps you from adding salt twice or forgetting to boil the water.

### *2. Building the outline step by step*

- **Write the thesis sentence** - one line that tells the reader exactly what you will argue or explain.

*Example:* "Social media improves communication among teenagers, but it also creates new pressures that affect mental health."

- **Choose 2-3 body points** - each point should support the thesis and be different from the others.

*Point 1:* "It lets teens stay in touch with friends across distances."

*Point 2:* "It provides platforms for sharing achievements, which can boost confidence."

*Point 3 (optional):* "It exposes users to constant comparison, leading to anxiety."

- **Add a short note for each point** - a single phrase that reminds you of the evidence or example you will use.

*Point 1 note:* "Example: group chat for school project."

*Point 2 note:* "Statistic: 70 % of teens report feeling proud after posting."

*Point 3 note:* "Study: higher Instagram use linked to lower self■esteem."

- **Draft a concluding sentence** - restate the thesis in new words and give a final thought.

*Example:* "Therefore, while social media connects teens, it also demands careful use to protect their wellbeing."

### *3. Allocating time*

Now attach minutes to each part. A typical 40■minute essay might look like this:

- Part - Minutes - What to do
- Introduction (thesis + hook) - 5 - Write a brief opening sentence, then the thesis.
- Body Point 1 + evidence - 8 - Expand the note into a short paragraph (3■4 sentences).
- Body Point 2 + evidence - 8 - Same process as above.
- Body Point 3 (if needed) - 6 - Write the third paragraph, or use the saved minutes for deeper examples.
- Conclusion - 5 - Restate thesis, summarize points, add a final comment.
- Quick check (spelling, punctuation) - 4 - Scan for obvious errors; underline any sentence that feels unclear.

- **Total** - **36** - Leaves a 4■minute buffer for unexpected delays.

> **Remember:** The time numbers are guides, not strict rules. Adjust them if you find a point needs more explanation or if you finish early.

#### *4. Putting the outline on paper*

During the exam, use the left margin or a separate sheet to jot the outline. Write it in **bullet form** so you can glance at it while you write. For example:

- **Intro (5 min)** - Hook, thesis
- **P1 (8 min)** - Stay in touch -> group chat example
- **P2 (8 min)** - Share achievements -> 70 % statistic
- **P3 (6 min)** - Comparison pressure -> study link
- **Conclusion (5 min)** - Restate, final thought

Having this visual list reduces the mental load of remembering what comes next.

#### *5. Common pitfalls to avoid*

> **Common mistake:** Adding too many body points.

If you try to fit four or five points, you will run out of time and each paragraph will be too short to develop. Stick to the maximum of three strong points; quality beats quantity.

#### *6. Quick practice*

Before the real exam, practice the whole cycle: read a prompt, brainstorm for 2 minutes, create a mini outline in 3 minutes, then write a short essay using the time allocations. The more you rehearse, the more automatic the process becomes, and the less you will think about "what to do next" during the actual test.

By turning a messy brainstorm into a tidy mini outline, you give yourself a clear path, keep the exam clock on your side, and increase the chances of producing a well■structured, coherent answer.

### 12.4 Time Management During Writing

When you sit down for an exam essay, the clock is your most reliable guide.

Think of the exam time as a piece of cake that you have to cut into equal slices before you start eating. If you cut the slices too small, you will run out of cake before you finish; if you cut them too large, you will waste time on one part and leave the rest unfinished. The same idea works for writing: **plan the time you will spend on each part of the answer before you begin**, then stick to that plan as closely as possible.

> **Note:** *Set a clock* - Put a watch, a phone timer, or the exam room clock in clear view. Knowing exactly how many minutes have passed helps you stay on track.

#### *1. Look at the prompt and the marks allocation*

First, read the question carefully and note how many marks each part is worth. Marks are a clue to how much time you should allocate. For example, a 20■mark essay might be divided into three sections: an introduction (2 marks), two body paragraphs (each 6 marks), and a conclusion (2 marks). The total is 20 marks, so you can decide to spend **2 minutes** on the introduction, **6 minutes** on each body paragraph, and **2 minutes** on the conclusion, leaving a few minutes for a final check.

> **Definition:** *Marks allocation* - the way the exam tells you how many points each part of the answer is worth.

#### *2. Turn the allocation into minutes*

Take the total exam time and turn the mark ratios into minutes. Suppose you have 45 minutes total. Using the 20■mark example above:

- Introduction: 2 marks -> frac220times45 = 4.5 minutes -> round to **5 minutes**
- First body paragraph: 6 marks -> frac620times45 = 13.5 minutes -> round to **14 minutes**
- Second body paragraph: same as above -> **14 minutes**
- Conclusion: 2 marks -> **5 minutes**
- Final check: the remaining **2 minutes**

Write these numbers on a small piece of paper or on the margin of your answer sheet. Seeing the numbers in front of you makes it easier to remember the limits.

#### *3. Follow the mini■outline, move on if you get stuck*

Before you write, sketch a **mini outline** that lists the main point of each paragraph and one supporting idea. The outline is your road map; you do not need to fill in full sentences yet. When the timer shows that the allocated minutes for a paragraph are almost up, stop writing, even if you feel you could add one more sentence. Move on to the next part of the outline. This prevents you from spending too much time on a single paragraph and running out of time for the rest.

> **Common mistake:** *Trying to perfect one paragraph* - many students keep editing the same paragraph because they think it must be flawless. This wastes minutes that could be used for other sections and often leads to an incomplete answer.

#### *4. Use a simple "watch■and■write" rhythm*

A practical rhythm is **5■minute blocks**: write for five minutes, then glance at the clock. If you are still within the allotted time for that block, keep going; if you have exceeded it, stop immediately. The rhythm creates a habit of checking the clock regularly without breaking your concentration.

#### *5. Reserve the last few minutes for rapid revision*

The final 2-3 minutes should be used only for **quick revision**:

- Scan each paragraph for obvious spelling or punctuation errors.
- Make sure each paragraph begins with a clear topic sentence that matches the outline.
- Verify that you have answered every part of the prompt.

Do not try to rewrite whole sentences; just make tiny corrections that improve clarity.

> **Remember:** *A complete answer with a few minor errors scores higher than a perfect paragraph that leaves other sections blank.*

#### *6. Practice the timing strategy before the exam*

The best way to trust this method is to practice it in mock exams. Set a timer, allocate minutes exactly as you would on the real day, and follow the plan. After each practice, note where you ran out of time or where you finished early. Adjust the minute distribution for the next try. Over several practice sessions you will develop an intuitive sense of how many words you can write in each time slice.

#### *7. Quick checklist for the exam day*

- **Clock visible:** place it where you can see it without moving.
- **Minutes written down:** keep a tiny note of the time you gave each section.
- **Mini outline ready:** 3■5 bullet points, one for each paragraph.
- **Timer alerts:** if your phone allows, set short alarms for each block.

By treating the exam clock as a partner rather than an enemy, you keep your writing steady, balanced, and complete. The goal is not to write the longest essay, but to write a **well■structured answer that covers every required point within the time you have**. With a clear time plan, a simple outline, and the discipline to move on when needed, you give yourself the best chance of success.

## 12.5 Rapid Revision and Proofreading

When the exam clock is almost up, you still have a few minutes left to make your essay as clean as possible. This last step is called **rapid revision and proofreading**. It means you look over what you have written quickly, spot the most common mistakes, check that every source you used is cited, and confirm that the essay is within the required word limit. Doing this carefully can turn a good answer into a great one, because examiners notice even small slips.

> **Definition:** *Proofreading* is the act of reading your own writing to find and correct errors in spelling, grammar, punctuation, and formatting.

Why is a quick check useful? Imagine you are packing a suitcase for a short trip. You might throw in most of your clothes, but before you close the bag you pause to make sure you haven't forgotten your toothbrush, your passport, or the charger you need. The same idea works for an essay: the main ideas are already in place, but a brief final sweep ensures you haven't left behind essential details that could cost you marks.

#### *Step■by■step checklist*

- **Read the last sentence first**

Start at the very end of your essay and read the final sentence aloud. This trick forces your eyes to jump to a new part of the page, helping you notice errors you might have skimmed over while writing.

- **Scan for the three most common error types**
- **Spelling** - look for words that are often misspelled (e.g., *definitely*, *separate*).
- **Grammar** - check subject■verb agreement (e.g., *The data *are* correct* vs. *The data *is* correct*).

- **Punctuation** - ensure you have a period at the end of each sentence and that commas are not missing before conjunctions like *and* or *but*.
- **Check citations**

Every time you mention a fact, statistic, or idea that is not your own, you must give a citation. Look for a short cue such as a year in parentheses (e.g., (2020)) or a footnote number. Then verify that the corresponding reference appears in your bibliography or reference list.

- **Confirm the word count**

Most exam instructions give a range, for example 500 ± 10 % words. Count the words using the exam software's built■in tool, or quickly estimate by counting the words in a typical line (about 12-15) and multiplying by the number of lines. Make sure you are inside the allowed range; if you are a few words over, delete a redundant phrase; if you are under, add a brief example.

- **Look for repeated words or ideas**

Repeating the same word or point can make your essay feel sloppy. If you see "important" used three times in one paragraph, replace two of them with synonyms like *crucial* or *significant*.

> **Note:** A *reference list* (or bibliography) is the list at the end of your essay that gives full details of every source you cited. It must match the citation style required by the exam (e.g., APA, MLA, Harvard).

### *Quick tricks for a fast read■through*

- **Use a ruler or your finger** to guide your eyes line by line. This prevents you from skipping lines when you are reading quickly.
- **Read aloud** for 30 seconds. Hearing the words forces you to notice missing articles ("a", "the") and awkward phrasing.
- **Look for capital letters** at the start of sentences. If a sentence begins with a lower■case letter, you probably missed a period before it.

### *Common pitfalls to avoid*

> **Common mistake:** *Skipping the bibliography because you think the essay itself is enough.*

Even if the essay body is perfect, missing or incorrect citations can lead to a loss of marks for academic honesty.

> **Remember:** *Time is limited, so aim for a checklist that takes no more than 3-5 minutes.*

If you try to rewrite whole paragraphs, you will run out of time. Stick to spotting and fixing small errors.

### *Example of a rapid revision in action*

Suppose you have written a 520■word essay for a 500■word limit exam. You have 4 minutes left.

- **Last sentence check** - you read it aloud and notice a missing period. Add it. (10 seconds)
- **Error scan** - you spot "definately" and change it to "definitely". (20 seconds)
- **Citation check** - you see a statistic about climate change with no citation. You add (IPCC,
- and note it in the reference list. (30 seconds)
- **Word count** - the software shows 525 words. You delete the phrase "in many different ways" from a paragraph, bringing the total to
- (30 seconds)
- **Final read■through** - you read the first two paragraphs aloud, catching a missing comma after "however". Add it. (40 seconds)

You have now used about 2 minutes, leaving a minute to double■check the reference list and submit confidently.

By following this short, systematic checklist, you turn a hurried exam essay into a polished piece that demonstrates both knowledge and attention to detail. The effort you spend on rapid revision can add valuable marks and, more importantly, shows the examiner that you respect the conventions of academic writing.

## Terminology at a glance

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Exam prompt | The question or statement that tells you the topic, task, and any limits for the essay. |
| Quick brainstorming | A short, timed activity (2-3 minutes) where you write down every idea related to the prompt without judging it. |
| Mini outline | A brief plan showing the introduction, main points, and conclusion, plus an approximate time allocation. |
| Time allocation | Dividing the total exam minutes into sections (e.g., intro, each body paragraph, conclusion) based on marks and difficulty. |

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Rapid revision | A quick final check of the essay to fix spelling, grammar, punctuation and ensure word■limit compliance. |
| Proofreading | Reading your own writing to find and correct errors in spelling, grammar, punctuation, and formatting. |
| Key words | Important words in the prompt that indicate what you must address, such as 'compare', 'evaluate', or 'discuss'. |
| Marks allocation | The distribution of marks for each part of the question, which guides how much time to spend on each part. |

## Practical application

Exercise 12.1:

Exercise 12.2:

Exercise 12.3:

Exercise 12.4:

Exercise 12.5:

Exercise 12.6:

## Checklist

- [ ] Plan an essay outline in under five minutes
- [ ] Allocate time for each essay stage during an exam
- [ ] Write a clear introduction, body, and conclusion within the time limit
- [ ] Check work quickly for common errors before submitting

> Educational note: this book is a study aid. Check important facts with your lecturer or textbook.